Pictures of You

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/51703387.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

Categories:
F/F, F/M, Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Angst with a Happy Ending, Implied/Referenced Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Homophobia, Transphobia, Suicidal Thoughts, Post-Season/Series 05 Finale, church camp au, Shadow Weaver's A+ Parenting, Implied/Referenced Sexual Assault

Language:
English

Series:
Part 41 of Miscellaneous Works

Stats:
Published: 2023-11-19 Completed: 2024-07-03 Words: 50,382 Chapters: 17/17

Pictures of You

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/51703387.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

Categories:
F/F, F/M, Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Angst with a Happy Ending, Implied/Referenced Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Homophobia, Transphobia, Suicidal Thoughts, Post-Season/Series 05 Finale, church camp au, Shadow Weaver's A+ Parenting, Implied/Referenced Sexual Assault

Language:
English

Series:
Part 41 of Miscellaneous Works

Stats:

Published: 2023-11-19 Completed: 2024-07-03 Words: 50,382
Chapters: 17/17

Pictures of You

by TheSofterGentlerMe

Summary

Pictures are worth a thousand words and more emotions than can be counted. They remind us of the past, of our accomplishments, our victories, but also our regrets and our failures. Adora, across worlds and time, is going to learn this but will the pictures be all she has left?

Bright Moon Timeline

Chapter Summary

> It's been years since the fall of Prime, and the one and only kiss Adora had with Catra before Adora lost her, and Adora has moved on the best she can. She's tried to at least but that moment still haunts her.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora rolled over in the huge bed in her room in Bright Moon. Her back twinged a little from the movement but her shoulder, which had been giving her trouble the last few days, seemed to be doing alright.

The joys of growing old, she thought. She looked over at the poof of hair sticking out of the covers next to her and grinned. The snoring was definitely not the normal snoring and Adora knew she was faking it.

"I know you're awake," Adora said as leaned over and gave Glimmer a kiss on her head, the pink and purple hair tickling her nose as she did.

"Go away," Glimmer muttered into her pillow.

“OK, but just for a moment,” Adora said as she slid out of bed. “You know it’s a big day today. Bow’s been up for an hour.”

“Why did I marry two morning people?” Glimmer said as she rolled over with a groan and flopped her arms out across the bed.

“Because you love us,” Adora said in a sing-song voice as she headed for the bathroom.

“Not before the sky is light I don’t,” Glimmer said back to her.

Adora just laughed. After she’d dressed in a nice outfit for the day, one that Glimmer had already picked out for her the night before, she went into the front room of the royal suite at Bright Moon. Bow was sitting at a table with a large hologram coming out of the top. Some elaborate mechanical part was shown in an exploded view that Bow nudged a little to get a different viewpoint on the object while he hummed happily to himself. His eyes flicked sideways to Adora before looking back to his project.

“My wife up yet?” Bow asked. Adora grinned at that because she always loved when Glimmer would introduce them all to new people. She’d introduce herself as Bow’s wife and then as Adora’s wife. If anyone asked, which didn’t happen often with Etherians, she’d explain that Bow and Adora were just good friends who happened to have the same wife.

“Phffft, no,” Adora said as she sat down on a sofa. “I mean, she’s awake and staring at the ceiling but she’s not up.”

“As long as she’s ready for the Fall opening celebration,” Bow said as he made a tweak to the mechanical part, made a notation, and then shut down the program. He turned to Adora with a thoughtful look on his face. “Can you believe it’s been thirty years since you defeated Prime?”

Adora frowned as she said, “Yeah, seems like yesterday sometimes.”

“Thinking of her, aren’t you?” Bow said.

Adora wanted to lie to her friend but she just nodded. Bow got up and came over to give Adora a hug and she returned it.

“You don’t have to go today,” Bow said.

Adora stepped back from the hug as she said, “Yes, I do. I’m She-Ra, it’s expected.”

“I can’t believe you still have that hang up after all these years,” Bow said with a smile. “You can do what you need for yourself.”

“I know,” Adora said as she walked over to a little bar. There was a slot on the back that the castle staff would slide snacks in and out of and Adora picked a cinnamon roll off the small tray. She picked at it for a moment before she went on. “I just feel I should go. It’s such a huge moment and I was a part of it and people expect it and yes, I know I can do what I need but it’s the least I can do.”

“Promise me you’ll take some time off for a few days after this,” Bow said.

Adora rolled her eyes as she said, “I can’t do that. After this I have the symposium on cartography.”

“That you’re attending, not presenting at,” Bow said as he leaned against the bar.

Adora gave him a look before she said, “Then I have the surveying job to get ready for out in Dryl.”

“That your crew is more than capable of handling without you for a day,” Bow said.

“You’re not going to let this go, are you?” Adora said with a tired smile.

“Nope,” Bow said. “Every year you sink into depression because of what happened to Catra and every year you try to ignore it. I want you to take some time and just work through it. Is that so much to ask? To take care of yourself? I believe a certain someone said you’re worth more than what you offer others.”

Adora sighed as she said, “That’s not fair.”

“She wasn’t wrong,” Bow said.

“OK, no, she wasn’t wrong but I still don’t know if that was actually Mara, a computer program of Mara, or my own subconscious,” Adora said.

“Doesn’t matter!” Bow said. “It’s still good advice!”

“What’s good advice?” Glimmer mumbled as she came out of the bedroom and shuffled her way to the snack tray.

“Adora is going to take a few days off after today to take care of herself,” Bow said.

“I didn’t agree to it,” Adora said.

“Yet you’re still going to do it,” Bow replied with a smile.

“Bow’s got that tone,” Glimmer said as she gave him a kiss. “I think you’re out of luck.”

“Fine! I’ll take care of myself!” Adora said, throwing one hand in the air and then flinching as her shoulder answered with a stab of pain.

“Yeah, you might want to finally see the healer about that as well,” Bow said.

“It’ll fix itself eventually,” Adora said. “It always has in the past.”

“I’m not going to dignify that with a response,” Glimmer said with a sigh.

“Yet you did respond,” Bow said.

“No, too early for word games,” Glimmer said as she came around the bar to give Adora a kiss before heading back to the rooms “I’m going to go get dressed, you two actually be ready on time for once.”

“Can you believe the nerve?” Adora said to Bow.

“I know, you’d think she’s the queen or something,” Bow said as Glimmer made a flapping mouth gesture with her hand at them before disappearing back through the bedroom door.

Despite their talk, the three were early to the throne room. The planning staff whisked them into a little side room. Perfuma and Scorpia were both there as Perfuma checked the last touches for the flower displays. When the other three came in, Perfuma, leaning on a cane, began to walk over with Scorpia. There were hugs around as Bow asked how their children were doing.

“Chelicera is doing great,” Scorpia said. “They send their love but they weren’t able to make it back to Ethiera in time. Rose had a bit of a hard time over the last few months, I think you knew that, but he’s coming through it strong.”

“Prickly Pear is doing fantastic,” Perfuma said. “She’s going to be with the flag dancing troupe this afternoon. She’s off getting ready for that.”

“Has anyone heard from Entrapta and Hordak?” Bow asked.

“Not since that transmission a month ago,” Scorpia said. “Her chamberlain is here though.”

“Oh, I like her,” Bow said with a smile. “Although she’s always so serious.”

“Well, Izzy is young,” Perfuma said, “and it’s a big position she’s in.”

“She’s older than I was when I took the throne,” Glimmer said.

“And isn’t that a weird thing to say,” Adora said. “I mean, I have to remind myself she’s not an actual kid occasionally.”

“I know, right?” Scorpia replied. “You haven’t told us how your kids are doing though!”

“Well, Capella is being the pain she always is,” Glimmer said with a grin. “She threw a pie in a mayor’s face last week in a protest. She said she’ll try to be here today.”

“Nock is with my brothers and dads today,” Bow said. “They’re having that celebration at the Library and he wanted to be there with them. He honestly spends more time there than he does at home these days and I think he’s basically thinking of it as his home now but just hasn’t got up the nerve to tell us he’s moving. It makes sense though, he loves the scholar's life after all.”

Adora had the feeling she sometimes got when kids came up. Capella and Nock were Glimmer and Bow’s biological children. Adora had been there at their birth, they called Adora mom, just like they did Glimmer, and she knew they loved her just like she

loved them but sometimes, it just didn’t seem real. She’d never thought of herself as a mother and even having been one for the kids growing up, she still didn’t think of herself as one, not really. When she really got to thinking about it it made her wonder what would have happened if Catra had lived past that first and only kiss. Would they have had a kid? Many kids? She wasn’t sure they would have because she’d always worried about being a good parent and she kind of thought that Catra would have had the same concern.

Adora had freaked out a little when Glimmer had first become pregnant, and told both her and Bow that she'd screw up, she just knew she would. It’d taken some time to assure her that she’d be fine, that it wouldn’t be a problem and while she had to admit both the kids had grown up well, it was still a fear. That and she knew she’d been the soft touch of the three parents, a fact that Capella had taken gleeful advantage of, especially in her early teen years. Even Nock, a quiet and studious boy, had known Adora was the easy mark when it came to something that his other parents would probably refuse. Even that feature had made her think that maybe Catra would have been the more firm parent, like Glimmer had been.

As the other four talked, Adora made noncommittal noise to indicate she was paying attention to the conversation, though she really wasn’t, when the master of ceremonies for the day came into the room. She was a member of the Bright Moon guard named Mimosa who was dressed in a stunningly formal suit that set off her fluff of bright pink hair. Adora questioned her own choice in suits because it didn’t just feel like her. Though she knew it looked fine, having been custom made by the Bright Moon tailor, she’d have preferred something else. She’d mentioned that to Glimmer who’d just given her a look and said, “You can’t wear your old Horde jacket to this.”

It wasn’t what Adora had meant, although she kind of had, and she’d quietly went to the tailor and even that had made her think of Catra, wondering what she’d have said in that situation.

“We’re about ready to begin,” Mimosa said. “Your Majesty, if you would take your place, I think we can get started.”

Scorpia and Perfuma said farewell and went to take their place in the audience. Adora stood to Glimmer’s left while Bow stood to her right. Glimmer had grumbled about that before, the two of them towering over her, but that had been years in the past. Now Glimmer had settled in nicely to her role as queen and she walked forward at the announcement from outside the door of, “Her Majesty, Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon, and her royal consorts, Adora, She-Ra, Princess of Power, and Bow of Bright Moon.”

Adora didn’t like that part of the announcement. She’d tried to get it changed so Bow would be first but it had been explained that etiquette put her first since she had the title of princess. Adora had asked years before why Bow hadn’t let himself be crowned king, like Glimmer’s father had, but Bow had shook his head and said it wasn’t something he’d felt comfortable with and, as he’d put it, “I kind of like the title consort. It feels fun.”

As Adora walked forward beside Glimmer though, fun was the last thing on her mind. Every year, Etheria had a holiday to celebrate the Fall of Prime and the end of the war. In the evening were parties and fireworks, feasting, and laughter and dancing to top it all off. The morning though, that was for remembering. Bright Moon’s throne room was full of people in the rainbow colors of

Etherian dress and each and every one of them wore a somber expression like a black flower in a field full of wildflowers. The floating throne, that Glimmer had never sat in, had a small crown sitting on it along with the black sash that hung on it every other day of the year in memory of Angella. Micah sat in a wheelchair at the small throne on the floor that Glimmer used for day to day business, dressed in a white suit, as they walked down the aisle. Adora saw some of the princesses in the crowd but mostly just focused on the throne they were walking towards. Everything leading up this moment was the priming of the pump for Adora. The next part was the part that invariably set off the flood of emotions she had every year.

Once they were all around the throne, Bow standing behind Micah with one hand on his shoulder, Adora on the other side of the throne, and Glimmer in front of it, the room went from quiet murmurs to absolute silence.

"Today we remember our liberation," Glimmer said. "We remember the glory of being free and open. Later today, we'll feast and dance and celebrate but for now, we remember those who were lost."

A Mystacor sorcerer began to project an illusion over the crowd, visible from all over as if one was standing in front of it. It showed the faces of those lost during the occupation by Prime but it always started with one particular face. Adora knew it was coming but she steeled herself not to react as Catra's face floated above the crowd. It was a picture taken on the way back to Etheria after they'd freed her and Glimmer from Prime's ship and it was the one Adora thought of when she thought of Catra. She was sitting looking out the window at the stars, a soft smile on her face.

Adora had begun to notice, over the last few years, just how young Catra looked in the image.

Adora managed to keep it together through the images, that lasted for a couple of hours, and when it finally came to an end, took a deep breath like everyone else in the room and then began to mingle, doing her best to interact with people even though all she wanted to do was curl up in a corner and think of those last moments with Catra under the Heart of Etheria.

"You've got that look," Glimmer said as she came up beside her.

"What look?" Adora replied.

Glimmer gently laid a hand on Adora's arm as some minor town leader came up to speak to them for a moment. After the leader had gone on, Glimmer said, "That look that you're trying to hold it together."

"Is it that bad?" Adora said.

"No," Glimmer said with a sad smile. "I've just been seeing it for decades now. Want me to take you back to the rooms?"

Adora shook her head and then stopped. She remembered what she'd talked with Bow about earlier and changed the shake to a nod.

“But can it be discreetly please?” Adora asked.

“Of course,” Glimmer said. “I’m always discrete.”

That brought a little snorting laughter out of Adora, and a gentle elbow nudge from Glimmer, before the two stepped out of sight long enough for Glimmer to teleport Adora back to the room.

“Make my apologies for me,” Adora said. “And tell Bow to do the same too please.”

“I won’t,” Glimmer replied. “And get that look off your face. No one is going to be asking anything that requires an apology and they certainly wouldn’t get it if they did.”

Adora started to argue but she just sighed instead and sat down on the couch.

“OK, thanks,” Adora said.

Glimmer hugged her tight and gave her a kiss on the forehead as she said, “We’ll be back soon. Try to take a nap maybe.”

“OK, love you,” Adora said.

“Love you as well,” Glimmer replied.

Adora leaned back after Glimmer disappeared and stared at the ceiling. She decided to do what Glimmer had suggested and tried to fall asleep. It didn’t really work. She kept hearing little ticking noises from the little housekeeping bots that kept out of sight and the hum of electricity in the silent room. After a little while though she was pretty sure she’d begun to drift off when she heard, clear as a bell, Catra’s voice.

“Adora, where am I?”

Adora sat up on the couch with a gasp, looking around as her hands shook. As she began to think it had to be a dream, she heard someone moving behind her.

Chapter End Notes

> I was driving into work one morning when Pictures of You by The Cure came on. If you haven’t heard that before, this is the opening verse.
>
> “I've been looking so long at these pictures of you / That I almost believe that they're real / I've been living so long with my pictures of you / That I almost believe that the pictures are all I can feel”
>
> That made me go, “Oh, post-season five Adora without Catra but the canon divergence was like, right after the kiss. I can do something with that.”

Then I got to thinking of my other stories and how I could change them and I just knew I had to write this one. This may be above my skill level to pull off but damn if I'm not going to give it a try. I'm also pretty sure if I had thought of this back when the fandom was still going strong in 2020, I never would have written it because I'm pretty sure I would have got some negativity for not having Adora be with Catra (especially with the second storyline that starts with Chapter Two).

With that in mind, I'm going to say this, this fic? I'm looking forward to it. I know it's going to be sad, although I will say I still hold to my happy ending rule (even if it's not the happy ending you expect) with it. I'm excited for this one. Update schedule for the moment is probably going to be once a week (or so).

For those who've read my other stuff, yes, I reused some of my OC's although they're not going to be the exact same. Example, Izzy is in this one but she's not going to be quite the same person. Mimosa briefly shows up in one of my fics as a mercenary but she's a Bright Moon guard in this one. So if you've never read my other stuff, don't worry, it'll make sense and you don't have to read the other stories (though you're more than welcome to).

In closing, I write for myself but I post for everyone and I really hope this is something you enjoy.

Camp Bright Moon Timeline

Chapter Summary

> One kiss on a dock at Camp Bright Moon, one moment stolen in time, and things changed. For a moment. Then Adora made one decision different afterwards and her whole life went another direction.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora stood in the kitchen, finishing up the morning dishes. She nervously shifted her feet as she put the last one in the dishwasher and closed it up, thinking of her mother's upcoming visit. It was still two days in the future, when she was set to come for dinner, but Adora was already fighting off a mild panic attack over it. It'd been years since Adora had felt she'd done anything to garner Sharon Weaver's approval, no matter how hard she'd tried. The last time had been when Adora had run away from her summer camp when she was eighteen. Sharon had shown up the next day where she'd been staying, demanded that Adora come with her, and Adora had caved. Sharon had worn a rare smile all the way home that day.

"Hey, honey," a voice called from the living room. "That thing with your mom isn't tonight is it? I ask because I just found out I'm needed at the office late."

Adora wiped her hands on a towel as she walked to the entry between the living room and the kitchen. Standing on the other

side of it, by the front door, was her husband, Daniel. Adora had met him in her last year of college.

"No, that's on Thursday," Adora said.

Daniel smiled at her as he said, "That's right. I knew it was a day that started with a T."

Adora smiled back at him and felt like she was wearing a mask.

"That's right," Adora said. "I'm going to go shopping today for that. Is there anything you want?"

"What are you making?" Daniel said.

"Probably just do roast again," Adora said. "Mom likes that."

"Can you do those ranch potatoes you did a while back?" Daniel said.

Adora felt her anxiety jump up another level. Her mother didn't like surprises when it came to dinner, even though the potatoes weren't outlandish. Adora had lied as well. She knew she was doing roast because Sharon had requested roast and Adora knew, from long experience, that meant roast beef, the vegetables that

it was cooked with, a green salad, a gravy made from the drippings, and dinner rolls. Mashed potatoes weren't included, ever, especially ones seasoned a different way.

"I'll check into it," Adora said. Daniel, who'd lived with her for almost five years at that point, knew the look and nodded.

"Alright. Have a good day," Daniel said before heading out the door.

After he'd left, Adora went around the house, making sure everything was in place and moved the laundry from the two hampers, one in the bedroom and one in the bathroom, into the washer. After the wash was started she went to her bedroom. She shut and locked the door, her hand shaking a little as she did.

In the room, she did what she did every morning after Daniel left. She went to her desk in their bedroom and sat down. Her Bible sat on the corner of the desk under her computer monitor and she took a moment to read a verse from it as she started her morning study. She used to follow published devotional study guides but had long since abandoned those. Now she followed a study she didn't talk about with anyone and to be sure it didn't come up, she locked most of what she studied up every day in a desk drawer. After the verse and a short prayer, she opened the locked drawer and pulled her most recent notebook out, along with a philosophy textbook she'd bought with cash a couple of months before. Sitting beneath it was a textbook on world religions that Adora had only skimmed through.

Adora didn’t know why she went to such extremes to hide what she was doing. It wasn’t as if Daniel was controlling or abusive. He’d been very religious when Adora had met him, the same as she had, but she was pretty sure, while the questions might be a little awkward, that he wouldn’t do anything bad. He’d probably even understand but it didn’t matter. Everything in her told her to keep it secret and so she kept it secret.

As she read the philosophy textbook, trying her best to keep any judgment out of what she was reading as she did, she made notes while occasionally highlighting something. After forty minutes of that, she put the notebook and book away, locked the drawer again, and picked up her Bible. She read that for about ten minutes and then spent a few minutes in prayer before leaving the bedroom with thoughts racing in her head.

Since it was Tuesday morning, that meant Adora was going to be volunteering at a local food bank, the same she did every Tuesday, working in a cluttered back room of an old building filling sacks for people. There were guidelines of what should go out to each client, such as so much protein, so much carbs and dairy, so much fresh fruits and vegetables, but she had to be creative to make sure each order met those guidelines from the limited supplies on the shelves and it was a rare moment she got everything. Add to that any special dietary restrictions and it was taxing, although she admitted she liked the challenge of it. Her favorite part of the process though was putting in the few little treats the food bank had into the bags, hoping whoever was using them would be happy with something that wasn’t strictly survival.

Today was the same as always. As Adora worked, an old television sat in the corner playing daytime soap operas that were ignored by most of the staff except for one older woman, named Imelda,

who watched them constantly as she filled bags. Adora liked Imelda but trying to talk to her while the shows were on was pointless. Adora heard her give a little sigh and looked up to see the credits running.

"You alright, Imelda?" Adora asked.

Imelda looked over to Adora as she gave a smile that made the wrinkles on her face light up as she said, "Oh, I'm fine. Jessica is just getting away with her usual."

Adora knew enough to know that Jessica was one of the main villains on the show Imelda had just been watching.

"At least you only have to wait until tomorrow to find out what happens," Adora said.

"That's true," Imelda said as her eyes drifted back to the television as the news came on. They were both quiet for a minute while the news reported on a murder and a fire before cutting to a reporter standing in front of the state capitol. Behind the reporter Adora could see a crowd of a few hundred people in front of the state capitol steps with signs. The sound of their chanting carried through the speaker, although Adora couldn't make it out. The chyron below the reporter said, "Protest Against SB1523 Passage."

For some reason, the senate bill number seemed familiar to Adora but she couldn't place her finger on why. Imelda shook her head as she said, "Not the way they should handle that."

Adora was about to ask what she meant but the reporter was already speaking and Adora turned to that instead to catch the tail end of a sentence.

"... protesting the passage of SB1523 through the House, where it will now go to the governor for signature. If it is signed, it will require Child Protective Services to conduct an immediate investigation of any family that may have transgender children to be certain there is no abuse taking place," the reporter said.

Adora had a memory surface of meeting a young man named Bow in a dark forest years before and finding out he was trans. She'd been trying to find a horse and he'd volunteered to help. She shoved that memory down, as she did any other memory from that summer, and shook her head.

Imelda was saying something about the protesters again when Adora's eyes went wide. The camera had cut from the news reporter and was making its way along the front of the protestors while the reporter talked over the image. That's when Adora saw her, Catra. Her face was screwed up in anger as she threw a fist in the air and shouted something. The reporter was talking about potential legal action being threatened and all Adora could see was Catra, standing next to that young man, Bow, who was shouting something himself. It was only a couple of seconds before the camera cut back to the reporter standing next to a short woman in an impeccable suit with dark pink hair.

“I’m here with attorney Glimmer Selene who is representing the Rubicon Foundation, one of the sponsors of today’s protests,” the reporter said. “Ms. Selene, what are your plans if this becomes law?”

Adora looked into the face of the woman she’d met the same night she’d met Bow, who’d hated Adora at first sight but who’d offered her and Catra a place to stay at her parent’s summer camp, Camp Bright Moon, shortly afterwards. Adora hadn’t seen since that day she’d left with her mother from that same camp.

“We’ll seek immediate injunctions on both state and federal constitutional grounds,” Glimmer said. “However, that’s not the only defense we plan as we’ll also address the procedural grounds on which the bill passed. While I assume Governor Plim has better things to do than pass a bill that interferes with the lives of his constituents on such pointless grounds, if he doesn’t veto the bill, we’ll see the state in court.”

The image went back to a pan of the crowd and Adora once again caught a glimpse of Catra, right up front against a barricade at the bottom of the steps of the state capitol with her face inches from a state trooper while Bow had a restraining hand on her shoulder, before it jumped again back to the reporter. The reporter’s comments might as well have been gibberish to Adora.

“You OK, hon? You look like you’ve seen a ghost,” Imelda said.

Adora shook herself a little as she plastered on a fake smile, one she was well practiced in, as she said, “Yes, I’m alright. I think I might need a bite to eat though, I’m feeling a little shaky.”

“Well, go on and grab something, I’ll let Tammy know you had to leave a little early,” Imelda replied.

Adora, who’d normally never leave something early, especially one of her volunteer jobs, nodded as she went to gather up her purse.

“OK, I appreciate it,” she said. “I’ll see you Friday.”

“I’ve got my procedure that day,” Imelda replied. “Probably be next Tuesday if the doctor says I can get out.”

Adora was already halfway out the door as she said, “OK, next Tuesday, bye!”

Adora hurried to her car in the parking lot. When she got in, she didn’t pull down the sunblind sitting on her dashboard as she leaned her head against the steering wheel. She was shaking as the image of Catra, fist in the air, face full of anger, seemed to be seared in her mind. She’d done her best to block her out of her mind. She’d spent one night with Catra, curled up with her in a small travel trailer in the backyard of Glimmer’s family home, and remembered every kiss. Each one seemed to be screaming out of her mind at the moment as Adora tried to use the technique the

church counselor had taught her to deal with her unnatural feelings.

Adora cried as she did but it was tears she was used to, tears that weren't looking for comfort because she knew she didn't deserve any for what she'd done. It wasn't loud, it was mostly just shoulders shaking and tears streaking down her face as she fought to stop them. Adora had brought it up with her church counselor just once. The counselor had told her, "The Holy Spirit is searing your soul for your sins. You should feel blessed, it's helping you become closer to the Lord."

Adora didn't feel blessed, she felt cursed. She'd tried to love Daniel. She'd tried to be a model wife, model daughter, model Christian, and all she felt like most of the time was a model, plastic and fake.

After a few minutes, she'd fought the tears down, composed herself, and drove straight back to her house. While she went, she tried to think of the things she had to do for her mother's upcoming visit. What would have caused her major anxiety that morning was almost soothing now as she fought to keep her mind off of Catra. She pulled her car into the garage and went inside, moving the laundry from the wash to the dryer almost on autopilot, before she went into the kitchen to get the wood wax, intent on making sure the dining table was glossy and clean. She realized she didn't have a good rag for the task and headed for the linen closet where she had a small rag bag.

On the way, she passed her bedroom and saw her desk. Her computer seemed to pull at her as she went past and she stopped for a moment before going over to it. She knew what she was

doing but she didn't admit it, even to herself, as she pulled up Facebook. She looked at her feed, full of people she knew from church, and tapped her thumb lightly against the space bar before finally typing into the search bar, "Catra Manzana."

Chapter End Notes

If there were ever something I wrote that was going to get me actual hatemail, I figured it's going to be this chapter. Why is Adora in a straight relationship? Because I'm telling a story here that requires it but also, because I have known many women who, after years of being in a marriage with a man, have come to fully realize they were a lesbian. They're just as much a valid part of the queer community as anyone else and deserve to have stories about them as well. Some of those women are friends and needless to say, if you say gold-star lesbian in my presence, I will not be polite with my response.

I also wanted to touch base on Adora locking herself in her room to do her studying, as well as hiding her study materials. I did this for a long time with things I was interested in, hiding them, after I moved out on my own and I had a decent relationship with my parents. However, they were still evangelical Christians and I did get in trouble for some of the stuff I read as a kid so I got really adept at hiding what I was doing and that carried over as an adult. With Adora, I think that impulse is through the roof.

Finally, ranch potatoes are a thing. My wife makes them and when I told her they got a mention in this fic, she wrote out the recipe for me to share and said to mention she does this by the ish. A ½ cup-ish of milk, a tablespoon-ish of this and that, and that kind of thing. I gotta say, I really enjoy these, although I prefer to add some cheese myself.

5 lbs potatoes
1 stick unsalted butter
1 block cream cheese

1/2 (ish) cup milk
1-2 ranch packets
Garlic, salt, and pepper to taste

Peel potatoes and cut into 1/2 inch discs.
Bring to a boil until firm tender.
Drain and put back in hot pot.
Add stick of butter, milk, cream cheese, and 1 ranch packet to potatoes.
Mash until smooth and add more ranch packet(s), garlic, salt, and pepper to taste.
Last, but certainly not least, chow down and enjoy!

When the Musics Over Timeline

Chapter Summary

> When the musics over, turn off the lights. However, Adora can't stop thinking about Catra, disappeared from her life after a fight years before, and a photo and a story stirs up emotions she has tried to keep down for years now.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora remembered the last thing she ever said to Catra.

"You love me?"

It was said in a sad, disbelieving voice right before Adora had walked out the door of their house after a huge fight. They'd been married for several years at that point, together as a couple even longer, but if Adora was honest with herself, they'd been on a downhill slide for a while. That had been ten years ago, when she'd left to get some clarity, to talk with Glimmer and Bow, and when she'd come back to the house a few days later, she'd found some of Catra's things packed and Catra was nowhere to be found.

They'd called, they'd searched, but they hadn't found her. Adora had moved into Bright Moon castle again for a while but eventually, the memories got to be too much and she'd moved to Mystacor. She lived with Castaspella and Juliet for a while, hoping

their low-key relationship would be alright to deal with, but found even that was a bit much. She spent a lot of time in her room. She spent a lot of time trying to figure out what she'd done wrong but mostly, she spent a lot of time crying. That was in private.

In public, she was still Adora, She-Ra, Princess of Power, and went about as if nothing had happened. She waved to crowds, went to celebrations, and did her best to not ever show anyone that she needed anything.

"You're worth more than what you can offer to other people," Mara had told her but Adora had only believed that for the metaphorical fifteen minutes. People had asked her for help and she'd given it, over and over, and after Catra had left, Adora had dove into that, giving everything she had so she wasn't sitting in her room and crying. Even when She-Ra wouldn't respond sometimes, she'd still force herself to do what she could. She felt like a shell picked up off a beach, the outside bright and peppy, while the inside held nothing but rancid tears and sand.

Now she waited in the thick semi-tropical forest in the south of Plumeria, waiting for a delegation from Half Moon to come to them. Even if she wasn't about to meet with a group of Magicats, she'd still be thinking of Catra because it was one of the last big adventures they'd had together, finding the legendary civilization of Half Moon in a cavern deep beneath the ground where they'd been hiding out for centuries.

"You alright?" Glimmer asked Adora for the second time in the last four minutes.

“I’m fine,” Adora said with a smile. “Really. You don’t have to keep asking.”

“You just look…,” Glimmer started to say before trailing off.

“It’s going to be alright,” Adora said. “You don’t have to keep asking.”

Glimmer nodded as the Bright Moon guards shuffled their feet a little around them as they tried to fight off boredom. It was a yearly tradition to meet with the queen of Half Moon but, in what Adora assumed was a show of control, the day was set but the time of the meeting was not. Glimmer was supposed to be at the meeting spot, a stone pavilion in the woods, first thing in the morning but Queen U’Rtria didn’t show up herself until some undisclosed time later. The latest had been when the Bright Moon contingent had been sitting down for a late lunch but that had only happened once. Usually it was by mid-morning though and today wasn’t going to be the exception.

“They left the tunnel,” one of the guards said, looking up from a small data pad.

“I don’t know why we can’t just meet in the little village by the tunnel,” Adora said, the same as she did every time they met. The village had been started when Half Moon had been discovered again and Adora loved it. Small houses tucked in and around the large trees with some farming taking place around them and the walkways and roads being made out of flagstones. They weren’t even forbidden from going into the village, not normally, but on

this day U'Rtria preferred they stay out, as a show they weren't subject to anyone. Adora knew all of this but she still would have preferred to meet in a friendly little village instead of out in the woods under the looming stones of the pavilion.

"We're not going over this again," Glimmer said with a smile. "Besides, sounds like they'll be here soon."

Adora knew when the contingent was close because the ten guards they had with them went from leaning against the walls and looking around to straightening up and forming up around Glimmer and Adora. Sure enough, a few minutes later, the first of Queen U'Rtria's bodyguards came out of the woods along the path. They made Adora think of how Catra had moved at her best, slow and sleek, eyes moving around to take in everything with a self-assured calm. The bodyguards were dressed in their normal attire, mottled brown, gray, and black clothing, each with several weapons on them that showed the signs of plenty of use.

Then two of them walked straight through the stone pillars of the pavilion.

Adora would never get used to that. She'd seen the same guards leaping through stone walls when they'd found Half Moon and been shocked even then. She knew it was magic, she knew when She-Ra cooperated she was capable of doing things way more impressive, but that simple walking through stone trick still caught her every time.

Once the bodyguards were confident everything was alright, one of them made a gesture back towards the trees and the queen and her attendants came walking out. This part Adora enjoyed. They all wore flowing clothes that were a riot of patterns and colors as well as jewelry made from a multitude of stone, metal, and gems. The previous year, after the formalities had been observed, they'd all sat down to talk and eat and Adora had been gifted a silver chain intricately detailed with a single gem, shaped like a teardrop, that reminded Adora of mercury captured in a crystal form. She wore it now as Glimmer stepped forward.

"Your Majesty, good as always to see you," Glimmer said.

"And the same to you, Your Majesty," U'Rtria responded back. "I hope you didn't wait long."

Glimmer grinned at U'Rtria as she said, "It always seems like a long wait when we're waiting on you, simply from the anticipation of your presence."

U'Rtria grinned back as she said, "I don't believe the king would appreciate you flirting."

"Who says I'm flirting?" Glimmer said. "Besides, I always anticipate these little meetings."

U'Rtria nodded as one of her people brought a chair up for her to sit on, said something to the queen in the Magicat language

before bowing and backing away. Bright Moon guard stepped up and unfolded a chair for Glimmer at about the same time. They both sat down as Adora backed away, her part in the whole thing done. She-Ra had figured in the Magicat's history somehow and so they expected Adora to be there but she rarely had to say anything in the meetings themselves. She wandered out of the pavilion, most of the guards following her as well. She noticed that the bodyguards were doing the same.

She settled down back in the trees where Bright Moon had set up some chairs and tables with refreshments, trying to keep down the voice that said she was nothing more than a figurehead for this whole thing. At least the first time they'd done this, Catra had been by her side and that had caused the Half Moon contingent to perk up in interest. Catra had been interested as well, part of the reason they'd gone looking for Half Moon was because Catra had been interested in her roots, but it had never gone anywhere. Catra may have been a Magicat but she wasn't from Half Moon and they'd never really accepted her.

Adora wondered now if that had just been one more thing in Catra's life that left her feeling kicked down. Catra had been a huge drinker and now Adora wondered if maybe that rejection from them had driven that drinking higher. That, coupled with other problems Adora didn't like to think about, had been part of that last big fight that had sent Adora out the door in the first place.

"There you are," Bow said as Adora looked down at the grass. Adora looked up in surprise as he sat down next to her.

"I thought you were busy today," Adora said.

“I thought I was too but I got pretty much everything taken care of so I caught a skiff with some of the guards who were coming out for the evening watch,” Bow said as he sat a backpack down on the table beside him. “Glimmer still meeting with Tria?”

Adora grinned to hear Bow use the nickname that only he was able to get away with for Queen U’Tria. To absolutely no one’s surprise, she found Bow endearing and charming where she found pretty much anyone else who wasn’t from Half Moon tolerable at best.

“Yes, she’s still up there. U’Tria didn’t get here until about thirty minutes ago,” Adora replied as Bow rummaged around in his bag to grab his data pad.

“Sounds about right,” Bow said as he held the data pad up and Adora heard it take a photo.

“Did you have to do that?” Adora said.

“Yeah,” Bow said. “I’ve got one from every time we’ve done this.”

“You do not,” Adora said.

“I do,” Bow said as he handed his data pad to her. “See? I’ve got them organized in an album.”

Adora took the data pad as she saw thumbnail pictures of herself. She went to move the images to see the older ones and Bow suddenly reached for the data pad. Adora froze as she saw an image of Catra draped over Adora’s shoulders, big smiles on both of their faces, as they stood under the stone pavilion surrounded by strings of colored lights.

“That was the first one of these,” Adora said softly as she moved to keep Bow from grabbing the data pad as she opened the photo.

“Adora, don’t,” Bow said, his voice low.

“It’s alright,” Adora said as she looked at the photo of her younger self. It wasn’t the same face she saw in the mirror anymore but in contrast, Catra’s face seemed the same. Adora knew it was because she hadn’t seen Catra since not too long after that photo had been taken but it was still the face that came up at the oddest times to make her cry. “I still miss her but… it’s not so bad.”

Bow looked at Adora before looking down at Adora’s covered wrists.

“You sure?”

Adora saw what he was looking at before smiling at him.

"It might hurt but it doesn't hurt like that anymore," Adora said, rubbing at her wrists and feeling the scar tissue under her sleeve. She looked back down at the photo and her smile became crooked. "We look so happy."

"You were happy," Bow said as he scooted up beside Adora and hugged her. "It wasn't all bad."

"I know it wasn't," Adora said as she touched Catra's image for a moment. "That night was really good in fact."

She went quiet and Bow hugged her again as he said, "Tell me about it?"

Adora set her hand on Bow's hand resting on her shoulder as she said, "Like you need to hear it from me. You were there too."

"But I want to hear it from your point of view," Bow replied.

Adora looked up from the data pad and into the trees as if she could almost see it again as she said, "I don't know if there's much story there. I remember the dancing the most I think. We always loved to dance together and that night I think we never

got off the dance floor. Fast, slow, in-between, it didn't matter, we were going to dance it. She was so excited about actually finding Half Moon." Adora stopped as she looked back down at the data pad. "I've never told anyone this and she'd kill me if she knew I said anything but she thought she was going to find her family. Day after this is when they basically snubbed her but for that brief moment, she was thrilled."

Adora looked down at the data pad before putting it to sleep and handing it back to Bow.

"I'm sorry," Bow said.

"You didn't leave," Adora said.

"You know what I mean," Bow said as he put his data pad on the table.

Nothing was said for a little while until Bow spoke up.

"You know Glimmer still tried to find her after you told her to stop?"

"I kind of suspected it but I didn't want to know so I didn't ask."

Bow looked away, his face deep in thought for a second, before he looked back at Adora.

"It's my turn to say something someone would be mad at me for I guess," Bow said. "Glimmer found where Catra had been only a few days before."

Adora thought for a moment that Bow had said that Glimmer had found Catra and her heart stopped for a split second until she'd figured out what had been said.

"Where was it?" Adora said.

"Way up in the Northern Reach," Bow said. "Some tiny little town. The grocery clerk remembered her, said they were worried about her and ID'd a photo Glimmer had. When she went to the house, it had just been vacated. No one knew where she'd gone."

Adora felt like crying but a sudden wave of anger overrode that.

"The Northern Reach," Adora spat out. "She hated the cold but I guess not as much as she hated me."

"Adora, don't do this to yourself," Bow said.

“No, it’s fine,” Adora said as she stood up. “I get why you didn’t tell me. I mean, talk about a slap in the face. I wanted to move to Moraine so badly, at least for a few years. It would have kept us a bit more out of the limelight but no, she couldn't do it, it was too cold, it was too dark, but damn, I guess it was just fine if I wasn’t along.”

Bow stood up as well as he said, “I’m sorry, I shouldn’t have said anything. It probably had nothing to do with you, it was just a place that was way away from everything.”

“So is Half Moon, so are the outer reaches of Dryl, damn, so is *space,* but nope, she went there,” Adora said as she began walking back through the woods, away from the pavilion.

Bow kept pace with her as he said, “Now come on, talk with me here. I didn’t mean to set you off.”

“It’s not you, Bow,” Adora said as she found the spot where some skiffs were landed. She climbed up on one and was happy to find the keys hanging out of the ignition. It hummed into life as she turned them and then she noticed Bow had climbed up on board with her. “What are you doing?”

“I could ask you the same,” Bow said.

“I want to go somewhere,” Adora replied. “Alone.”

“I’m going with you,” Bow said.

“No,” Adora said. “Get off the skiff, Bow.”

“I’m not letting you run off by yourself,” Bow said. “Besides, what if you’re needed here?”

“They don’t need me,” Adora said. “Besides, what if they need you?”

“I wasn’t even supposed to be here,” Bow said. “I’m not getting off this thing.”

Adora looked at Bow, his face stubborn, before letting out a sigh and turning the skiff off and getting down. Adora was irritated to see Bow had seen through what she planned when he took the keys from the skiff.

“Come on,” Bow said. “Get that look off your face. I’m worried about you.”

“It’s fine,” Adora said but didn’t say anything else as they walked back to the chairs. Two hours went past and they all gathered together again under the pavilion for the party that always followed the summit between the two queens. This time, Bow

didn’t see Adora slip out, go to the skiffs, fire up another one, and fly away.

Chapter End Notes

> Can I make my series When the Musics Over sadder? Yep! I’ll say that this is the third and final story line to be introduced. The next chapter we’ll head back into one of the other story lines and see where that is going. This is part of what I said when I said this might be above my skill level. I’m not so sure I can juggle three disparate story lines at the same time and give them equal credit. Thank you as always for reading!

Bright Moon Timeline

Chapter Summary

> Adora is at Bright Moon after she thought she heard Catra, dead and gone for decades, and looks to see who's behind her.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Mom, are you OK?” Adora heard a voice behind her say and it took her a moment to realize it was Capella.

“Yeah, I’m OK,” Adora said as she stood up, still shaking.

“Liar, you’re shaking,” Capella said, coming around the couch.

Adora was taking deep breaths, trying to get her shaking under control as she plastered a smile on her face. Capella was shaking her head, having seen Adora like this before.

“Nope, don’t put the fake smile on,” Capella said.

“Your speciality?” Adora said, trying to make a joke out of it. Capella hadn’t been particularly good with most magic but she was a deft hand at illusions and stage makeup. She had her hair

shaved close at that moment and Adora knew that was a sure sign she'd been spending a lot of time under a wig lately. "And what's this I hear about you throwing a pie in someone's face?"

Capella hugged Adora as she said, "Good try, Mom, but I'm not letting you change the topic. I know what day it is."

Adora hugged her back as she said, "Don't worry about me, I'm fine."

"Bullshit," Capella said. "You might be able to put Nock off with that but it's not flying with me. You were sitting there starting to snore and then suddenly jumped up like you'd been electrocuted. When you turned around you looked…"

Capella wasn't sure how to put it. Adora had looked desperately hopeful but that seemed such a weird way of saying what she'd seen.

"I was asleep?" Adora said.

"Oh, don't say you were resting your eyes, that's Dad's schtick," Capella said.

Adora seemed to deflate as she realized she'd probably just had a dream and, not realizing she was asleep, thought she'd heard Catra.

“Come on, what’s wrong?” Capella said and Adora saw the concern written across her face.

“I thought… no, it’s stupid,” Adora said. “Tell me what you’ve been up to instead.”

Capella sat down on a chair and Adora sat down on the loveseat next to it as Capella said, “Alright, I’ll tell you what I’ve been up to. I’ve been away from home for a little while and I came here to find my mom acting weird. Now I’m trying to find out what’s going on but she’s trying to ask me about something else instead.”

Adora gave a little sigh as she said, “That’s not what I meant.”

“It’s what I’m up to,” Capella said. “You said, ‘I thought’ and then wouldn’t finish that. Now I want to know what you were going to say.”

“You’re going to make a good queen one day,” Adora said with a little smile.

“Don’t threaten me,” Capella said with a smile back. “Now finish what you were going to say.”

Adora sighed as she said, “I thought… I thought I heard Catra.”

Capella reached out and took Adora's hand as she said, "I'm sorry. I shouldn't have pushed you."

"No, it's… it's been so long, you'd think I wouldn't be like this every year," Adora said.

"You loved her," Capella said. "I mean, that's kind of what we're celebrating today."

Adora fell back into the loveseat, letting go of Capella as she did, as she said, "I know. I still do but do you have any idea how horrible that is?"

Capella gave her an odd look and it suddenly occurred to Adora that Capella didn't know the story. No one really knew the full story, except Bow and Glimmer. Everyone knew Catra died in the Heart of Etheria. Everyone knew that they'd confessed their love and kissed, and that'd activated the Failsafe and safely shut the Heart down. No one really knew how Catra had died though, Adora hadn't ever elaborated.

"What do you mean?" Capella said.

Adora looked away as she tried not to think of the moment of that kiss she'd been wanting but refusing to acknowledge that she wanted for years. How she'd buried her love for Catra so deep

only for Catra to admit she loved Adora and then Adora to do the same and then the kiss, only for it to end a bare few minutes later. Adora was surprised to feel Capella hugging her and then realized that she was crying as Capella handed her a tissue.

Adora wiped at her eyes and then blew her nose as Capella patiently sat beside her. Adora thought about the times she'd comforted Capella when she was growing up and thought of how the tables had turned now as she gave a little laugh at the thought.

"OK, what's funny?" Capella said.

Adora reached for another tissue as she said, "Just thinking how I used to comfort you and now here you are, doing the same for me."

Capella gave her a hug again as she said, "Of course I am. I might not really be around much anymore but you're still my mom and I worry about you."

"That's what I'm supposed to say," Adora said. "Well, not the mom part."

"Really? You think?" Capella said.

Adora gave her a little push with her shoulder as she said, "Ha-ha."

Capella said, "Listen, I'm not going to bug you about whatever it is but just tell me you've talked about this with someone, please."

"I've talked about it with Glimmer and Bow, yes," Adora said.

"I was hoping for something more than that but I guess that'll do. For now," Capella said before getting a little quieter. "Something really bad happened down there, in the Heart I mean, didn't it?"

Adora didn't answer for a moment before she said, "Yes, but also, no, and that's what's so awful."

Capella left it alone there and a little while later Bow and Glimmer returned. Hugs went all around and Adora found herself feeling a little better as they all gathered in the living room.

"So, any warrants you're running from this time?" Bow asked with a smile.

"No, *Father,* there's no warrants," Capella said with a roll of her eyes. "As if you wouldn't have heard of them already. Tandini might still swear one out for the pie thing but we'll see."

“Where’s Gress?” Glimmer asked. “I was hoping he’d be with you.”

“He’s up on the Velvet Glove for the spacebat’s remembrance thing today,” Capella said. “We’ll meet at the spaceport in the morning.”

“And go on to plan more dastardly events, I’m sure,” Adora said.

“More like plan to foil dastardly events,” Capella said. “If people don’t want me showing up and being a pain, they should be civil.”

Adora smiled as she said, “You would have made a fantastic She-Ra.”

Capella made a big show of recoiling as she said, “Are you kidding!? Are you mad at me!? No, that’s your gig, I don’t want anything to do with that!”

Everyone laughed as Bow said, “She’s right though. You would have.”

“Hey, I have to be queen someday,” Capella said. “Let’s not put more than one thing on me.”

“Don’t sound so excited about it,” Glimmer said\.

“We’ve been over how I feel,” Capella said. “Make sure you hit your checkups with the healers, I do not want the position any time soon.”

“I’m glad your concern for me is so personal,” Glimmer said as she stuck her tongue out at Capella. “And don’t think I don’t know why you’re home now.”

“Of course I’m going to show up when the party is in Plumeria!” Capella said. “I remember what the last one was like and I’m an adult this time. I am going to dance until the dawn comes, have breakfast, and then keep going!”

“You know, you don’t have to come home for that,” Adora said.

“I know but I wanted to anyway,” Capella said to Adora before turning to her other parents. “Also, did you know this one was hiding in here?”

“Yes,” Bow said. “I got her to agree to take a few days off and recoup after today.”

“And I will, I promise,” Adora said.

“Sounds like you don’t want to talk about it,” Capella said. “Which means you need to talk about it. You want me to tell them or do you?”

Adora gave Capella a dirty look that Capella returned right back as Bow said, “Tell us what?”

“I just had a bad dream,” Adora said. “Capella saw me waking up and is making too big a deal of it.”

“All I remember of you and sleep when I was growing up is being impossible to wake up sometimes but not you jumping up from a bad dream,” Capella said.

Glimmer and Bow, who did remember Adora doing that early in their relationship, looked at each other before looking back at Adora. It’d been about Catra back then as well but it hadn’t come up in some time.

“Yes,” Adora said to the unasked question in their eyes.

“What is she saying yes to?” Capella said.

“Why don’t you ask her?” Glimmer said.

“What is it?” Capella said.

“Something I’m not going to talk about right now,” Adora said.

“You know, I get my pain in the ass from you,” Capella said.

“No, you get that from me,” Glimmer said. “You get your kind heart from Adora.”

“Which combines into being just kind of a pain in the ass,” Bow said with a grin.

“Well damn, the bad jokes are coming out, I think I’m going to go for now, especially since someone isn’t sharing,” Capella said.

“I’ll talk about it, eventually,” Adora said. “Just not with you. I love you, I don’t want to put all that on you.”

“I love you too,” Capella said as she got up and hugged Adora. “I’m still not going to let this go but for now, it’s a stalemate.”

Glimmer and Bow both hugged Capella before she teleported out. Glimmer stood next to Adora with an arm around her for a moment before she said, “OK, what happened?”

“Do I really have to talk about this now?” Adora said.

“You did say you were,” Bow said.

“I said eventually,” Adora replied. “It’s a holiday, I don’t want to bring it down.”

“We just spent the morning looking at photos of the departed,” Glimmer said. “I don’t think you can bring that down.”

Adora sighed as she went over to the bar and got herself a fizzy drink. She didn’t even look at the label as she popped it open and took a drink. She made a face as the taste hit her and she looked at the bottle.

“Why do we have a tamarind, mango, and orange drink?” Adora said. “It’s awful.”

Bow came over and took the bottle from her as he said, “I happen to like it. And you’re avoiding the subject.”

“I’m not,” Adora said. “I just wanted something to drink and then was ambushed by your horrid taste in beverages.”

“She’s definitely avoiding it,” Glimmer said as she stepped up next to Bow and took the bottle from his hand and took a sip herself. “Although she is right, that is awful.”

“It’s not in there for you,” Bow said as he took his drink back. “Now, come on, what happened?”

“I had a bad dream, that’s it,” Adora said.

“Something about this has you messed up though,” Bow said. “What was it?”

Adora paid attention to the drink selection this time and got a peach fizzy drink. She popped it open with a sigh as she said, “I thought I heard Catra. Like, it was so real.”

“I’m sorry,” Glimmer said as she came around and hugged Adora.

“It’s stupid, I know it’s not her,” Adora said. “Well, now I do but why am I so hung up on it after all this time?”

“I don’t think you’re hung up on it,” Glimmer said. “It’s just this day. Maybe next year we do the memories in another way. Looking at old photos over and over to relieve tragedy can’t be good.”

“Yeah, I guess,” Adora said with a sigh.

The three were quiet for a moment before Bow finally said, “What did she say?”

“What?” Adora said, looking up from her study of the bar top.

“When you said you thought you heard her, what did she say?” Bow said.

Adora could still hear it in her head and shook her head to clear Catra’s voice as she said, “She asked where she was.”

“That’s definitely some dream logic right there,” Glimmer said.

“What do you mean?” Adora said.

“I mean, you’d think it’d be something more personal but that just sounds like your brain trying to make sense of something,” Glimmer said.

Adora remembered the voice, it had sounded so confused and lost, but she had to admit, Glimmer did have a point.

“Yeah, probably,” Adora said. “Can we not talk about this anymore though? I don’t want to linger on it.”

“You did tell us,” Bow said. “We’ll let you off the hook.”

“Thanks,” Adora said.

“That doesn’t mean for good,” Glimmer said. “We’re not having a repeat of how you were when we got together.”

“It’s not going to get that bad,” Adora said with a roll of her eyes.

“I know,” Glimmer said, her voice softening. “I just don’t want you like that again, I hated seeing you like that.”

“I hated being like that,” Adora said with a frown. “I’m happy with you, you know that right?”

Glimmer hugged her again as she said, “Of course I know that. Both of you make me happy as well. I just know… well, she made you happy and it was a big moment for you. I’d never hold that against you.”

That wasn’t strictly true Adora knew, they’d have a few fights early in their relationship about it before they’d worked through it,

but she wasn't going to bring those up.

"I know you wouldn't," Adora said.

Bow stepped around and hugged them both as he said, "We still have a few hours before we need to head out. Let's get some lunch, relax, and then get ready for the party."

"That sounds good," Adora said.

After lunch, Adora was sprawled out in a beanbag chair, her eyes drooping a little as she drifted off again. Then she sat bolt upright as she heard Catra's voice again say, "Adora, *please!* Where am I!?"

Chapter End Notes

> Not much to comment on at this point. It was fun trying to think of what Capella would be like without all of the incidents from *The Heir Apparent* happening to her. Thanks for reading!

Camp Bright Moon Timeline

Chapter Summary

Adora sits down on her computer as she tries to see what Catra has been up to for the previous years.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora's hands shook a little as she looked at the Facebook profile in front of her. Very little of it was public from what Adora could see but the image looking back at her sent Adora's memory flooding back, the moments as friends at Camp Horde for the Lord, the church camp they'd met at when they were just kids, the feelings Adora fought down as she got older, the moment on the dock at Camp Bright Moon when she'd literally said, "Fuck it," and pulled Catra in for a kiss. Her stomach felt like a solid knot as she stared at the image looking back at her. It was Catra, her hair tied back in a ponytail, a heavy pair of tongs over her shoulder, and safety glasses pushed up on her head as she looked into the camera. Adora couldn't help but notice that her arms seemed thicker and shook her head to clear it.

Adora looked at the few bits of information for a moment, feeling her heart thudding, when she finally realized that one of those bits of information was the city that Catra lived in and the realization that Adora lived in a suburb of the same city made her suddenly close the tab on her browser. She leaned back in her chair, feeling stupid, feeling the old feelings that she'd fought so hard to keep down. She knew she was going to make a stupid mistake like she'd made at camp and she knew she had so much more to lose now. She wasn't going to do that, she wasn't going to ruin the life she had with Daniel. She picked up her cell phone

to call her counselor and get some help but her finger froze over the call button as she thought of what the counselor would say to her.

After a brief moment of time, Adora set her phone down and walked out of the bedroom. She stood in the hallway, trying to remember why she'd even come this way before she was intercepted by her computer. She looked down the hall and saw her linen closet and remembered she was going to polish the dining room table. She hurried down and opened the closet, grabbing a few pieces of old towels out of her rag bag, and quickly headed back to get the wood polish. As she passed her bedroom, she looked away, as if the computer had the power to curse her if she went any closer.

The next hour she filled with polishing the table. It was a good sized table and with all of its leaves in it could sit twelve. She remembered picking it out with Daniel a few months after they'd been married and they'd bought a house. It was walnut, solid and dense, and she remembered being there as several people from the furniture company had brought it in to set it up. She'd never been able to put into words very well but the table had been an anchor, this thing that her and Daniel had done together for their new home, and now she went over it and over it, getting on the ground and making sure even the underside was dusted and cleaned before focusing on each chair, pulling the spares out of storage and removing their dust covers to polish each one.

Finally, Adora sat on the floor of the dining room, looking at the table and felt at peace. She knew everyone had something in their past they weren't happy with and she knew the urges she suffered from were just temptations from the Devil that she had to ignore. She even laughed a little as she thought of looking up

Catra on Facebook. It wasn't like Catra being in the city made any difference. Including the suburbs, the city had a population of almost one and half million people. It wasn't like she was going to track her down with just a city and her profession that had been listed. Besides, what was she going to do if she did find her? That was the past after all. Things were different. She was a happy housewife to her husband with a satisfying life.

Glimmer Selene.

The name suddenly popped into Adora's mind. Glimmer Selene, attorney-at-law, in fact. She could see the name in her head and remembered her talking on the news broadcast and at the same time remembered her on the dock of Camp Bright Moon, telling her that her and Catra had a safe place to stay. Glimmer Selene and her boyfriend, Bow Hart, two people that had shown Adora acceptance and care even though they didn't know her for more than a few hours at the time. She realized that Catra had stayed in touch with them, was probably friends enough that they were going to protests together, and suddenly Adora was off the floor and headed back towards the computer without fully realizing it.

Halfway there though, she stopped in the hallway.

"What are you doing!? This is stupid! You don't need to see her again! It was just a stupid moment! That didn't mean anything, why am I still hung up on this!?" Adora said out loud. "Don't do this, it's not going to help."

Adora leaned against the wall and looked at the ultra-saturated farmhouse picture on the wall opposite. It had been a gift from her mother, who had a rotating selection of them in her home, and Adora had it hung in the hallway as a way to appease her mother but not have it in a place she'd notice it much. Now, staring at it, she had the deep urge to take it and throw it down the hall or at least into the trash.

"Damn it, damn it, damn it," Adora muttered as she turned away from the painting and walked into her bedroom.

A few minutes later she was looking at Glimmer Selene's page. This one was more open than Catra's page had been and included the name of the group that Glimmer had said she represented. Another minute and Adora was looking at the Facebook page of the Rubicon Foundation which had a picture of Glimmer and Bow standing in a group of other people as its header. What caught Adora's eye though was an event notice at the top of the page.

"SB1523 Discussion," Adora read. The event was that evening at a local coffee shop called The Cracked Cup Coffee. She saw that about six people had said they were going with about twenty more saying they were possibly going. Adora hadn't heard of the coffee shop but she clicked through anyway and saw the location, not too far from the downtown area and in an area she'd heard was kind of rough. She wasn't sure why she was even thinking of that, she couldn't just go there, she had no business going there, and she certainly wasn't going to go there.

"Why am I doing this?" Adora said as she stared at the computer before going back to Glimmer's page. Where Catra hadn't had any photos available beyond her profile picture, Glimmer had several

different albums. Adora clicked into one labeled Family and saw Glimmer standing with her Mom and Dad, who Adora had briefly met on that fateful day, as well as Bow. There were two women Adora didn't recognize, although one of them looked a bit like Glimmer's dad, and standing next to Bow was Catra with an awkward smile.

The time stamp on the photo was only a few months old and as Adora scrolled down, it was mostly various photos of Glimmer with her parents, the two women, Bow, and Catra in various combinations. Some of them were on the back porch of her parent's home and Adora recognized some of them were around Camp Bright Moon, but there were a bunch of places that Adora didn't recognize.

One caught her eye. It was a group of people in a living room. The room had some Christmas decorations hung up and one of the people in the crowd Adora was someone Adora was sure she knew. After a moment, Adora realized it was Lynda D'ream and she'd known the woman from Camp Horde for the Lord. Catra was sitting in the woman's lap and laughing and Adora felt a rush of anger come on for some reason that she just as quickly shoved back down.

Adora spent the next ten minutes going through every one of Glimmer's photos and switched over to Bow's profile to find he had even more photos available. From the amount of photos, Adora began to wonder if Bow ever set his phone down. She slowly went through the photos, fighting back the stabbing guilt she felt, and saw Catra and Bow with their arms around each other as they made goofy faces on the front porch of some house and then another with Bow, Glimmer, and Catra at some restaurant with other people, Bow's arm disappearing out of the

frame as he held the camera up to try and capture the whole table. Another photo that stood out was a photo of Catra with safety glasses and hearing protection on as she struck at a piece of metal that seemed to be glowing orange. Sparks were flying everywhere and the caption to the photo said, "Catra making our new home's front railing!"

There were lots of pictures of Glimmer in various poses along with candid photos taken without her seeming to have known. Catra showed up as well as some people that Adora assumed were Bow's fathers. She felt a little awkward to see one of the photos of two older men, one rolling his eyes while he smiled and the other holding his face to kiss him.

Adora finally hit the bottom of the photos and then scrolled back up through them, stopping on some of the photos with Catra. Adora was looking for photos with Catra and Lynda. She noticed that Lynda was in a portion of the photos for a few years with Catra, although Bow had her labeled as Scorpia on the photos, and then she seemed to drop out for a little while before she was back with a woman that Bow had labeled as Perfuma and Catra was by herself. Adora felt a strange contentment that she was sure she wasn't ready to explore on her own. When she got back to the Christmas photo that had Catra in Scorpia's lap, she realized Perfuma was sitting right next to them and was laughing as well.

When she backed out of the photos, feeling a strange mix of satisfied and unhappy, she saw that while she'd been scrolling through the photos that Bow had posted about the event that night that the Rubicon Foundation was hosting.

“Come out tonight to find out more about the mistake that is SB1523 and how you can help support trans rights!”

Adora looked at it and felt a strange feeling, like Bow was speaking to her, and she quickly shook her head as she carefully closed the browser tab. She spent the next hour lying to herself as she did some meal prep and then she spent ten minutes changing into some clothes she thought of as nondescript as she told herself it was just to run to the store, and then she spent two minutes on the phone, lying again but this time to Daniel.

“I’m going to go to the grocery store and then I thought I’d run out to a meeting tonight if that’s alright,” Adora said. “I figured I’d go since you would be working late.”

“Sure!” Daniel said and Adora felt guilty how trusting he sounded. “Do you want to eat together when you get back or do you just want me to grab something on the way home?”

“You don’t have to do that,” Adora replied. “I can make something and leave it for you to warm up.”

“Don’t worry about it,” Daniel said. “It’s Tuesday, I’ll grab some tacos.”

“If you’re sure,” Adora said.

“I’m sure,” Daniel said. “See you tonight!”

“OK, see you tonight,” Adora said and then hung up the phone.

She paced back and forth in the kitchen for a few minutes as she said, “I’m just going to go to the store. I haven’t made a decision, not really. I can just say I changed my mind if he asks. He won’t ask. What if he does ask, what do I say!? This is stupid, this is so stupid, why am I doing this?”

As she said the last part, she grabbed her keys and headed towards the door.

Chapter End Notes

I had to go and remind myself how Facebook works because I hardly use it anymore. If there’s any discrepancies, let’s just say this Facebook works a bit differently.

When the Music's Over Timeline

Chapter Summary

> Adora flies to Moraine, full of anger as she thinks of Catra. She's going to try and find out what happened to her, why she went to the Kingdom of Snows, and maybe even find her to ask why herself. On the way, she's going to run into something she hasn't run into in a long time. How she deals with that, well, that's the rub.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora had been in the air for an hour before she got the first radio call.

“Adora, this is Bow. Answer back, over.”

Adora ignored it. She had the skiff pointed north and she wasn’t going to turn around. The air was colder at altitude but her anger was keeping her warm.

“Adora, this is Bow. Please answer. I need to know you’re alright. Over.”

The anger waned a little as she heard Bow’s voice. She could tell he was worried and she sighed a little as she reached for the radio before stopping herself. She didn’t want to turn around. She was

going to go to this little town where Catra had once fled to and figure out what was going on herself.

"Adora, this is Bow. I know you're still flying because you're passing close to the Heart Blossom Traffic Control center."

Adora looked over to the side and saw the sprawling nomadic homes of Plumerians that were set up near the Heart Blossom.

"Come on, Adora. Please. Let me know you're alright. Over."

Adora finally picked up the microphone and keyed it up.

"Bow, this is Adora. I'm going to be alright, I just have to do something here on my own. Over."

There was silence for a moment before Bow spoke.

"Promise me you'll check in regularly. Over."

"I promise. Every morning, every evening. Would that be alright? Over."

"Yes. Why are you doing this? Over."

"I have to know. Don't ask me what, I just have to know something. Over."

"That's reassuring," Bow said and Adora could hear the deadpan sarcasm even through the radio link. "Alright, if that's what it is. Let us know if you need us. Over."

"I will. Over."

Adora hung the microphone back up and pushed the throttle forward a little bit more.

By the time Adora reached Moraine, a town on the edge of the Kingdom of the Snows, she was shivering. She'd been dressed for a day in Southern Plumeria in early summer. However, in Moraine, snow still hung out in the deeper shadows and as Adora landed at the airport shortly before they shut the beacon off for the night, she was shivering and wondering where she could get a coat.

"Kind of lightly dressed aren't you?" a voice said. Adora turned to see a woman in a pair of insulated coveralls walk up and lean against the front of the skiff.

"I didn't realize it'd be this cold," Adora said. "There isn't a place I could get a coat this late is there?"

“Well, normally, no,” the woman replied. “You’re in luck though. There’s a festival going on right now and I think one of the vendors is still open and has a coat. I’ll take you over if you want.”

Adora took the keys from the skiff and jumped down to the ground as she said, “Thanks, I’d appreciate that. My name’s Adora by the way.”

“I thought so,” the woman said. “I’m Sally.”

“What do you mean you thought so?” Adora said.

“You’re not exactly a common person you know,” Sally said.

“That’s not why you’re helping me is it?” Adora said, stepping back a little. She hated when people treated her as someone special.

“No, I’m helping you because it’s part of my job to help fools who fly into Moraine wearing thin shirts,” Sally said with a grin.

“It wasn’t exactly a planned flight,” Adora said with a grimace.

“All the more reason to help,” Sally said. “Come on. Let’s get you something to keep you warm and then see about getting some dinner if you don’t mind some company.”

Adora kind of did but she didn’t say, feeling like she’d already kind of insulted Sally already with the insinuation that she was only helping Adora because of her status. They walked into the town and Adora noticed the sharply sloped roofs and how every building was painted in various bright pastel colors. She’d been there once before, years before shortly after the war, and she remembered it being a lovely town. Nothing seemed to have changed much. People bustled about greeting each other, lights were strung across the road casting multiple colors in the early evening darkness, and Adora felt a little more solid than she had in a while.

It was a short walk to a wide open square that had a bunch of people milling around listening to music. Around the square in temporary structures ranging from tarps to full geodesic domes were vendors of varying kinds. Sally walked right up to one in a large tent with racks of clothes.

“Otter, this is a friend of mine,” Sally said, hooking a thumb over her shoulder at Adora. “She miscalculated the weather and needs a few things so she can run around and not freeze to death.”

Otter looked up, their whiskers twitching a little as they fought back a huge smile as they said, “Yeah, no worries.”

Adora could tell Otter knew who she was but was grateful that they didn't say anything about it.

Otter walked around Adora, looking her over, before saying, "You got a good base layer going there with what you got on and the shoes you've got should be alright if you're just knocking around town. So let's go sweater, some good pants, and a good anorak should round it all out. I'll toss in some mittens and gloves for nothing."

Adora just agreed and was soon feeling much warmer. The sweater was a dark red but the pants and anorak were a bright blue with abstract colorful embroidery along the front and the seams. The gloves and mittens were similar and once Adora was dressed, she was reaching for her money when Sally waved her off.

"Don't bother," Sally said. "I've got it."

"Which means that town is going to cover it," Otter said with a laugh. "Don't let her fool you into thinking she's doing a big thing. I'll charge it to the usual account."

"I don't want a big deal made about me," Adora said.

"It's something we do," Sally said. "Make sure visitors are kitted out right. It avoids us having to spend even more on finding them

and fixing them up when something happens because they weren't dressed right."

"Or burying them," Otter said.

Sally rolled her eyes as she said, "Yes, or bury them but I was trying not to mention that."

"Well I will because I'm tired of doing it," Otter said. "And thanks for choosing me by the way."

Adora watched the two as she tried to think of what to do now but once again Sally jumped in with, "Well, I'm going to go get her settled. Have a good night."

Otter gave a little salute as they went back to packing stuff away and Sally started walking.

"You got a preference to food?" Sally said as Adora walked along beside her.

"Not really," Adora replied.

"Alright, well there's a good inn here in town," Sally replied. "The food isn't fancy but there's lots of it and it's filling which is a

needful thing if you want to stay warm."

"Sure, that sounds fine," Adora said, feeling welcome.

Sally chatted as they made their way through the square. A band began to tune up in a gazebo and a crowd of people were gathered around to listen. Adora stopped for a moment to listen as the band launched into some kind of jaunty dance tune and Sally stopped with her as they watched part of the crowd start dancing.

"You dance?" Sally asked after watching for a few minutes.

"Not for years," Adora replied, trying to remember the last time she'd danced. She knew it had to have been with Catra more than likely and she suddenly remembered why she was even in Moraine and fought back the anger. "Can we get that dinner?"

Sally looked at her a bit oddly but just nodded and gave a little head nod in the direction she started walking. They didn't walk far from the square, as the inn was just down the street, and as they walked in, the woman behind the desk greeted Sally warmly. As Sally responded back, Adora looked around the small lobby, noticing the large dining room with a low ceiling off the back of it.

"Frosta, my friend here needs a room for the night," Sally said.

Adora's ears perked up at the woman's name. It had been common after the war to name babies after the princesses and their companions but while there were a lot of Adoras and Bows and Glimmers and more Catras than Adora had expected, and even the occasional Sea Hawk to her neverending amusement, she'd rarely run into a Frosta. She'd never understood why but now she had a sneaking suspicion it was probably more common in the Kingdom of Snows, a place she hadn't traveled very much even though she'd very much wanted to do so. She remembered why she hadn't as well.

"Nothing fancy," Adora said and then heard the anger she was feeling towards Catra snip out of her voice. "Sorry, been a long flight up here. Nothing fancy, please."

"No worries, we don't do fancy in here," Frosta said with a laugh. "You want ground floor?"

"I'm not picky," Adora said.

"Ground floor," Frosta said with a nod and then handed Adora a slim piece of metal with holes punched in it. "There's your key. If you need it for another night, let me know as soon as possible."

"Should just be for tonight, I'm headed on early," Adora said.

"No worries," Frosta said. "Someone will be on the desk early. Settling up is straightforward."

After a little more back and forth, Adora followed Sally into the dining room. A huge rack sat along the front of the room that had various coats, parkas, anoraks, hoodies, and other cold weather clothes hung up on it. Adora got out of her anorak and hung it on a peg before turning around and blushing as she saw Sally tying her coveralls around her waist. The sleeveless shirt she was wearing under it showed off her muscular arms and Adora was suddenly awkward as she realized that maybe Sally wasn't just showing her around to be a good host to a guest of the town.

After Catra had left, Adora had tried to date after a while. It'd never gone very far and after a couple of years, she'd just stopped trying. Her therapist had asked her why she felt like she needed to not be involved with anyone and Adora had never given an answer she felt like was worth anything. Now she was reminded of it and began to argue with herself over whether or not she was overthinking the whole thing and seeing things that weren't actually there.

They walked over to a little table sitting up against the wall and Sally sat down with a sigh as Adora sat down, her mind whirring as she tried to take in every little sign and signal.

"Been a long day," Sally said. "Gotta say, good way to end it though."

"I don't want to keep you, I don't mind eating by myself," Adora said as she looked around for a menu.

Sally shook her head as she said, “I don’t mind, although if you want to be alone, just say the word.”

Adora suddenly felt supremely lonely all of a sudden and just shook her head as she said, “No, it’s alright. Although, where’s the menu?”

Sally tapped the table top and Adora looked down to see that the menu was pasted to the tabletop and sealed over with clear lacquer.

“Right there,” Sally said.

Adora laughed suddenly as she said, “Just needed to move my hands.”

Sally laughed as well and the two took a look at the menu. Adora noticed that like Sally had said, the food was not fancy, and there certainly wasn’t a wide selection, but she could see other tables with big plates full of various things and picked something out right as the server got up to the table.

“Welcome, you got any questions?” the server asked.

Adora shook her head as Sally said, “Naw, I think we’re good, Mitt, I’ll have my usual.”

“We don’t have your usual beer,” Mittens said. “You want something else?”

Sally was about to respond when she caught the look on Adora’s face when the word beer was mentioned.

“Naw, let’s go cherry fizzy drink,” Sally said.

“Can do,” Mittens replied before turning to Adora.

“The Blue Plate Special and just some ice water,” Adora said, although she wondered how special it could be sealed under lacquer where it couldn’t be updated.

“Done,” Mittens replied. “Back in a few.”

“Stories are true then?” Sally said after Mittens had left the table.

“What stories?” Adora said, trying not to feel defensive.

“About the drinking,” Sally said after a pause. “I didn’t even think about it until I saw your face.”

Adora sighed as she picked up a sugar packet and fiddled with it.

"Yeah, they're true. Sorry, if you want a beer, get a beer. Don't let my hangups screw with your evening."

Sally reached forward and placed a hand over Adora's hand that was flicking the top of the sugar packet back and forth.

"It's not screwing with my evening," Sally said. "It's just a beer."

Adora would have normally said that she'd never seen it be just a beer but she also knew that was one of her many unresolved problems with Catra. This time though, her brain was nothing but white noise as she felt Sally's hand on top of hers. After a moment she thought of pulling her hand back but she didn't.

"I'm… I'm not looking for anything," Adora said.

It was Sally's turn to look a bit embarrassed but Adora noticed she didn't move her hands as she said, "OK, that wasn't what I originally intended when I offered to get you the clothes at the airport. The town really does cover that, I wasn't just making a move. I am enjoying myself though but I'll leave if you want."

Adora wanted to tell her to go on but she was so tired of eating by herself and being by herself and the simple touch of Sally's hand resting on her own felt warm and comfortable and she said, "No, don't go. Let's just… I get it now, it's alright. Let's just have a good dinner."

Sally gave Adora's hand a squeeze and pulled her hand back as she said, "Well, I don't know about good but we'll have dinner."

Adora laughed as she said, "You said it wasn't fancy. You didn't say it wasn't good."

"That is true," Sally said. "It's good. And who knows? Maybe they'll toss a little parsley on the plate and make it fancy too."

Sally said the last part with a smile that seemed to pull Adora in and she briefly found herself wondering what it would be like to fiddle with Sally's close cropped hair before she laughed a little at both the image and the parsley comment while blushing a little. The rest of dinner went that way. They talked about little things, just getting to know the other, and Adora laughed again when the food came out and there was a little bit of parsley on both of their plates. She started off a bit hesitant but after about ten minutes, she found herself actually having a good time. As the meal wrapped up, with what Adora had to admit was a truly fantastic dessert of cinnamon apples over ice cream, she and Sally had a little light hearted argument over who paid.

"Come on, you're a stranger to my town and I recommend the place," Sally said as she held one side of the little notebook that

held the check. “Manners say I pay for you.”

“And I’m traveling and have no problem covering myself,” Adora said as she held the other side.

“Are you going to make me say it?” Sally said.

“Say what?” Adora said, genuinely confused.

“It’s a date I’m taking you on,” Sally replied. “I’m paying.”

“Oh, it’s a date? I thought it was just a good dinner,” Adora said, actually feeling a little pleased at the thought, to her pleasant surprise.

“Fine, it wasn’t, kind of, but I’m calling it that,” Sally said. “I even say we go check out which band is playing after this, to cement the date.”

Adora found herself smiling at the thought and finally let go as she said, “Fine.”

Sally dropped some coins on the check as she stood up and said, “Thank you. Shall we?”

“We shall,” Adora said with a smile.

As they walked back to the square Sally cautiously reached out and took Adora’s hand. Adora felt it through her mittens and fought back the urge to grasp back tightly. She was happy and the next two hours were the best hours Adora had experienced in years. They held hands together and listened to the music for about ten minutes before Sally convinced Adora to dance. At first Adora was rusty but soon she was dancing smoothly as she laughed and held onto Sally as if she was a life preserver. Finally, the band wrapped up with one last song to general applause and the two of them collapsed onto a heated bench.

“Oh, this is nice,” Adora said as she took her glove off and touched the armest.

“Necessary for living up here,” Sally said as she watched Adora. “Nights get long and sitting around indoors gets old. You’ll see people out here in all but the worst weather.”

Adora leaned back as she looked up and saw the stars laid out above her. In the cold air, they seemed sharp as cut glass and were only accented by the shifting Etherian aurora. Sally leaned back and looked with her in silence.

“You know,” Adora said, her voice quiet, “I remember when they came out. I’d just done something that I couldn’t go back from and I was so scared.” Sally turned to look at Adora as she took

one of her hands as Adora continued to watch the stars. “Took me years to appreciate them like others did and even now, they’re still a reminder of mistakes.”

“You want to talk about it?” Sally asked.

“No,” Adora said, with a sigh as she wiped at her eyes with her other hand. “I feel like all I do is think about the past or talk about the past. Tonight is the first time in months, damn, probably years, that I’ve really felt happy.”

“Glad I could help,” Sally said, squeezing Adora’s hand.

Adora shook her head with a shy smile as she said, “Sorry, we were trying to have a date and I’m bringing it down.”

“Naw, you’re not. Part of a date is just getting to know someone. I’m getting to know you,” Sally said.

“Well, I’m glad I was dumb enough to fly in without proper clothes so you could take me to get some,” Adora said, running her hand along the embroidery on the front of her anorak.

“I haven’t wanted to ask but…,” Sally said and then trailed off.

Adora turned to her, realizing it was the first time that night she'd really seen her without confidence.

"Go on," Adora said.

"Why are you up here?" Sally said. "I know you said it was an unexpected flight but, I mean, you don't even have an overnight bag. Unless it's in the skiff and I just didn't notice."

"I don't really want to talk about it," Adora said as she looked away.

"Hey, that's fine," Sally said. "I was just curious."

The crowd was thinning out and a solitary hot cider vendor was doing brisk business as people stopped for a warm drink on their way home. Adora watched the groups walking away and felt the anger rise as she remembered all the times she'd had to bow out of one thing or another because Catra had refused to go along. She'd always had one excuse or another that Adora would try and accommodate but it usually just led to a fight and then they wouldn't do it.

"Didn't mean to make you look so gloomy," Sally said. "It really was just idle curiosity."

"Just old bad memories," Adora said. "It's nothing, really."

“Want to call it a night?” Sally said.

Adora wanted nothing less but she was beginning to realize she’d started the morning early to be out to Half Moon and then spent a long time on a skiff to reach Moraine. Add on everything else and she realized she really was tired.

“I don’t but I started the day early,” Adora said. “It’s not you though. I really am having a good time.”

“Let’s grab some cider and I’ll walk you back to your room,” Sally said.

Adora agreed, even though she suddenly had butterflies in her stomach as they got the cider. It came in heavy, insulated mugs that required a deposit. As they walked, holding hands, Adora sipped at the cider with a sigh as the warmth spread through her.

“Good, isn’t it?” Sally said.

“Yeah,” Adora replied.

When they got to the inn, it was quiet inside. The dining room was empty and a bell sat on the desk with a sign saying to ring

for service. They stepped down into a hallway and went a short distance until they stopped in front of the room.

"Thanks for this," Adora said. "I'll probably be flying out tomorrow but thanks, really. This is the most normal I've felt in far too long."

"I'm glad it could be me then," Sally said. "You deserve to feel normal."

They both stood in silence for a moment before Adora suddenly drained the last of her cider and held the mug out to Sally.

"Here you go. So you can get your deposit back," Adora said.

Sally gave a little chuckle as she took the mug.

"Thanks," Sally said as she shuffled her feet a little before she went on. "I, uh, really would like to kiss you right about now."

Adora didn't answer, she just leaned forward before she could stop herself and pulled Sally to her for a kiss. After a moment, Sally closed her eyes and wrapped her arms around Adora. After a couple of minutes, they broke apart.

“OK, I was expecting a little more warning,” Sally said with a chuckle.

“Sorry,” Adora said with a shy smile.

“You say that too much,” Sally said before kissing Adora’s nose.

“Sorr… I mean, yeah, I know,” Adora said. “I should say, nothing else is going to happen tonight.”

“That’s fine,” Sally said. “Finest night I’ve had in a while myself.”

“Thanks, me too,” Adora said.

They kissed a few more times before they parted and Adora went into the room, to sit on the bed in the dark, staring at the tiny frost covered window for a long time.

Chapter End Notes

> Sally has a brief moment in To Strive, To Seek, To Find, and Not to Yield, Finn’s big story about finding their biological parents. She’s doing the same thing here that she was doing there, helping people who don’t quite understand how dangerous the Kingdom of Snows can be. Her turning into a date for Adora came out of nowhere though. Adora was supposed to have a more introspective time by herself, and this was supposed to be a shorter chapter, but that is not how it turned out obviously.

As may be obvious, I've been posting slower than normal. Part of that is my wife and I got COVID again. We're doing alright though so that's good. Part of it is I've just kind of been worn down lately. The season, personal stuff, and other has kind of kept me from writing. I'm not announcing that I'm quitting, I do want to finish this and my other stuff, but I am announcing I'm not going to worry about punching the clock like I have for the last three and half years. So thank you as always for reading and I look forward to giving you more stuff, just might be a little slower than normal.

Bright Moon Timeline

Chapter Summary

> Adora decides to visit the Crystal Castle for the first time since the war has ended in hopes she can put to rest her guilt over Catra's death.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora looked around, trying to see where Catra's voice had come from, when she realized what had happened, that she'd fallen asleep again. Glimmer and Bow were in another room and Adora leaned onto her knees as tears pricked at her eyes. She wondered if she was finally going insane from the guilt she carried over that day in The Heart. She'd never really said but it had all been her fault, she knew it was her fault. If she hadn't kissed Catra, if she hadn't held her close, none of this would have happened. If she'd just waited, she wouldn't have killed her.

"I love you! So please, just this once, stay!" Catra had said and Adora had been ready to do just that. For all those things she'd wanted and not fully realized. For love, for the warmth of Catra's embrace, for a future, all of it a beautiful wish that she reached for and in doing so, she pulled Catra to her and kissed her and she felt the warmth and power of the Failsafe trigger. It was the grandest moment in her entire life. Followed by the worst.

"Adora?"

Adora snapped back to the present to see Bow crouched down in front of her.

"Hey, we're going to be leaving soon," Bow said. "Do you want to get ready?"

Adora nodded as let out a long sigh.

"I guess. Maybe Plumeria is what I need."

"You always did enjoy the dancing," Bow said as he sat down in front of her.

"It happened again," Adora said after a moment.

"What happened again?" Bow said.

"I thought I heard Catra," Adora said. "I was sure I had. Why now? I thought I had made peace with it for the most part except for days like today. Why am I all of a sudden hearing her?"

"Were you asleep?" Bow said. Adora nodded as he smiled. "See? It's just a dream, like when Cappe woke you up earlier."

“I know but… Bow, I’ve seen a lot of magic, I *am* magic, and this felt…,” Adora said as she trailed off, not sure she wanted to say it.

“Magic?” Bow said. Again, Adora nodded as she shifted on the beanbag chair. “Are you sure?”

“No,” Adora said. “Not really. Maybe I’m just imagining it.”

“You’re doing that thing where you try and dismiss yourself,” Bow said.

“I’m not,” Adora said and then let a little frown develop. “Well, not really.”

“You know, you never really talk about that day,” Bow said.

“For good reason,” Adora said.

“Maybe it’s time,” Bow said.

“It’s not time,” Adora said.

“You’ve said that for years now,” Bow said. “Maybe it is time.”

“No,” Adora said as she crossed her arms. “Bow, I know I’ve said it’s not time but you know what? I don’t think it’s ever going to be time. I don’t want to remember it at all. If I could wipe my mind of it and live without that knowledge, I would have done it years ago.” When Adora looked at Bow, she realized how horrified he looked at what she’d said. “I see how you look. I mean it.”

“I… I don’t doubt that,” Bow said. “But maybe that’s why you need to share it. Don’t hang on to it, get it out there.”

Adora stood up as she said, “No. Bow, you’re my best friend but I’m not going to talk about this.”

Adora walked away as Bow stood to follow her.

“Adora, I’m sorry, I wasn’t trying to make you angry.”

Adora was about to snap at him that she wasn’t angry when she realized that wasn’t true. She took a deep breath to calm down, doing a slow count to ten before she answered.

“I know you weren’t. I know it’s who you are to care and worry but this is just… it’s something I have to carry on my own. Let it go.”

Bow stepped up and hugged her and after a moment, Adora hugged him back.

"I'm going to get dressed now. I just… I need to get out of my head," Adora said. "The whole point of the party tonight is to get out of our heads after this morning after all."

"That's not the whole reason. I mean, we want to celebrate," Bow said.

Adora gave a little chuckle as she said, "We're Etherians, do we ever need a reason to celebrate? I mean, do you know anywhere on this planet that doesn't have a party at the drop of a hat?"

"That's not a bad thing," Bow said.

"I know," Adora said as she made a decision. "Listen, I'm going to go visit the Crystal Castle before I go to Plumeria."

Bow looked at her in confusion as he said, "You haven't been back there in, well, I don't think you've been back there since that day."

"I haven't," Adora said. "I think I need to though. Maybe that's the problem. I need some closure."

“Listen, I’m all for that, I’d love it, I know Glimmer would love it, but are you sure?” Bow asked. “By yourself?”

“It’s fine, really,” Adora said. “I’ll see you at the dances, alright?”

“What do you mean, see you at the dances?” Glimmer said as she walked into the room.

“I’m going to go to the Crystal Castle,” Adora said. “I just want to look around a little.”

Glimmer stood there in silence for a moment before she said, “Bow, can we have a moment?”

Bow nodded and walked out as Glimmer came over.

“It’s just for a short time and then I’m going straight out to Plumeria,” Adora said.

“You know, when I married you, I was worried. I knew how you still felt about Catra, let me finish,” Glimmer said as she held up her hand with a sigh. “I’ve never felt like you loved me any less or anything but why after all this time? Why are you still hung up on this?”

Adora paced away from her and stood staring out a window for a moment. She watched a couple of skiffs, more modern ones than the old Horde variety, go flying away over the Whispering Woods, probably heading for Plumeria for the evening festivities.

"It's just… it was such an awful moment," Adora said with a shake of her head.

"Tell me about it," Glimmer said as she stepped up and put a hand on Adora's wrist.

"You know I don't want to talk about it," Adora said. "I just told Bow I don't want to talk about it, so no, I'm not talking about it."

"OK, maybe I need to be more firm," Glimmer said as she gently pulled Adora's wrist so Adora would turn and look at her. "I'm not giving you the option. You need to tell me about what happened that day. I know she died but you something more happened that you're still carrying around and you need to tell me."

"Listen, I don't…," Adora started to say before Glimmer cut her off.

"No. I want to know. No, I need to know. I should have done this a long time ago but you need to tell me what happened and you're going to tell me right now," Glimmer said, her face getting a bit angry.

“No. I’m not telling you,” Adora said.

“I didn’t give you an option,” Glimmer said, her back straightening and Adora heard the hint of a tone in Glimmer’s voice that Adora hated, the tone that said Glimmer was queen and someone had better answer her. “I want you to tell me.”

“Don’t take that tone,” Adora replied.

Glimmer gritted her teeth as she forced herself to answer in a less imperious way.

“Adora, you need to talk about this and I don’t want to be an asshole about it but I think maybe I should have been an asshole about this years ago because it’s obvious you're still hurting over it,” Glimmer said before she sagged a little. “I just want you to get this out, alright?”

Adora pulled her wrist away from Glimmer as she said, “I killed her, alright? Is that what you wanted to hear?”

Glimmer’s face went slack for a moment in shock before she went straight to confusion.

“What? You said… you said you two confessed your love and then kissed,” Glimmer said. “How in the world… are you screwing with me? Is this because I used my work voice?” The look Adora gave her back said there was no way that was going on. “OK, I think you need to tell me everything.”

“What’s the point? It’s over, it’s done,” Adora said.

“The point is that you just said you killed Catra and that makes no sense,” Glimmer said.

Adora grunted as she turned away but she began talking anyway. She’d feared this for years, that Glimmer would pull away from her, that Bow wouldn’t be her friend anymore, that everyone would hate her but it was out there, blurted out, and she needed to say something.

“You know about our confession and our kiss and everything,” Adora said as she looked at a little kinetic sculpture by the open window as it slowly moved in the afternoon breeze. “Well, it was the kiss.”

“Your kiss killed her?” Glimmer said and Adora could hear the disbelief in her voice.

“I was holding her close when the Failsafe worked,” Adora said as tears streaked down her face at the memory. It seemed particularly close at the moment as she tried to think of what to

say. She could still see Catra disappearing in her arms as the magic raged in the room, like a wish blown out by reality. “She just… she was just gone.”

Glimmer hugged her from behind as Adora took a deep breath.

“If I had just gone in there alone and released it, she’d still be here,” Adora said. “It’s my fault she’s dead. We knew how dangerous the Failsafe was, we weren’t even sure I was going to make it but I let her go with me and then I killed her.”

Glimmer hugged Adora tighter as she said, “You didn’t kill her. I can’t believe you’ve been carrying this around for so long but you didn’t kill her.” Glimmer turned Adora around and looked up at her as she went on. “Do you understand that? There is no way she was going to let you go alone that day. I didn’t know her long but I know that. This isn’t your fault.”

“It is,” Adora said and Glimmer grabbed her by her arms and gave her a gentle shake.

“No, it’s not,” Glimmer said. “Bow and I almost died who knows how many times that day and then there’s Frosta, Perfuma, Scorpia, I mean come on, all of them and more have their own stories that could have turned out just like yours did and it still wouldn’t have been their fault and it’s not your fault.”

“I should still have known,” Adora said.

“No,” Glimmer said, “you’re not using that one. This isn’t something you could have known, something any of us could have known. None of us could have known what was going to happen and that means you didn’t either.”

Adora let out a sigh as she snaked an arm around Glimmer and hugged her as she said, “Maybe you’re right.”

“You know I’m right,” Glimmer said. “I’m going to keep telling you this too.”

Adora nodded as she said, “I’m sorry I’m putting you through this.”

“Adora, you’ve put me through a lot since that day we met in the woods,” Glimmer said. “I don’t regret any of it.”

Adora hugged Glimmer tighter as she tried to think of something to say. Finally she said, “You know, I’m not unhappy with you, I just…”

“It’s what could have been,” Glimmer said, finishing the sentence. “You two grew up together, you had this huge messy thing going on, and then that’s how it ends. I get it. I really do.”

“You ever think about what would have happened if she’d still been here?” Adora said.

“You mean, like not having two bed hogs shoving me around at night?” Glimmer said with a little smile.

Adora gave a little choked laugh as she said, “Be serious.”

“Of course I have,” Glimmer said. “Things would have been different. You two probably would have been married. You’d have done your own thing and Catra would have…”

Glimmer stopped and Adora waited for a moment before saying, “What?”

“I just realized I had no idea what she would have done,” Glimmer said softly.

Adora tried to think of something and just had a vague sense of Catra working with her maybe but on what she didn’t know. As she tried to think it was nothing but vague thoughts of living together and doing abstract things.

“I can’t either,” Adora said in a whisper. “It’s just… if I try, I can think of something but it just feels like making up a story. I stole her future and left her with nothing but a made up story.”

Glimmer hugged her again as she said, “Listen, and I know this is going to be hard to get past your innate Adora-ness, but you didn’t kill her, you didn’t steal anything, it was a freak accident, alright? Just like you always said, she died in an accident. Do you hear me?”

Adora nodded, not really feeling it. Glimmer looked at her and Adora just nodded her head again.

“Nope, Cappe does the same thing,” Glimmer said with a smile. “Answer me with your words, please.”

Adora couldn’t help but smile as Glimmer said the last part in the same gentle tone she’d said it to Nock when he was young and had a tendency to be quiet and just point at stuff.

“I hear you,” Adora said.

“But you don’t believe me,” Glimmer said.

“It’s been a long time,” Adora replied. “I’m not going to just turn around and drop it after all these years.”

“Well, I’ll always be here for you,” Glimmer said with a quick kiss thrown in.

“Thank you,” Adora said. “I don’t regret what’s happened with us, I just want you to know that.”

“I know you don’t,” Glimmer said. “I just wished you’d said this way earlier. A lot of things make more sense now.”

“Really? Want to share them with me?” Adora said as she felt a little lighter.

Glimmer gave her a little push as she said, “Listen, you go do your thing you got to do but you better be at the party by nightfall. I want a dance with you.”

“OK,” Adora said as she gave her another kiss. “I’ll see you there.”

“You know, I don’t know why, but I just… it’s going to be OK,” Glimmer said.

“I know,” Adora said. “It’s been OK all this time.”

Glimmer thought of Adora in her depressive moments over the years as she said, “It hasn’t but I think with this out, it’ll be better.”

“Don’t tell the kids, OK?” Adora said suddenly.

“I’m not but I think you should. I am going to tell Bow though,” Glimmer said. Adora froze for a moment before she started to shake her head and Glimmer nodded back at her. “Yes, yes I am because he’s your friend and he’s in this marriage too and he deserves to know. Besides, you know he’s going to say something way better than I ever managed and make it all better.”

Adora smiled as she said, “Yeah, he’s good at that. ”

“Meaning I’m not,” Glimmer said with a returned smile.

“You’re just fine,” Adora said, hugging her tight before stepping back. “Tell him I’m sorry that I didn’t tell him when he asked earlier.”

“You mean I got it out of you when he couldn’t?” Glimmer said and Adora snorted a little to see Glimmer almost rocking back and forth a little in glee.

“Don’t rub it in,” Adora said with a hug.

They talked for a few more minutes and Glimmer helped Adora pack some clothes for the evening and then Adora was out the

door and to the skiffs. It didn't take her long to get to the Crystal Castle. She remembered before, when she'd come out during the war, it felt like it took forever to find it, as if the Whispering Woods was trying to hide it or shift its location but this time it felt like she could almost see it as soon as she left Bright Moon Castle. When she arrived, she sat down in the meadow in front of the entrance and sat on the edge of the skiff for a few minutes, just listening to the noises of the forest around her and staring at the entrance. Adora didn't realize just how intent she was looking though until a set of arms dropped around her shoulders and a voice said, "What are you…"

The sentence was never finished. Adora jumped and slid off the side of the skiff while grabbing the arms and throwing whoever it was over her shoulder. She saw a form flying forward and then disappear in a cloud of sparkles.

"Cappe, what are you doing out here!?" Adora said, having recognized the distinct sparkle pattern, more purple than Glimmer.

Cappe was standing in front of Adora, straightening out a coat, as she said, "Well, I was coming out to see why you decided to come out to this old wreck of a place."

"And how did you know that I was coming out here?" Adora said, doing her best to put on her Mom voice. Capella just gave her an eye roll for her effort.

“Because Mom and Dad aren’t as quiet as they think they are,” Capella said.

“You were listening at doors again in other words,” Adora said.

“Yes, Mom, I was listening at doors again,” Capella said. “And you still haven’t said why you’re out here.”

“Because I have something I need to do,” Adora said. “I don’t want to talk about it.”

“This has something to do with you being all weird earlier, doesn’t it?”

Adora didn’t say anything for a moment but finally just nodded.

“I thought so. You going in?”

“That was the plan, yes, before I got attacked from behind,” Adora said, trying to make a joke.

“Please, if I was attacking you, that is not what I would have gone with. Aunt Juliet trained me much better than that,” Capella replied.

Adora smiled as she shook her head and said, “Yes, she did. Now, I’ve got to go do this but I’ll see you all at the dance tonight. Come here and give me a hug before I go.”

Capella went over and hugged her as she said, “Mom, it’s funny how you think that I’m just going to sparkle off and let you go down there by yourself.”

Adora pushed Capella back gently as she said, “No, you’re not coming with me.”

“And you’re going to enforce that how?”

Adora started to say something and then shut her mouth as she tried to think.

“Yeah, that’s what I thought,” Capella said. “Now come on, let’s get to walking. I don’t want to be late for the opening dance.”

“You’re not coming with me,” Adora said as Capella started walking backwards across the field.

“OK,” Capella said with a grin. “Here’s how I see this going. You’re going to give me some long thought out rational explanation for why I should stay behind. You’ll probably even get some good

pathos to really tug at the heart strings a little. Then one of two things are going to happen. I'm either going to ignore you and go anyway or I'm going to agree with you, teleport out and then come back and follow you. Sound about right?"

Adora frowned as she said, "I swear, it's you and wanting cake for breakfast all over again."

"That was actually Nock who wanted the cake, I just told him I'd mediate for him," Capella said.

"It's still the same," Adora said with a shake of her head as she started walking forward.

"Not even going to try?" Capella said as Adora passed her.

"It's what you said, let's not miss the first dance," Adora said with a wave of her arm. "Come on and stick close."

Capella nodded and followed her down into the Crystal Castle.

Chapter End Notes

> I just realized I've done Cappe and Adora going down into the Crystal Castle before. What can I say? It's a good place for a little katabasis story element. Anyway, as I've mentioned before, I'm going a bit slower on these than I was but I'm still doing alright. I seem to have fallen into an every other week update schedule for this and my other ongoing fic. My wife

and I have recovered from COVID and don't seem to have any lingering effects on this round. Thank you for everyone's well wishes and as always, thank you for reading.

Camp Bright Moon Timeline

Chapter Summary

Adora heads towards the meeting, not realizing just what's going to happen on a quiet, tree-lined street.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora’s hands were steady as she drove but her stomach was in knots. She’d turned off the highway a few minutes before and followed her GPS as it turned her up a broad boulevard. A sign with ornamentation that called to mind a pagoda sat in the center of the grassy strip of the boulevard and announced she was entering the Asian District. She’d grown up hearing that the part of town she was driving through was dangerous and nothing she’d heard since she’d got older had changed that notion a bit. A tiny building with a giant loaf of bread on top of it greeted her as she drove a little further and she saw signs of graffiti on an old abandoned building.

Other things though stood out, such as the bustling restaurants and car wash she went past as well the nice landscaping on the median and the small, well kept park that had a bronze statue of a soldier that had several flags flying. Adora didn’t recognize the design on one of the flags, a yellow flag with three red stripes running from one side to the other, but it was gone in a flash and the thought of what it was disappeared as she tried to think of why she was doing this at all. It wasn’t like she was going to actually go to the meeting she had told herself as she followed her GPS, turning at a small gas station onto a side street. She immediately saw the coffee shop, with what Adora assumed was a large fiberglass coffee bean sitting on the roof, and noticed the

tiny parking lot was full and the side street she was driving on had cars parked on either side.

She kept going, taking a moment to admire the trees that arched over the street, and saw a space towards the end of the block. She got turned around and managed to parallel park her car before shutting it off. She sat and looked around at the houses, a few in bad repair but most of them looking alright and one or two in excellent condition after what Adora imagined was a lot of renovation since the neighborhood reached back to the early 20th century. A few people were out in the early evening twilight doing things like walking dogs or just out for a stroll and she once again wondered about why she was there. She was happy with her marriage, she was happy with her life, and she had put Catra behind her.

That's what she told herself at least while she sat in the car, staring down the street at the small crowd she could just see starting to gather on the outside deck. She could see the glow of the heaters that were running in the cool early spring air and the strings of fairy lights that crisscrossed the rafters over the patio. For a split second, she thought she saw Catra and her heart gave a hard thud as she felt anxiety and happiness stab at her stomach but then the moment was gone and she was again looking at a group of people she didn't know doing things she could only guess at.

"I'm out of my mind," Adora said with a groan as she leaned against her steering wheel before leaning back a little to thump her head against it. She reached up to turn on the car when a knock at the window caused her to jump. She sat up to see who was at the window and froze as a face looked back at her that she hadn't seen since Camp Bright Moon.

“You alright?” Bow said, although Adora couldn’t really make out the words. She could tell by his face he didn’t seem to recognize her and she found herself rolling down the window a little to tell him she was fine and was just leaving when his face changed and she heard the next words clear as day as the window lowered . “Wait, Adora? Is that you?”

Adora went for a lie. The problem was Adora was a terrible liar.

“Um, no, Bow, it’s not.”

Bow went right past the denial as he said, “What are you doing here? Does Catra know you’re here?”

Adora tried to say something but she just floundered and made some awkward noises.

“Listen, I’m not mad, I’m just shocked to see you here,” Bow said. “Are you here for the meeting?”

“This was a mistake,” Adora managed to say as she started the car up. “I… I just…”

“Hey, it’s alright,” Bow said with a smile that Adora remembered well. “What have you been up to?”

Adora looked at Bow and remembered the first time she met him on a dark night in the woods as she looked for a horse. He'd helped her look for the horse and he'd been kind yet firm when Adora had said ignorant things about him being trans and now he was here again, his voice just as kind as he spoke to her.

"Uh, just, you know, this and that," Adora said. "Finished school, I do some volunteer work, stuff like that."

She didn't know why she didn't mention her marriage but she saw Bow's eyes flick to the ruby on her left ring finger as he said, "That's cool. I work for the Rubicon Foundation. They're putting this on tonight. Is that why you're here?"

Adora just shook her head as she said, "No, I just got lost trying to find a place and was taking a moment. I'm going to head on now."

"Just coincidence then," Bow said and Adora would have laughed at the knowing smile that was on his face if she hadn't been so nervous.

"Yeah, just coincidence," Adora said. "It's good to see you though."

She found that it really was good to see him. His girlfriend Glimmer had been prickly, to put it mildly, when they first met but Bow had always been warm.

"It's good to see you too," Bow said. "Listen, I know how things went but I'd like to catch up, if you want that is. Do you have Facebook?"

Adora didn't move for a moment as she wondered if he knew she'd been snooping on his page but finally just said, "Yeah."

"Great! Is the last name still Weaver?" Bow said.

Adora was stuck. She didn't want to tell Bow, though she couldn't think why at the moment, that she was married. She felt trapped as she said, "It's Addison actually these days."

"Congratulations!" Bow said. "Is it recent?"

"No, we've been married for about five years now," Adora replied. "He's a good man."

"Good to hear," Bow said. "Listen, I got to run, I'm speaking at a thing down the street. It was good to see you, hope to catch up soon!"

Bow was already backing up from the window and Adora put on her best fake smile as she said, "Of course, great to see you, looking forward to hearing from you!"

Bow gave a friendly wave and crossed the road to the sidewalk. Adora quickly rolled her window up and pulled out onto the road. Bow waved again as she passed him and she waved quickly before doing her best not to look at the crowd as she passed the little cafe again. She knew she saw Catra that time, her big mass of curly hair was pulled back into a ponytail and Adora couldn't forget that hair and the amount of times she'd played with it at camp. She almost ran the stop sign in her haste to be out and away.

It was 7:30 when she got home and she didn't turn on any lights as she went into the kitchen and grabbed a few things before she went onto the covered back patio. It was her favorite part of the house, sunken just a little and looking out over the backyard. Daniel liked gardening and Adora looked at the trellis he'd built for some grapes just a few weeks before and the plowed area that he'd already planted seeds into. He'd even planted a few fruit trees back by the fence when they'd first moved in and he was excited because the two plum trees were already showing promise of a second crop and the apple trees, which had been worrying him as they hadn't fruited when he expected, were starting to blossom.

That was where Daniel found Adora about forty-five minutes later, sitting on the back porch in the dark with a glass of white wine that her mother favored, and she kept in the house for her visits, in her hand.

“You alright?” he asked as he sat down beside her. He looked at the half eaten cheese, sausage, and crackers at her elbow sitting next to the wine bottle. “You didn’t have this for dinner did you?”

“I’m fine,” Adora said as she took a sip of the wine, still looking into the backyard.

Daniel looked at her for a moment before opening a small square table sitting between them that doubled as storage and pulling out a small oil lamp. He busied himself with putting a bit of oil in, setting the wick to the right height, and then lighting it before setting it on the little wrought iron coffee table in front of them. Adora felt a bit annoyed at first, she’d been enjoying the dark, but the soft glow of the lamp did turn the back patio from grim to gentle in a beat.

“You want me to make you something?” Daniel asked.

“I’m alright,” Adora said.

“You’re in a mood again,” Daniel said with a kind smile. “Did your thing not go well tonight?”

Adora wanted to tell him just where she had gone, why she’d gone, and how it had gone but she just shook her head as she said, “Talked myself out of going. Just didn’t feel like it.”

“What was it?” Daniel said.

“Just a church thing I heard about,” Adora said. She felt Daniel looking at her and found she didn’t actually care very much if he tried to find out more. However, he just nodded.

“Probably for the best,” Daniel said. “You’ve been stressed about your mom coming after all, you probably needed a quiet evening.”

Adora drank the last of the wine in her glass, poured another from the bottle, and said, “Probably.”

“My evening ended up being boring,” Daniel said. “Director had said that a big request might be coming down but nothing ever came of it. I stayed late anyway, did some cleanup on stuff, and headed out. I hit Tucker’s Tacos for dinner. I wish I’d have known, I’d have brought you some.”

Adora felt herself go very still. Tucker’s Tacos was a little place not too far from where she’d been that evening. She tried to think if she’d gone past there but then realized she was being silly. There was no way Daniel had been there at the same time as she had been in the area and the chances he’d see her in traffic was even less.

“It’s alright,” Adora said. “I made a sandwich earlier.”

Daniel nodded as he picked up the salami and sliced a little off it with the paring knife Adora had brought out. He busied himself for a moment as he went on to get some cheese and cracker together before taking a bite.

"That's good," Daniel said. "Is that new salami?"

Adora shrugged as she said, "I think so. I can't remember."

Daniel looked at the label, nodded in satisfaction, and said, "It is. We'll have to get more, I like this better than our usual."

Adora finally turned to look at him. She'd told Bow he was a good man and he was a good man. She hadn't really dated in college but when she'd met him it'd been easy, well, easier, to date him because he hadn't seemed to expect much. She'd kissed him on their third date and felt about as much passion as kissing a friend. On their wedding night, when she'd done what her mother had referred to as her wifely duty, it'd been very blah and it hadn't occurred very often after that but he'd never really complained. Living with him was now like living with a good friend.

"You got that look," Daniel said.

"What look?" Adora replied.

“That look like you’ve been thinking a lot about stuff you won’t talk about,” Daniel said, which was their little way of mentioning Adora’s past.

“I’ve got a look?” Adora said, shuffling a smile onto her face to disarm the situation.

Daniel nodded as he picked up the wine bottle and took a drink straight from it as he said, “Yeah, you do and now you’ve got the smile you use when you try and lighten the mood or change the subject. You do it around your mother a lot.”

Adora wasn’t sure what to say so she just took a sip, that turned into a gulp, of her wine.

“Listen, I just… I don’t want to push you,” Daniel said. “You want to talk about it, let’s talk about it. You want to sit on the back patio and drink some wine, well, that’s what we’re already doing. In your own time, ok?”

Adora nodded, feeling a bit choked up as the thought occurred that she didn’t deserve any kindness, as she managed to say, “OK, I can do that.”

“It’s going to be alright, whatever happens,” Daniel said as he briefly laid his hand on Adora’s hand before standing up. “I’m going to go and make you something hot, alright?”

“Alright,” Adora said.

Later that night, after polishing off the bottle and chasing it with some soup Daniel had warmed up, Adora sat down at the computer and brought up Facebook again to be met with three new notifications. One was a friend request from Bow, one was a like on an older picture from Catra, and one was a message from Catra.

Chapter End Notes

I don't have much to say except, like the rest of Camp Bright Moon, that the coffee shop (honestly, the whole area around it) is based on an area I know well and in fact see every day of my life. The one I know doesn't have a giant coffee bean on top but it does have a giant coffee mug with coffee sloshing out of it and the shape of the brown coffee looks like, well, poo. It's quite amusing. As always, thank you for reading and I hope you enjoy this!

When the Musics Over Timeline

Chapter Summary

Adora wonders what to do next, unsure of her motivation even while her anger keeps popping up.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next morning, Adora cleaned up the best she could. She sent a message to Glimmer and Bow so they'd know she was alright and went out into the town to buy a few things she was lacking, which was everything. As she went to the stores wrapped up in the sweater and anorak that she'd received the night before, she couldn't help but think of Sally. She had a little smile on her face for a moment that immediately turned to a frown. It'd been a good night, better than she'd had in a long time, and she found herself thinking of Catra and all the problems she felt like she had because of their relationship. She'd been to therapy and had been told over and over to not just casually place all the blame on her problems with Catra but at the moment, she didn't care. It was Catra's fault she'd lived in misery for years and by all she held dear, Adora was going to blame Catra for everything on that bright, cold morning.

"Saw you last night at the festival with Sally," the last shop owner said as they put the shampoo and soap Adora had bought into a paper bag. "New to town?"

Adora took a little happiness in not immediately being recognized but it died as she thought of why that was so, because she'd been

out of the public eye after her disastrous breakup with Catra. She still showed up to Princess Council events and the yearly thing with Half Moon that had started the trip she was on to begin with but other than that, she was just Adora, a thing she'd wanted from the end of the war but had never been able to get. Now she had it and she found herself being angry and she had to admit it was because it wasn't on her terms.

"You alright?" the shop owner asked and Adora realized she'd been scowling as they'd been holding out the paper bag to her. "Did you need something else?"

"Sorry, no," Adora said, putting on an apologetic smile. "Got to thinking about something."

"I know how that goes," the shop owner said.

Adora nodded agreement and thanked the shop owner before heading out. She went back to her room and dumped everything she'd bought out on the bed and opened up the small plastic suitcase she'd bought to hold everything. She focused on packing her bag and found the anger slipping away as she worked to make sure that each thing fit perfectly into the suitcase. When she put the bottle of shampoo perfectly into the little cavity she'd left for it and saw the rest of the suitcase was perfectly packed, with no wasted space, she smiled as she closed it without effort and smoothly latched it shut. Then it fell on her that, having packed, she had no real reason to stay there.

Adora sat down on the bed, hard enough to bounce the suitcase a little, and sighed. She was thinking about how just the day before, she'd been in Plumeria, doing nothing more than thinking about meeting with Half Moon. Then she'd been reminded by the photo in Bow's data pad of Catra and she'd heard about how they'd almost found her up in the Northern Reach, and she'd just been so angry. Catra hated the cold, hated the dark, and had refused to move to Moraine more than once even though Adora had pushed for it. To hear that she'd willingly moved to somewhere even more cold and remote had just set something off in her.

Now things had changed. She realized she wasn't entirely sure where the little town Bow had mentioned was located. She'd been on a date, and she had to admit it'd been a great time, and now she was sitting in a little room, alternating between angry, sad, and curious. She set her hand on the suitcase and wondered what she should do.

The sensible part of her knew she should just get up and go home. She knew no one was going to be mad at her for taking off, although she might have to make a bit of an apology to Queen U'Tria for ducking out early but she doubted it. She could be back in Mystacor by evening and soaking in the hot springs to take away her tension shortly after that. She could have a nice breakfast with Castaspella and Juliet, who'd both no doubt give her kind, although blunt, advice, and she'd start over again.

Then she looked down at the mittens she'd got last night, thought of what it was like to have an actual good time, to not think about the past for even a moment, and found herself angry again that having that happen to her was just one more example of how screwed up her life had become. A few minutes later, she'd checked out of her room and was walking towards the airport.

Once there she looked over maps and charts, a little disappointed that Sally wasn't there at the moment but she pushed that down because it was the last thing she needed to think about at the moment. After taking a moment to send another message to Glimmer and Bow, she headed for her skiff. She stowed her suitcase away in one of the small cargo holds before beginning the pre-flight of the skiff.

Once she was done, she turned it on. Nothing happened. The engine didn't turn over at all and Adora sighed as a small bit of her old Horde training came floating back to her about temperature tolerances and how the engines had to be adjusted. She had her head under the engine cowling when Sally walked up to her.

"Heard you were about to head out," she said as Adora pulled her head back out.

"Yeah," Adora said, shuffling her feet on the tarmac under her as she found she was having trouble meeting Sally's eyes. "I've got something I have to go and do."

"I understand," Sally said. "You don't have to be awkward about last night."

"Oh, I'm not!" Adora said, even though she knew it was an obvious lie. "Just, um, you know, I was into getting this engine started and it's taking me a moment to get caught up."

“Starter coils had to be adjusted, didn’t they?” Sally said with a knowing head nod.

Adora nodded back to her as she said, “Yeah, the primary one did. I was checking the main batteries when you walked up, you know, make sure they weren’t having issues with the cold.”

“Not bad,” Sally said. “They shouldn’t though. If there’s one thing you can say about those old Horde designs, it’s that they did make some of the parts rugged enough to take being dropped off a cliff.”

Adora gave a little laugh as she said, “And a lot of the old stuff still looks like it was.”

Sally chuckled back at her before going quiet for a second. Then she spoke up, “Listen, I don’t know what’s really going on with you but I’d like to stay in touch. If it’s just as friends, that’s fine.”

Adora leaned back against the side of the skiff as the conversation just went right to where she didn’t really want it to go. She almost made a joke out of it, then she almost dodged the question, and then she surprised herself and just said the truth.

“Listen, I don’t know if I’m ever going to be in a relationship again and I don’t know what you might have heard about my breakup, but it was ugly and I’m still dealing with it and I know that’s stupid,” Adora said in one long rush. “To top it off, the reason I’m

up here is because I'm looking for my ex and I don't know really understand *why* because it's not like I want to fucking get back together and this wasn't planned out at all and like, I do think any other time we could have maybe have gone somewhere…"

Adora just felt the sentence trickle off to nothing and Sally shrugged as she said, "That's why I said friends. You're fun to be around but I get what you're saying. Life can be a damn mess sometimes and you're obviously going through it right now. I'll tell you what, if I hear back from you, then I hear back from you, friends or otherwise, alright? No pressure."

Adora felt a little relieved as she said, "Alright, no pressure, I appreciate that."

"You headed up soon?" Sally said, nodding towards the sky.

Adora nodded as she shut and sealed the engine back up.

"I was just about to when you showed up," Adora said.

"Batteries checked out then?" Sally said.

"Yeah," Adora replied. "I was honestly just kind of sitting there thinking and poking at stuff."

Sally laughed a little and then it went quiet. A little bit of snow blew past their feet and Adora wasn't sure what to do. She felt like that a lot since the breakup, even though it was years in the past now, that sense that she didn't quite have a handle on anything and didn't know where to go. She remembered the day she'd left the Fright Zone to go back to the Whispering Woods. She'd felt so confident then, in a way she didn't now that she was older. She'd made huge decisions back then and they'd seemed to just flow from her, right or wrong, it hadn't seemed to stop her. She didn't know why she couldn't do that now. She always second guessed herself and now she wondered if that was just because she was older. Not necessarily wiser either, just older with more experience and more knowledge of what happened when things were done a little too decisively sometimes.

"I better…," Adora started to say at the same time that Sally said, "I think…," and then they both laughed, tried to tell the other to go on and then they both spoke again and laughed before Sally put a hand over her own mouth and gestured at Adora.

"I was just going to say I'm going to go ahead and head out," Adora said.

"I was going to say I think I better leave you to it and I hope to hear from you again," Sally said.

Adora nodded and then stepped forward, surprising herself as she hugged Sally in a big bear hug. Sally froze for a second before hugging her back.

“Right, Bright Mooner,” Sally said with a chuckle as they stepped back.

“And what’s that supposed to mean?” Adora said with a laugh as she got up on the skiff.

“You’re huggers,” Sally said.

“What do you mean? Everyone enjoys a good hug,” Adora said.

“Yeah, but Bright Mooners take it a bit further,” Sally said. “I’m not complaining mind you, just making an observation. Safe skies to you.”

Adora gave a little salute back to her as she said, “Thanks.”

Sally backed up and Adora fired the skiff up, satisfied to hear the hum of the engine strong and true. She worked the controls and was soon flying off and away towards the town she’d identified on the charts that morning. She let her mind just go neutral and concentrate on the flight, a little bobbing nod of her head in time to the thrum of the engine the only continuous movement.

Adora felt the cold as she flew and it just got worse the further she went. She took a moment to pull the hood up and fasten it tight, so only her eyes showed but even after a while that didn’t help much. She had dark glasses on to protect against the bright

light coming off the snow but even then, the cold wind was slipping around the edges, causing her eyes to water. She checked the navigation system on the skiff and saw that she still had hours to go before she was at her destination but she did see a small village out in the middle of nowhere coming up on her navigation and hoped they'd at least have some goggles as she headed towards a landing.

The airport in the village consisted of a slab of heated concrete to keep the snow and ice off of it with a squat, half-buried building sitting next to it. Adora brought the skiff in for a landing as close to the building as she could and sighed a little with relief as the forward motion of the skiff stopped and the wind went from biting to manageable as she climbed down off of the skiff and headed towards the building.

The squat building was painted in bright colors, mostly yellows and reds with some green highlights peeking here and there, and she could smell something cooking as she got closer. She went down the short ramp, flanked on either side by towering snow drifts, and through the doors into what seemed to be the whole tiny village gathered into one big bright room.

At first she thought she'd stepped into a festival but then she realized it was just people hanging out. On the other side of the room, there was a little diner counter and a grouping of tables with a low wall delineating the eating area from the simply hanging out area. The hanging out area had old couches and chairs sitting around and up against the walls were a few booths selling various items, mostly aimed at travelers, Adora noticed.

About half the people in the room turned briefly to see who had come in and when they saw it wasn't someone they recognized, went back to their conversations, though not without the occasional subtle peek. One woman who was sitting by the door as Adora took her glasses off and dropped her hood greeted her and said, "Passing through?"

"I am," Adora said. "I stopped to see if I could find some goggles."

The woman nodded as she said, "You're not the first one to try coming up here with just glasses. I'd grab a stocking cap too while you're at it and maybe a scarf. Try Pingin over there, she should have something."

The woman pointed and Adora saw a woman dressed in black and white sitting on a stool chatting with someone. Adora thanked the woman who'd helped her and made her way over to Pingin.

"Yeah, it's just been too warm for the glacier cherries," a man standing and talking to Pingin said as Adora walked up. "They'll still be alright but it's not going to be top notch this year it looks like."

"It's not too warm," Pingin said with a shake of her head. "I'm telling you, it's that fertilizer mix you're using. They changed up the formula on you."

“Naw, it’s not that,” the guy said before glancing sideways and seeing Adora standing quietly off to the side. “You need me?”

Adora shook her head as she said, “No, I was needing a few things from here.”

“OK, I’ll leave you to it,” the man said with a little nod at Pingin.

“Fertilizer, I’m telling you,” Pingin said as the man walked off. Then she turned to Adora, her pear shaped frame shifting on the stool to focus on Adora. “You’re new. What can I do for you?”

“I’m flying through and I was told you had some goggles. I guess I should also get a stocking cap and a scarf,” Adora replied.

Pingin nodded as she turned around and started plucking stuff off of shelves.

“Can do. What brings you up here? Not a lot around us, we’re a bit off the beaten path,” Pingin said as she sat a matching scarf and stocking cap on the tiny table next to her that served as a counter. “Not that I’m being nosy, just making conversation, you know how it is.”

“I’m just seeing the sights,” Adora said.

Pingin looked over at Adora for a moment, the lie obvious as it wasn't as if the snow fields and hills outside were particularly noted for their sightseeing qualities, before shrugging.

"Understood," she said, before putting a set of goggles with a little pack of different colored lenses down next to it. "I think this should do you. You know how the colors work?"

Pingin pointed at the lenses and Adora just shook her head.

"OK, if it's bright, you want that set right there, the mirrored ones, it'll cut the light for you just fine. You can use the clear ones for most stuff but if you want a bit more contrast, use the green if it's just kinda cloudy but if it's really cloudy, use the amber ones. Personally, I use the mirrored or amber unless it's actually night and then I just use the clear. Want me to pop one of them in for you?"

"Thanks, yeah, the amber if you don't mind," Adora said.

Pingin nodded as she started changing out the lenses and said, "And if you're going north of here, you might want to leave a detailed travel plan in the computer over there."

Adora had draped the scarf over her and shoved the stocking cap into her anorak's front pocket before looking over to see an old computer terminal in a little kiosk by the door.

"Why?"

"Because you know what's north of here?" Pingin asked. Adora shook her head. "Nothing. A whole lot of nothing in a lot of directions in fact. If you don't show up to where you're going, it helps when the SAR teams come through looking to know where you had planned to go."

Adora was nodding her head as she said, "Ah, gotcha. That makes sense, it makes it easier for the rescue."

Pingin got real quiet for a moment before she said, "That too."

"What do you mean?" Adora said as Pingin handed Adora the goggles.

Pingin shifted a little awkwardly as she said, "Well, normally, if a SAR team is in here trying to find a travel plan that they didn't already have, they've kind of given up on rescue at that point."

Adora immediately understood what she meant as she said, "I'll file. I'll send one to friends as well."

"Good," Pingin said. "You're being super mysterious about your traveling so I just thought I should mention it, just in case."

“It’s just a personal thing,” Adora said.

“Nah, I understand, I don’t need to know. We get a lot of people who come up here who don’t want to talk about themselves or their past,” Pingin said. “I didn’t want to pry but I did want to be helpful.”

“Really? That’s a thing?” Adora said. “Lots of people flee up here?”

Pingin nodded as she said, “Yep. This town was founded by ex-Horde soldiers who just wanted a place to themselves. Didn’t last long, there was a brief spike in people living here shortly afterwards and it never really changed but yeah, nothing like the Kingdom of Snows to disappear into if that’s what you’re inclined to do.”

Adora bit back the angry comment she almost made as she said, “I can see that.”

Pingin didn’t pick up on the tension though as she nodded at the little diner and said, “Yep, in fact the cook of our diner is like that. She’s a Magicat, super quiet about where she comes from but she’s a damn good cook though. Nothing fancy but then, we’re not fancy people. Hot and filling is the answer.”

Adora froze. There was no way. It couldn't be her but why couldn't it be Catra? Adora remembered Catra trying to learn to cook after the war and how she'd been alright at it, definitely the better of the both of them at cooking, and she must have frozen in place because Pingin waved a hand in front of her.

"You alright?" Pingin said.

"Uh, yeah, sorry," Adora said with an awkward smile as she quickly laid some coins on the little table and tucked the goggles away. "I think I need to eat something. My day started early and I haven't eaten in a while so I think I'm going to go and get some of that food."

"Sure thing," Pingin said as she raked the coins off the counter. "Take care."

Adora responded back, not even sure what she said but hoping it was at least coherent, as she headed through the room to the diner. She felt her heart thumping hard as she went through the opening in the low wall. It reminded her of the gate at the home Catra and Adora had lived in when their relationship had blown apart. The opening through the low wall at the house had a gate on it and a nice little arch over it but the gate had never been closed. Adora had always said that it was because they were always open for whoever might need them and that thought was in her head as she made her way up to the counter and sat down at an empty seat.

The food options were on a screen over the little window that went back to the kitchen and Adora looked at them but found she couldn't even focus enough to read them as she kept glancing back into the kitchen, wondering if she was going to catch a glimpse of Catra at any moment. Then she saw the cook and for a moment, felt like she was going to throw up as she saw the ears poking out from around a hairnet holding back the mane. Then Adora realized that it wasn't Catra and felt stupid for even thinking it might be Catra because the woman on the grill had snow white fur which Adora recognized as one of the small group of secretive Magicats that lived in the Kingdom of Snows.

Adora was starting to chuckle to herself as she felt the tension leave her body. She couldn't believe she thought Catra would be just right there behind the counter, easy as that. Adora turned her face to the menu to see if she could figure out something to eat as she realized she actually was hungry. She was focused on the menu when the server came up to her.

"Hey, what can I get you?"

Adora turned to her to tell her she wanted a bowl of the stew and maybe half a sandwich and found the words die in her mouth as she locked eyes with Catra standing on the other side of the counter, notepad in hand.

Chapter End Notes

> I realized I'm kind of a sucker for having a person go on a quest with big plans of how to do something and then have them stumble over their objective when they least expect it. I've done this several times. That and the fake death trope is probably one of my more used tropes. Also, I love the idea of snow white Magicats, like snow leopards.

Bright Moon Timeline

Chapter Summary

Adora goes down into the Crystal Castle, chasing the phantom voice she's been hearing all day.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Crystal Castle was, if anything, more ominous inside than it had been during the war. No one ever really came out to the place and the vines had grown into the open doorway and leaves had blown a considerable distance down the hallway. Capella looked around in casual interest as she walked along beside Adora.

Adora though, she wasn't looking around much. She knew where she was going, like she was being led, and she thought of how some of the biggest moments in her life had taken place inside of the place. Memories flitted through her head, each one seeming so important for the seconds it was in her mind before being shoved aside by another memory. When she got a little further in, she stopped for a moment. Capella didn't notice at first and walked a few paces past Adora before stopping and turning around.

"You alright?" Capella asked.

"I should probably warn you, this place can show you things," Adora said.

“What?”

“It can show you things. I’ve seen things in here, things that were my biggest wishes and fears, and I thought you should know that,” Adora replied.

Capella looked at Adora for a moment before she said, “Are you serious? You’re messing with me, right?”

“I’m not kidding,” Adora said. “In fact, the more I think about it, the more you probably shouldn't go any further with me.”

“Oh, please,” Capella said. “You know me better than that. You think I’m *not* going to follow along now? If that was you lying to me to try and keep me from going with you, you should have picked a better lie. You should have said something like giant spiders were going to come out of the walls or something. Now come on!”

Capella took a few steps backwards as Adora shook her head as she said, “I’m not messing with you, don’t say I didn’t warn you, and there’s no giant spiders. Not anymore.”

Adora walked past Capella, who stood there for a moment before hurrying up to Adora.

“What do you mean, not anymore?”

“Just what I said,” Adora replied. “Not anymore.”

“There used to be giant spiders in here?” Capella said, looking around anxiously.

“Yeah,” Adora said. “They were guardians put here by the First Ones.”

“Come on,” Capella said. “You’re not really serious are you?”

“Listen, I know you’re probably going to come no matter what, and you were the one who made the mention of giant spiders, but yes, I’m absolutely serious,” Adora said. “As far as I know, most of the defenses went offline when the Heart was destroyed. If I thought they hadn’t, I’d refuse to bring you in at all.”

Capella was silent for a few more steps before she said, “Alright, but you better go all She-Ra and protect me if any show up.”

Adora gave a little mirthless smile as she said, “Naw, I just thought I’d let you get dragged away.”

“That’s not funny, Mom,” Capella said.

Adora just gave her a smile as she kept walking.

Half an hour later, Adora was beginning to wonder if she really knew where anything was in the place. She felt like she'd been walking forever and everything was starting to look the same.

"Are we lost?" Capella said. "Because I swear I've seen this corridor before."

"They all look alike," Adora said. "And no, we're not lost."

"I swear if you say just turned around a little, I'm going to scream," Capella said.

"We're just turned around a little," Adora said and then jumped when Capella screamed. "Are you alright!?"

"I told you what would happen," Capella said. "I had to follow through."

"I swear, I can see Glimmer in you every time you do something like that," Adora said as she held a hand over her heart as she took a deep breath.

“Mom says the same thing about you when I do something a bit, shall we say, unorthodox,” Capella said with a laugh.

“You can just say stupid,” Adora said with a laugh. “I know, she’s told me. I don’t necessarily disagree with her either most of the time.”

They both stood there for a moment as Adora looked around. Capella spoke up after a minute.

“So, we turning around or are we just going to stand here?” Capella said.

“I’m saying we’re going to just stand here,” Adora said. “We’ll just become unmoving statutes.”

Capella rolled her eyes as she said, “Very funny.”

“I’m just saying,” Adora said.

“I know you are,” Capella said. “I just wish you’d make up your mind.”

“Hey, there’s no call for that,” Adora replied. “That was kind of crappy.”

“No, I don’t know how to get out? Why would you ask me that?” Capella said.

“What? I didn’t ask you that,” Adora said.

“I’ve been following you,” Capella said. “I mean, I could teleport us, maybe. How far down are we?”

“No, don’t do that,” Adora said. “We can walk out, it’ll be fine, really.”

“What do you mean you don’t know,” Capella said.

“What? Are you alright?” Adora said as she stepped up to Capella.

“I’m fine,” Capella said, giving her a weird look. “I could ask you the same thing. You’ve just been standing there ignoring my questions.”

Adora froze in place as she thought.

“Mom?” Capella said.

“I haven’t said anything to you before I asked if you were alright?” Adora said.

“No,” Capella said, her face suddenly worried and a little scared.

“I’ve been talking this whole time,” Adora said. “It’s happening.”

“What’s happening? Oh, that,” Capella said. “So you really weren’t kidding.”

“I told you I wasn’t,” Adora said.

“So… now what?” Capella asked.

“Maybe now we leave,” Adora said.

“You’re going to leave me again?”

“No, I’m not going to leave you, we’re both leaving, and what do you mean again?” Adora answered the barely audible question, wondering why Capella sounded so scared.

“I, um, didn’t say anything,” Capella said, her eyes going wider.

“Don’t leave me again.”

“Do you hear that?” Adora said, suddenly realizing the voice wasn’t Capella.

Capella just shook her head.

Adora moved down the hall a little, in the direction she thought it had come from, and stopped after about twenty feet to listen. Capella was right behind her, so close that Adora swore she could feel her.

“Are you there?”

It was Catra. Adora knew it was Catra. She could hear it plain and clear and then she almost jumped out of her skin when Capella whispered in her ear, “I think I heard it that time. What is that?”

“I, uh, I think that’s Catra,” Adora said.

“What!?” Capella said, her surprised voice echoing back to them in a way sound hadn’t been doing just a moment before. Capella suddenly whispered. “Really?”

“I think I’ve been hearing her all day,” Adora said. “I just had this urge to come here and see the last place she was and…”

“And?”

“And I don’t know!” Adora said.

“I didn’t say anything, Mom,” Capella said and Adora felt her right up on her, shaking a little.

“It’s alright,” Adora said, turning a little to put an arm around Capella before she spoke up. She used her old command voice she’d trained so hard to perfect when she thought the big thing in life was to get to be a Force Captain. It was loud and clear as she said, “Who’s there!?”

“Don’t call them over here!” Capella whispered as Adora’s voice echoed a little. Adora hugged her a little closer and made a gentle shush noise followed by a shush noise from down the hall.

“OK, something is going on,” Adora said as she started to walk forward, only to be stopped by Capella holding on to her shirt. “It’s alright. If it’s just the computer, it’s just going to be sad. If it’s her though, I need to know.”

“And what if it’s something else?” Capella said.

“What else could it be?” Adora replied.

“I don’t know and *that’s the problem!”* Capella desperately whispered.

“I am still She-Ra you know,” Adora said as she took Capella’s hand in her own, removing it from her shirt.

“Listen, you don’t know what’s down there, you haven’t been in a fight since before I was born, and I really don’t want you to go,” Capella said. “Please, let’s go or at least let's go get Mom and Dad, alright?”

“I’m only going to go a bit further, alright?” Adora said. “You can watch me, I won’t go out of sight.”

“I…,” Capella started to say before just shaking her head. “Damn it, fine. Don’t go out of sight though.”

“I promise, I won’t,” Adora said as she let go of Capella and started walking backwards.

“I’m serious,” Capella said. “No word games on this. Just a little further and then right back.”

Adora grinned as she said, “Ah, it’s like your teenage years again except you’re saying my lines.”

Capella didn’t grin back though or respond. Eventually Adora turned around and Capella watched her start to walk.

And walk.

And walk.

And walk.

After a few minutes, Capella called out to her but Adora just kept going.

Then Capella screamed at her.

Adora just kept going.

Capella teleported and when she appeared where she thought Adora should have been, she was gone.

Adora meanwhile was walking what she thought was a straight path. When she turned around to look over her shoulder, she saw Capella sitting down on the ground, leaning back against the curved walls watching her. She waved at her and Capella waved back with a smile.

After that, Adora didn't turn around for a while when she suddenly realized she'd been walking for a bit. When she turned around this time, she saw that Capella was gone and where there had been a straight hall behind her, it was now a curve.

"Capella!" Adora shouted but got nothing in return. She started back at a run when she heard Catra right behind her.

"Adora, don't leave, please don't leave, come get me, please."

Adora skidded to a stop and turned around. Nothing was there but she heard Catra again.

"Come back, please come back."

"Capella! If you can hear me I'm going to The Heart! Can you hear me!?" Adora shouted.

She waited a moment but heard nothing and started running back down into the Crystal Castle. As she ran, things started to shimmer and soon she was running through moments from her life, moments from what she realized could have been her life, and moments that she didn't recognize at all. She saw herself standing in some low ceiling room full of people and Catra was there behind a diner counter. She saw herself in a bedroom she didn't recognize, sitting in front of a screen that it took Adora a moment to realize was some kind of data pad and she was crying as she tried to type. She remembered being married to Catra and Catra running off because she drank too much and not knowing where she'd been. She saw a blonde Magicat child hugging her and Catra and calling them Mom and Mother as they told the two of them about how much they loved the two of them but they were moving out to go to Dryl for some reason Adora missed.

Adora saw all that and more. She saw herself older than she was now, younger than she was now and every moment seemed to be something that could have been, should have been, may have been, would have been, and all of those mixed together. It was like trying to stand above an impossibly large woven carpet and trying to follow each individual thread all at once.

When Adora ran through the place where Shadow Weaver had died, for a split second she thought of her as Sharon Weaver, her mother who died of cancer almost all alone, and Adora shook her head, not understanding what was going on. She saw Shadow Weaver dying in a huge firestorm she created as she fought the First Ones guardian and Adora was confused because she remembered the guardian killing Shadow Weaver before the guardian fell to Adora's sword as Adora coughed up green glowing ichor from its poison. Adora kept running, as she realized that had never happened, at least to her in the here and now, and watched

as Shadow Weaver sacrificed herself in that firestorm but it felt like it had been forever since she had ever thought of anything like that.

Adora didn’t realize when she ran into the room where The Heart had been at first but she slowed down and looked around, finally coming to a stop on the spot she’d last seen Catra. She remembered being there when Catra had died, the room enormous and full of light and noise, but everything had seemed real, in some cases almost too real. Now it didn’t seem real. Nothing seemed real. Everything felt like a fog in the dim room. Adora thought for a moment that any other place that was like that, she might be a little scared, maybe even a lot scared, but now, it just seemed peaceful.

Then she felt a hand on her shoulder.

“Hey, Adora.”

Chapter End Notes

I'm kind of liking this update schedule. Since I wasn't rushing to meet a deadline, I felt like I got this one edited much better. I'd have preferred to have had this up a bit quicker but such is life. We're getting towards an end game now though so I'm looking forward to pushing this forward a bit quicker now that Betrayal and Trust is done. Thank you for reading!

Crossfading

Chapter Summary

> Crossfading is an audio editing technique that makes a smooth transition between audio tracks to fill the silence between multiple tracks.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"What are you doing here!?" Catra said. The whole cafe quieted down, which caused the rest of the room to look over to see why the cafe was quiet, which caused them to quiet down, and in a moment, the whole room was silent as Adora looked at Catra behind the counter.

"I saw you tonight," Catra's message read and Adora felt tears in her eyes as she read on. "You were sitting in your car down the street from the Cracked Cup. What the fuck were you doing there? It's not like that's the kind of neighborhood you'd normally be in so I know you weren't just lost like you told Bow. I can't believe you'd show up after all this time. Where you some protest against us fags and no one else showed up? Are you fucking stalking me? You need to cut this shit out, whatever it is, I don't want you back in my life after what you fucking did. You were just a teenage mistake, so get fucked and LEAVE ME ALONE."

"Looking for you, that's what I'm doing here," Adora replied back to Catra. "Where have you been!?"

Adora tried to type out a response, her hands shaking as she cried, but nothing seemed to gel in her head as to what to say or even if she should say anything. She knew Daniel would probably be coming into the room soon and find her crying in front of the computer but she just couldn't find it in herself to care.

"Where have I been?! Why do you care! You sure as shit didn't when you left me for… for her!" Catra shouted back at her.

"What is this?" Adora asked, scared to turn around as she reached up and felt the warm hand on her shoulder. "Is it really you?"

"Where have I been!? What a bullshit question that is," Catra said. "You don't care now, you didn't care then, and it's pretty damn obvious. Oh, get that damn look off your face or are you worried this little argument is going to sully your precious reputation, Princess?"

"I'm not stalking you," Adora managed to type. "I don't know why I was there. I wasn't trying to start a problem, I just wanted to go there but I knew it was a mistake, that's why I was sitting in my car. I didn't intend for Bow to see me. I didn't ever want to hurt you, I just wanted to do the right thing. I'm so sorry."

"It's really me," Catra said and Adora felt the hand slip into her own. She was still too scared to turn around. She didn't know what was behind her. She wished she'd brought Glimmer and Bow with her. She wished she'd never come down into the castle. She wished she'd done anything but what she was doing at that moment but she wished harder to not be anywhere else.

“Can we go outside?” Adora asked.

Adora stared at the computer as she wiped at her eyes with her sleeve.

Adora felt the hand in her hand.

Catra was in front of her.

Catra was behind her.

Catra was on the screen.

As these happened, Adora was united in not knowing just what to do as she tried to get through it all. She tried to think of what to say, how to say it, how to make things right, how to make things right and stay true to her anger, and how to make things right when she believed she’d been the cause of everything that had gone wrong.

“No, we can’t go outside, I have nothing to fucking say to you,” Catra said. “You need to get out or I’m going to throw you out.”

“Adora, why are you crying?” Daniel said as he stopped in the door to the bedroom.

“You’re dead,” Adora said.

“I don’t know what I am,” Catra said.

“Catra, I need to talk with you about this,” Adora said. “Can we not do it in front of a crowd, please?”

Adora looked down at the computer screen and the message she had been trying to write, trying to figure out what to say to two people now, one who was furious at her and one who she knew was about to be furious at her.

Adora turned around, not having the courage to look up, but then she felt a knuckle under her chin, raising her chin up. It was Catra but Adora couldn’t figure out what was going on at first until she realized it was Catra but it was Catra the same age as the last time Adora saw her decades before.

It’s just Catra as a trick of the castle, Adora thought.

It’s just Catra trying to get the upper hand by embarrassing me, Adora thought.

It's just Catra having the worst timing as usual, Adora thought.

"Why are you staring at me? What, you want a kiss?" Catra said.

"Do you need a hug?" Daniel said.

"Do you not recognize me?" Catra said.

"I don't want a kiss, I want some answers," Adora said, the anger in her boiling up.

"I don't need a hug," Adora snapped at Daniel.

"You still look just the same," Adora said. "Just like my memories."

"What? You got some memory you made up you need to justify?" Catra said.

"What's going on?" Daniel said as he walked over to her, concern on his face and Adora realized at the last second she should have closed the browser as he looked down at the monitor and saw the message. "What's this?"

“Adora? Do you not remember me?” Catra said.

“Well are you going to fucking answer me or just stare at me?” Catra said.

“I need a moment,” Adora said, three times, three different ways, in three different beings, and then went still.

Chapter End Notes

This. This is what I was worried about doing. I had an idea of something like this way back when I started this fic and I had no idea if I could make it work. I’ll say that this took some serious effort on my part because I had to keep three story lines in my head as I did the dialogue and I’m here to tell you, I have never been happier that I didn’t do more story lines like I had planned then I was when trying to write just three. This is a short chapter but it also probably took me at least as much effort as any other chapter in this one. This also isn't the end. As always, thank you for reading, thank you for commenting, and I hope you enjoyed this one.

Fade Into You

Chapter Summary

Adora carries on the conversations.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Stillness. It's a blessing sometimes. A still moment sitting on a bench in a park and watching ducks quietly paddle around on a pond can be a thing a person remembers for the rest of their life. A still moment in the kitchen in the early morning looking through the steam of a mug of coffee at the love of your life leaned back in a chair and scrolling through their phone can affirm an entire life.

Then there's the stillness when it feels like the whole world is holding its breath, waiting for the sky to fall in. That was the stillness Adora was in now and to break it felt like she'd shatter along with the silence but she knew it had to be done.

"I… well, I just…," Adora started to say, not sure how she was going to answer Daniel. She didn't want to lie to him but she didn't want to tell him the truth either.

Daniel knelt down by Adora's desk and held his hand out as he said, "Hey, take a moment, deep breath, whatever is going on, we'll get through it, together, like we have before."

Adora didn’t reach out to him and after a moment, he took his hand back, his face confused, as she said, “I don’t know what to say.”

“I don't know what to say,” Adora said, looking Catra in the face, as the rest of the room in the bowels of the Crystal Castle seemed to fade away.

“You're at a loss for words? Should I make a note of the date?” Catra said with a little grin.

“Stop,” Adora said, shaking her head. “I just… you’re…”

“I’m what?” Catra said. Adora couldn’t bring herself to speak as she tried to think of how to tell Catra she’d seen her die.

Looking at her, Adora couldn’t bring herself to speak. She felt the entire room staring at the two of them as Catra almost seemed to vibrate with anger.

“Damn it, what!? Did you really stalk me all the way up here just to stare at me like an idiot!? Say something damn it!” Catra shouted at her.

Adora felt the anger flow into her as she said, “Stalk you!? I’ve been an absolute fucking wreck for years because you fucking ran away! I said I was going away for a few days and when I got back, all your shit was gone and so were you! I couldn’t even find you and we sure as shit looked but no, you disappeared! I just found out Glimmer went looking for you because we were all worried about you but that doesn’t matter because Catra got butt hurt enough to disappear off the face of the planet!”

“Don’t act like you were coming back! You ran off to be with that sparkling little bitch! Yeah, I said it! I know what was going on between you two! I just got tired of pretending otherwise!” Catra yelled.

“We weren’t together!” Adora yelled right back. “How many years has it been and you still think that!? I’ve been living at Mystacor trying to deal with my abandonment!”

Adora realized she’d stood up and was leaning over the counter but she didn’t care. Her anger felt righteous.

After a moment Daniel reached out again to take Adora’s hand when she didn’t reach forward herself. Adora pulled her hand back, anger snapping into her like a flame suddenly puffing into life.

“Don’t,” Adora snapped. “I don’t want to be touched right now.”

Daniel stood up and took a step back as he held his hands up.

"I'm sorry, I wasn't trying to make this uncomfortable. Do you want to talk?"

"No, I don't want to talk," Adora said. "I want to forget about the stupid shit I've done in my life. I want to turn back the clock, I want a fucking do-over!" Daniel stood there in silence, not sure what to say and Adora snapped at him. "Don't you want to know what's going on!?"

"Of course I do," Daniel said quietly, looking down at his hands as he rubbed his right thumb over his left index finger in thought. "It's just… you're mad, it's obvious, I don't want to make it worse."

Adora leaned back in the chair as she felt the anger drain off and become regret. She'd never meant to hurt him. He'd always been good to her and she hated to act like this but she was at her wits end. She didn't want to hurt him more than she thought she already had and then have that to regret as well.

Adora just knew that if she spoke, she'd hurt her, more than she'd already hurt her and she knew she'd regret that. Catra was looking at her waiting on a response though, with those eyes she remembered from so long ago.

“You’re dead,” Adora finally said. “I watched you die, after we kissed.”

“I’m not dead,” Catra said. “Things have been weird these last few minutes but I’m not dead.”

“What do you mean these last few minutes?” Adora asked.

“Since we kissed,” Catra said with a little shy smile that was so out of place on her that Adora almost laughed despite everything. “I’ve felt weird and you went away but you’re back now so I guess I’ll forgive you if you kiss me again.”

Adora began to realize that if this was really Catra, she didn’t know about all the time that had passed.

“Catra, look at me,” Adora said. “What do you see?”

“What are you talking about?” Catra said.

“Just look at me,” Adora said and after a pause, she went on. “It’s been thirty years since I kissed you. I thought you were dead.”

Catra looked at Adora and she watched as Catra’s eyes went from narrowed in confusion to suddenly wide open.

“There’s… no, this is isn’t right, you were just right here!” Catra said.

“We had a funeral for you, we remember you every year on the day of Prime’s Fall, I’ve run a survey business,” Adora said and then spoke a little softer as she went on. “I’ve raised two children with Bow and Glimmer, they’re adults now.”

Catra was shaking her head as tears started down her face and Adora’s heart broke.

Adora’s heart broke as she looked at the anger on Catra’s face. Adora didn’t know it was possible to be this angry and this sad all at once as Catra said, “You moved to Mystacor with Glimmer!? Seriously!? How did you all keep that from the public!?”

“Because we’re not together,” Adora said as she sagged back down into the seat. “I don’t know what to tell you. I came looking for you because I heard that Glimmer had almost found you once and I thought I’d try and see if maybe we could settle this between us but I guess we can’t.” Adora stood up and turned her back on Catra. The rest of the room didn’t even bother to try and look away but they at least looked uncomfortable while they all looked at her. “I’m sorry you all had to see this.”

Adora started for the door, her face hot from embarrassment, when she felt a hand on her shoulder that pulled her around.

“Don’t you fucking walk away from me!” Catra said. “I’m not done talking to you!”

“We’re just shouting at each other,” Adora said. “It’s not helpful!”

“Speak for your fucking self,” Catra said. “I’ve got a lot that I’ve wanted to say to you over the years and I’m going to damn well say it!”

Adora saw over Catra’s shoulder that the other Magicat, the one on the grill, had come out of the back and was standing in front of the counter, her face grim as she watched both of them. Adora looked back at Catra as she said, “Fine, say what you want to say, I don’t care anymore.”

Catra started to speak and then shook her head as she said, “No, we’re not doing this out here. That’s what you want, to make me look like the bad guy, yet a-fucking-gain. We’re going somewhere private to talk.”

“I just suggested that,” Adora said.

“I don’t need an ‘I told you so’ right now!” Catra shouted before turning and headed back towards the diner area. Adora followed her after a moment as Catra spoke to the other Magicat. “Snowball, we’re using your office.”

“You want me along?” Snowball said, her voice low and threatening as she looked at Adora.

“No,” Catra said as she slammed into the double swinging doors to the kitchen.

Adora waited for a second before shaking her head and following.

Chapter End Notes

Not much to say here except thank you for reading!

Sound Blocks

Chapter Summary

Conversations among conversations among conversations.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Daniel looked at Adora for a moment before sighing and turning his back and heading for the bedroom door. He was out into the hall before Adora stood up and followed him.

"Daniel, wait," Adora said, holding onto the door frame as if she was trying to keep from falling off a cliff. Daniel stopped in the hallway but didn't turn around. "I… I never wanted to do this to you."

"Just tell me, please," Daniel said.

Adora found it was easier to tell him when he wasn't looking at her as she said, "I'm not over Catra. I went out tonight because I thought I was going to see her but I lost my nerve and came home. She messaged me on Facebook. That's what I was trying to answer when you came in. I know it's wrong, I know it's a sin to feel this way, I just…"

Adora took a deep breath and found she couldn't keep going as she waited for him to blow up. Her hand was gripped so tight to

the door frame it creaked a little from the strain as she waited for any reaction. There wasn't one though, not for several long breaths. Then Daniel just briefly nodded before walking down the hall to disappear into the living room and Adora just stood in the hallway, not sure what to do. She was shaking and tears were going down her face as she heard a cabinet in the kitchen open. Then she heard the refrigerator open and then close.

"Daniel?" Adora said. It was quiet for a moment and then she heard him coming back.

Daniel stopped at the end of the hallway. In the dim light of the hallway, she could see he had a large plastic cup in his hand. He took a drink from it before speaking.

"First, I'm not mad."

"What?"

"I'm not mad," Daniel said. "I… I can't… I don't what I am right now but I don't think being mad is part of it."

"I'm not cheating on you," Adora replied. "She didn't know I was even going there."

"I didn't think you were," Daniel said before taking another drink. "Can I meet her?"

Adora straightened up a little, her whole face screwed up in confusion as she said, “I’m sorry, what did you say?”

“I mean, I’m willing to talk about an arrangement,” Daniel said. “I just want to meet her is all.”

Adora had no idea what he was talking about as she said, “I don’t get it.”

“If you want to see her, we can do that,” Daniel said. “I don’t want to be involved but there’s no reason you can’t be with her if that’s what you want.”

Adora’s mouth fell open as she realized what Daniel was saying and she actually laughed a little as she said, “Daniel, I haven’t talked to her. She thinks I’m stalking her. She sent me an obscenity-filled message.” Then Adora realized what he had proposed and the late nights at work. “Wait, are you… are you seeing someone else?”

It was Daniel’s turn to look surprised as he shook his head as he said, “No.” He took a drink from his cup as he suddenly came to the same realization Adora had just jumped to. “Oh, you think because… and the late nights… and, ok, yeah, that’s a legit question. No, in fact, can we sit on the couch? I think we need to talk.”

“You want to talk, let’s talk,” Adora said, her back against the wall in a tiny little office. Catra leaned against the cluttered work surface made from a few old planks constructed across the back wall for a desk. There couldn’t have been more than four feet between the two of them. “Can I at least tell you what’s going on first?”

“No, you’re going to shut the fuck up and listen to me,” Catra said. “I don’t know what you’re doing here and I don’t care. I’ve made a life for myself after you pissed all over the one we had been trying to make for ourselves and I don’t want you in it. I would have thought disappearing would have made that clear.”

“Catra, do you have any idea what I’ve been through?” Adora said.

“No, I don’t really care. I have something up here. People don’t think of me as Catra, Force Captain, or Catra, She-Ra’s wife, they just know me as Catra, waitress and friend,” Catra said before suddenly getting angry. “But you had to come and fuck all that up! I told them I was just named that way, that it was a coincidence that it was the same and you had to come up here and fuck it all up! Why are you here!?”

“I’m trying to tell you that!” Adora said. “I keep trying to tell you but you keep stopping me!”

“Well, fucking tell me then!” Catra said.

“This is so like you!” Adora started to say but held a hand up and shook her head. “No, I’m not going to go into that. I’m up here because I was talking with Bow at the whole Half Moon thing that happens every year. He accidentally showed me an old picture and then told me that Glimmer had almost found you in some town up here. I got so pissed, I just had to come up here and see if I could find you myself.”

“So you are following me,” Catra said, a smug “I was right” look on her face.

“I’m not… fine, yes, I’m following you, because I want to know what happened to my wife!” Adora said.

“I’m not your wife anymore,” Catra said. “I saw the divorce decree.”

“Yeah, a year after you fucking left,” Adora said.

“Had to keep up appearances so…,” Catra started to say when Adora cut her off.

“I swear to Mara, if you’re about to go on about me and Glimmer, I’m going to scream and I’m going to do it as She-Ra,” Adora said. “Get it through your head! WE! ARE! NOT! TOGETHER! THERE NEVER WAS ANYTHING THERE! IT WAS YOUR DRUNKEN JEALOUSY! THAT’S IT!”

Catra leaned back a little as her claws slipped out and gouged into the top of the desk.

"Don't talk to me like that," Catra said, her voice low and threatening.

Adora took a deep breath as she lowered her voice to match.

"There wasn't anything," Adora said. "Believe what you want but I know that I didn't cheat on you."

They both jumped as there was a rough rapping on the door at Adora's back and Snowball's voice asking Catra if everything was alright.

"I'm alright," Catra said. "It's fine. We're just talking."

There was a silence for a moment and Adora said, "You said her name was Snowball."

"It's a nickname," Catra said. "She hates giving her given name because it's in the Polar Magicat language and most people can't say it right. Pisses her off. So she just goes by Snowball. We're not together, not in the way you're thinking."

Adora let out a long sigh as she said, “I’d be a hypocrite if I gave you shit over that.”

“You got old,” Catra said.

Adora felt tears in her eyes as she said, “I did. Thirty years, Catra. So much has happened in that time I don’t even know where to begin.”

“This isn’t real,” Catra said. “I’m… I’m hallucinating aren’t I?”

“You’re not,” Adora said, as she reached up and touched Catra’s face. Catra leaned her head into Adora’s hand and Adora heard the soft purr for a split second before Catra shook her head.

“What do you mean you raised two kids with Glimmer and Bow?” Catra said.

“I… I don’t want to talk about that right now,” Adora said. “I don’t want to make this harder.”

“Are you together?” Catra said.

“With Glimmer,” Adora finally said after a pause. “I’m married to her. Bow is married to her. The two of us are just friends.”

“And there’s kids?” Catra said, her voice breaking.

“Capella and Nock,” Adora said, tears streaming down her face. “They’re wonderful kids.”

Catra let go and walked away from Adora, her arms holding her tight as she shook her head.

“That… how!? I remember kissing you and then I remember calling for you and… how!?”

Adora had her own arms tight around her as she said, “I kissed you and we released the magic in The Heart. You pulled back and I remember your eyes. You were so happy and then you just… you faded away. You went limp and faded away. I looked for you but I had to go out and face Prime.”

“You said he’s gone?” Catra said, turning around.

“He is,” Adora said. She still remembered looking at Hordak, his mind being overwhelmed by Prime and Adora driving him out. She still heard the dying shriek as the dark thing he came out as he disappeared into nothingness.

Catra sat down on the ground and Adora walked over to her and knelt down.

“What… what is going to happen?” Catra said and Adora reached forward to pull her in close.

“I don’t know,” Adora said.

Chapter End Notes

We're coming to a close soon. I think we have a few more chapters but we're getting there.

Camp Bright Moon Timeline

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Daniel finally have a long overdue talk and look for someone to help them. It comes in the form of two people Adora barely knows.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?
>
> Please be aware, this chapter does contain a very brief mention of sexual assault. It is about a paragraph long, does not describe it in any detail, but it is there and I am updating the tags to reflect it and wanted to post this as warning.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora sat on the loveseat and Daniel sat on the couch catty-corner to her. He took another drink from the cup in his hand and Adora held her hand out for it.

"It's just lemonade," he said, although he still handed it to her.

Adora took a sip from it and savored the sweetness. Daniel made his own syrup for the drink and he always preferred more sweet to the typical sour acidness of most lemonades. Adora held the cup for a moment, before taking another sip and handing it back to him as she said, "I'm not sure what to say."

"This hasn't been working out," Daniel said. "No matter how much we pretend it has, I think you've been pretty unhappy since

before we ever got married."

Adora felt tears in her eyes as she nodded. She tried to speak normally but all she managed as a half-sobbed, "Yes."

Daniel set his drink down and started to reach forward to comfort Adora before he stopped. The only real light in the room came from the streetlight outside and Adora could just tell he wasn't sure what to do. She reached out and took his hand and gave it a squeeze.

"I've tried," Adora said. "I really have. I just… I keep thinking of her and I just keep trying not to because it's not fair to you."

Daniel sat for a second before he said, "Do you remember when you first told me about her?" Adora nodded. It had been on something like their fifth date sitting in a park as they fed ducks. "Do you remember what I said?"

"That you didn't care about that," Adora said. "That you'd help me through it with prayer and guidance."

Daniel nodded as he said, "That's right. And what have we done?"

"Prayer and guidance," Adora said and then gave a little snot filled, weeping laugh. "It's been so helpful obviously."

"Yep, prayer and guidance," Daniel said. "And you've tried your own guidance as well, like that book you have in your desk drawer."

Adora didn't move for a moment before she said, "How do you know about that?"

"You left it unlocked one day and I was looking for some spare paper for the printer," Daniel said.

"When?" Adora said.

Daniel shrugged as he said, "It's been a while. I didn't read your notebooks though. I just made sure to lock it since I had a feeling you didn't want me to know."

Adora sat back as she said, "I didn't. I guess I should have trusted you."

"I am your husband," Daniel said with a little smile. "Supposed to be one person after all."

"Genesis 2:23-24," Adora said with a sigh. "Yeah, I remember but… it's just never been right. I hate it. I don't know what to do but I can't keep doing… *this!"*

“I get it,” Daniel said. “I feel the same way.”

“Oh God, are we getting divorced?” Adora said, thoughts of her mother and what she’d say in her head.

“I mean, it doesn’t have to come to that, you know, if we don’t want,” Daniel said. “I’ve been doing some reading about something for myself and came across something. I think we can make an arrangement.”

“What are you talking about?” Adora said. “You said that earlier.”

“I don’t know,” Daniel said. “I’m not sure how to put it. Like, poly, something like that.”

Adora didn’t know what he was talking about at first but then thought of some things she’d heard at a volunteer job as she said, “Wait, no, why would you even agree to that? You want to sleep with her too, don't you?”

Daniel was shaking his head as he said, “No, it’s not like that.”

“It sure as hell seems like that,” Adora said, her back straightening as she felt anger splash up into her. Daniel took a deep breath and let it out as he spoke.

“Adora, it’s not like that because I think I’m ace.”

“I don’t care how awesome you think you are,” Adora replied, “I’m not OK with what you’re saying.”

Daniel grabbed his drink and took a long drink before he said, “Adora, I’ve been… you know that thing I was reading about I just mentioned? It was about this. I think I’m asexual.”

Adora paused in confusion before she said, “Wait, you think you’re an amoeba?”

She was surprised when Daniel laughed.

“I’m sorry,” Daniel said, as he fell back into the couch, trying to control his laughter which only caused more to come out. It took him a moment to get it under control but when he did, he said, “I didn’t think I’d tell you in this way and of all the things I thought you’d say when I did tell you, that was absolutely not on the list of responses.”

“OK, I’m kind of freaked out, really confused, and I think we need to start over,” Adora said.

“Absolutely,” Daniel said with a sigh. “Let’s try this again. You’re a lesbian, I’m asexual, you’re still in love with your old summer camp crush, and I was trying to propose something so we could all be happy.”

Adora didn’t move, as if the word lesbian was in the room looking to pounce on her but she remembered the moment on the Camp Bright Moon dock, kissing Catra, feeling like everything was right in the world. She remembered the next day, her mother screaming at her how she wouldn’t have a dyke for a daughter and how Adora had caved and left with her to try and keep her happy. She’d denied it had ever meant anything, she’d denied that she felt that way, she’d done everything she could to not be a lesbian, but her she was, eyes stinging from tears, realizing that yes, it wasn’t just some habit or mannerism, like biting your fingernails, that you could train yourself out of, but something so basic and deep in her being that to deny it was like trying not to breathe. By trying to avoid it, all she was doing was suffocating herself. She moved and let it pounce.

“I am,” Adora said. “I really am.”

“Are you OK?” Daniel asked.

Adora felt light headed, like she’d drank a really fine wine too fast but she still nodded.

“I… I am,” Adora said. “I’m so scared but it doesn’t seem to matter.”

“I know what you mean,” Daniel said. “I’ve never talked about this with anyone. I was terrified to tell you.”

“I don’t think I even know what you told me,” Adora said.

Daniel started to speak for a moment and then stopped and then tried again, before stopping again, before finally saying, “I don’t really experience sexual attraction. I like the hand holding and spending time with you but it feels, to me, what I think of as a close friend. You were the first person I ever felt comfortable around when we dated.”

Adora, looking backwards at their courtship, gave a sad smile as she said, “I felt the same way. You didn’t push me for more, you were happy to wait, and I liked that.”

“Because you weren’t attracted to me, not like that,” Daniel said.

Adora sighed as she said, “Yeah, that seems to be the case. I actually told Mom that when we got engaged and she said that I shouldn’t think about it and that it’d come with time.”

Daniel shook his head as he said, “I do love you, you know but…”

Adora finished his sentence as she said, “Like a friend. I feel the same way but that’s it.”

They both sat silently as Adora reached over for the cup and took a drink from it. As she went to set it down, Daniel reached out and Adora handed it to him, the sounds of the ice hitting the side the only noticeable noise in the room. Daniel took a drink and carefully set it on the table. He looked at it for a moment before looking at Adora.

“Our marriage is falling apart,” Daniel said, a little smile playing along his lips. “Shouldn’t one of us be screaming and the other, I don’t know, be throwing some plates or something?”

Adora gave a little smile in return as she said, “We have that dish set we never use but let’s be honest, I don’t think either one of us is all that broken up about it.”

A frown shoved the smile off Daniel’s face as he blinked really fast for a moment before he said, “You know, I kind of am though. You’ve been a good friend. I don’t want to lose you, that’s why I tried to bring up the poly thing.”

Adora felt her heart break at the look on Daniel’s face, like a little lost boy.

“We couldn’t do that because, other than everything else, I don’t think she wants anything to do with me,” Adora said. “I’m not

talking to her, she just liked a photo on my Facebook and sent me a go away message. There's no relationship there."

"What do we do from here?" Daniel said.

"I don't know," Adora said. "It's not like I'm going to just move out right now and it's not like I'm never going to speak to you again but… I don't know. I really don't. Normally I'd pray but it seems kind of…"

"Wrong?" Daniel said with a little humorless laugh.

"Yeah," Adora said.

They both sat for a minute and then Daniel suddenly said, "I'm not sure I really believe anymore anyway."

Adora looked at him in surprise. It was a statement more shocking than his coming out to her. It was one of the reasons she'd chosen to marry him. He'd been active as a youth pastor and her mother had loved that about him. He'd been serious about the ministry and serious about his faith. This was as sudden as if he'd announced he was an alien from another planet.

"Are you serious?" Adora said.

“You’re shocked at this but not the ace thing?” Daniel said.

“It just seems… I mean, yeah, I’m shocked at both but this seems so… not you,” Adora said.

“I just… I don’t know, I think church does something helpful but I’ve just seen so much that it hurts,” Daniel said. “Remember Charlie?” Adora nodded. Charlie had been a kid that Adora had been a summer camp counselor for and she’d reached out to Adora about six months before from a rehab center. She’d been an absolute mess and had been flailing as she looked for help. “She’s all screwed up because of all the stuff she got told from the church about what happened with her dad and probably a ton of other crap. How was that helpful? Why weren’t we good people instead of good Christians for her?”

“I so don’t want to talk about this right now on top of everything else,” Adora said, feeling the guilt climb up her spine. She’d always blamed herself for that as Charlie had come to her about what her dad had been doing to her and Adora had gone to the church staff and they’d ultimately done nothing for her other than tell Adora it was being taken care of and telling Charlie she should pray and reflect. Everything else had been brushed under the rug with a little handwaving and bullshit. Charlie had disappeared not long after that, ran away from home Adora had found out later, and Adora hadn’t done anything. Adora had tried to tell herself she’d only been sixteen but in her heart she’d still blamed herself for it.

“Yeah, I guess not now,” Daniel said before taking another deep breath. “I want to stay married, although I’d like it if we didn’t, um, you know, do married stuff anymore.”

Adora looked at him in confusion for a split second before blushing a little as she said, “Yeah, I’ve never particularly liked that, I was just doing it because Mom said it was my duty to you and I figured you expected it.”

Daniel shook his head as he said, “Yeah, my Dad said something similar but way more vulgar. I’m not repeating it.”

“Thank you,” Adora said as she snagged the cup and took a drink. “I’m not sure I want to stay married though.”

Daniel bit at his lip for a moment before letting out a sad sigh.

“I thought so,” he said.

“I’m not saying I don’t ever want to see you again,” Adora said. “I agree with what you said, you’re my friend, we’ve been through a lot together but…”

“But you don’t want to keep this going,” Daniel said.

“I don’t even know what this *is.* I mean, we’re friends?” Adora said. After Daniel slowly nodded, she went on. “So are we friends with… are we friends with a shared bank account? Are we friends

who own a home together and have insurance together? I mean, I feel like this is kind of unexplored territory."

"What do we owe each other, I think that's what you're trying to say," Daniel said.

"Yeah," Adora said after a moment to think. "Maybe that's it."

"We need some advice I think," Daniel said. "I'd say let's see your counselor but maybe this isn't the thing to bring in."

Adora snorted as she said, "Considering she thinks what I'm going through is my burden to shoulder for God, I don't think so."

"I can only imagine what she'd have to say to me," Daniel said.

The two sat there in silence again, Daniel taking the cup from Adora to take a sip before passing it back to Adora who took a sip as well and sat it back on the table. After looking at it for a moment, she took a coaster from the small stack on the table and put it under the cup. As she did, she thought of something.

"I… I might know someone who can give us advice," Adora said, standing to her feet suddenly and speed walking towards the bedroom. Daniel fell in behind her and stood there with her as she started a short text exchange that changed to a brief but awkward

video call and then about thirty minutes later, there was a knock at their front door.

Adora opened the door to two people, two people she hadn't seen since she was eighteen, and the reaction from each one was fairly similar to the first meeting they had when she originally met them.

"Thank you for coming," Adora said to Bow.

"I'm glad to help," Bow said as he stepped forward, arms open for a hug. As Adora hugged him, Glimmer stood behind him on the porch. It could be said that her eyes were full of distrust and anger but only because it had overflowed from her face and pooled there.

"I'm not," Glimmer said. "One peep of a sermon and I'm trashing your place."

"Nothing like that, I promise," Adora said as Glimmer came in, gave Daniel a once over, snorted, and headed into the living room without asking. She stood in the middle of it, looking around at the tidy room, frowning at a cross on the wall, before turning around.

Bow was turning to Daniel for a hug, who stepped back a little and put his hand out as he said, "I'm Daniel. I'm not… um…"

“No hug, got it,” Bow said as he shook Daniels’ hand with a smile. “I’m Bow, pronouns he/him.”

“Oh, that, yeah,” Daniel said. “Same.”

Glimmer snorted and Bow shot her a look before he said to Adora, “So you said you all were having some issues and you thought I could help but you weren’t real clear what’s going on.”

“A sermon, I’m telling you,” Glimmer said as she flopped down on the love seat.

Adora said, “How about we sit down?”

“How about you just say what’s going on?” Glimmer replied.

“OK,” Adora said, looking at Glimmer as she rushed through the next bit, trying to keep it together. “My marriage just ended tonight, we think, because I’m a lesbian and I don’t know anything about this and I would have called literally anyone else but you’re the only people I know to reach out to for anything like this.”

“I umm… I also realized that I was, no, I am, you know, asexual awhile back and just now came out to her,” Daniel said. “In fact, I

guess you're the only other people who know."

Bow gave Daniel a kind smile as he said, "It gets easier to say, I promise, and I'm proud of you for having the courage to say it at all."

Daniel nodded quickly and looked away as Glimmer sat up from the couch, her face still distrusting but also showing a little sympathy now.

Bow said, "How about we sit down. It sounds like there's a conversation to be had."

As they sat down, Glimmer looked at Adora as she said, "You know you broke Catra's heart, right? You know she was a fucking mess for years after because of what you did?"

"Glimmer!" Bow said.

"She's my friend, Bow!" Glimmer said. "You think I'm going to stay quiet!?"

"I know," Adora said. "I really screwed up and she definitely let me know what she thought of me in her message. This isn't about that. Maybe it isn't about that. I don't know."

"She's in a relationship and she's perfectly happy in it," Glimmer said. "So if you're burning your marriage down for a shot at her again, stupid move but par for the course for you."

Bow buried his face in his hands as he said, "Can we do this a little more politely? *Please?"*

Glimmer said, "I'm not the one stalking Catra. Maybe we start there."

"I'm not stalking her," Adora said. "Well, not like, creepy stalking…"

Daniel sat a hand on Adora's arm as he said, "Just stop."

Glimmer was about to say something when Bow jumped in as he said, "Listen, I knew you didn't just get lost tonight but I wanted to let you save face. I know you're not being creepy either or you wouldn't have called." Bow gave Glimmer a look as she started to speak up again and she just made a go on gesture at him before crossing her arms and glaring at Adora. "I meant what I said though, I miss you."

"And Catra is going to be pissed at you for coming here," Glimmer said to him. "I'm not defending you."

“Please, five minutes. Five minutes and you can say whatever you want,” Bow said in a pleading voice. Glimmer looked at him, pulled her phone out, set a timer and put it on the table as Bow raised an eyebrow at her. “That is the most lawyer thing I’ve seen you do.”

“You’re wasting your time,” Glimmer said. “Tick-tock.”

“I don’t know what Adora wants but I’m trying to figure out what to do. I mean, what’s even the point of staying married at this point?” Daniel said. “I want to, she’s my best friend even if I don’t feel romantic about it but… it just doesn’t seem like it’s a thing that can be done.”

“Listen, sex isn’t a thing that’s got to be in the relationship,” Bow said. “You can make whatever vows and promises you want to each other. It’s about you, it’s about what you want to make together.”

“I don’t know if I want to,” Adora said. “I think that, um, I think I agree, he’s my best friend, but I don’t want to live a lie.”

“It’s not a lie,” Bow said. “No one needs to know the details of your relationship.”

“It’s not just that,” Adora said as she took a deep breath and let it out. “I really want to see Catra and I guess ask for forgiveness.”

“You owe me money,” Glimmer said to Bow.

Bow pointed at the timer on the phone without looking away from Adora as he said, “I said five minutes, it’s not up. Thirty second penalty.”

Glimmer snorted and reached town, tapped the phone, and sat back as Adora said to Glimmer, “Listen, I know you’re just looking out for her but I really don’t want to hurt her. I didn’t back then, I just thought, um, damn, I don’t know, I guess that I’d work it out with Mom and we’d move on.”

Glimmer glared at Adora before saying, “You broke her. I barely knew her and I could see that. You could have just spit in her face and then slapped her and it would have been less insulting.”

“I’m so sorry and I…,” Adora started to say when Glimmer cut her off.

“No, fuck you and your sorry,” Glimmer said. “We took a lot of time putting her back together. She got kicked out of her home, she had nothing but what she had in her bag she carried from camp that night, but she thought she had you and you just turned your back on her. Why in the hell would I help you break her again and for that matter, Bow, why the fuck are you doing it?”

“That’s not what I want. I have so much regret that it’s killing me. I just want to try and put this right,” Adora said, tears starting to streak her face. Daniel reached out and took her hand and Adora let him as he gave it a squeeze.

“You can’t put it right, it’s already been done! And why are you letting her do this to you?” Glimmer said as she turned to look at Daniel.

“I’m doing this to myself,” Daniel replied. “Even if she never said anything, I knew it was long past time to tell her about myself. It just worked out that it’s time at the same time this was happening. I also don’t think you’re being helpful.”

“You're Goddamn right I’m not,” Glimmer replied. “Catra is my friend and I won’t let you do this to her.”

“Glimmer, hon, maybe we let Catra decide that,” Bow said, taking Glimmer’s hand. She glared at him but didn’t pull away.

“Then call her right now,” Glimmer said.

“Maybe that’s not the best idea,” Daniel said gently.

“I agree with Daniel,” Bow said.

“No, if it’s up to her then let’s get her involved, right now,” Glimmer said, picking up her phone.

Adora watched in horrified delight as she saw Glimmer pull up Catra on her contacts.

“No, don’t,” Bow said as Adora felt relieved disappointment as Glimmer swiped away from the contact. Then her heart stopped as Bow took his phone out and dialed. “She’ll take it better from me.”

He stood up and almost immediately got an answer. Adora couldn’t hear the words but she could just make out the cadence of Catra’s voice. Daniel reached over and rested a hand on Adora’s shoulder as Bow stepped out of the room into the nearby kitchen as he said, “You got a moment?”

Adora could just hear him, little snippets of “Let me tell you what’s going on” and “That was really loud, could you repeat yourself?” but mostly it was silence. She really wanted to get up and go in there but it would mean going past Glimmer and Glimmer’s incandescent angry look.

“Um, so I don’t really know you,” Daniel said. “And we didn’t get introduced. I’m Daniel and your name is Glimmer, right?”

Glimmer just nodded at him and then it was silent for a moment before a, “Catra, it’s not like that” came out of the kitchen.

“So, ah, I work for an insurance company in actuarial,” Daniel said. “What about you?”

“Are you really trying to make fucking small talk?” Glimmer said, her tone full of contempt.

Daniel shrank back a little as Adora straightened up as she said, “Hey, you can hate me all you want but he didn’t have anything to do with what happened and didn’t deserve that. He’s just trying to be polite.”

“It’s alright,” Daniel said. “I’m sorry.”

Glimmer started to open her mouth and then frowned as she said, “I’m a lawyer.”

Daniel was about to open his mouth when Bow walked back into the living room and held the phone out to Adora.

“She wants to talk to you.”

“Bow…,” Glimmer started to say and Bow just shook his head.

“Daniel, I…,” Adora was saying at the same time.

“It’s what you’ve wanted,” Daniel said with a comforting smile. “Go. We’ll talk after.”

Adora wouldn’t move, couldn’t move, and Daniel stood up and went over to Bow, who let Daniel take the phone from him and walk it over to Adora. She took the phone like it was a hot coal and stared at it in her hand.

“We’ll be in the kitchen,” Daniel said and then left the room. Bow waited while Glimmer glared at Adora for a moment before getting up and leaving with him.

Adora finally put the phone to her ear and she could hear Catra muttering something and for a moment, she was transported back to Camp Horde for the Lord, listening to Catra complain about something under her breath, and she took a deep breath. Catra heard her and went silent.

“Uh, hello?” Adora said.

“Why the fuck did you get my friends involved?” Catra said.

“I… it’s not like that,” Adora said.

“Listen, Bow says I should talk to you and I trust Bow more than just about anyone on this fucking planet so I’m fucking talking to you. Say what you have to say,” Catra replied.

It was silent as Adora had a thousand things to say go through her head and then right back out without leaving hardly a trace. She could hear noises in the kitchen of the fridge opening and she could see Daniel trying to be hospitable and offer refreshments and for a moment she wanted to just hang up and go in there with a fake smile on her face and say that all was right in the world and so sorry to have bothered them and it would be alright and thank you for the evening and then never see them again and just live the best fake life she could. She was halfway to hanging up when she finally blurted something out.

“I’m sorry.”

“Yeah, thanks, don’t mean shit, but thanks.”

“I deserve that.”

“Fucking right you do. You ruined my fucking life.”

Adora was crying now as she said, “I didn’t mean to. I was scared.”

The response was immediate and loud.

"You didn't think I wasn't scared!? You left me! You left me with people I didn't know and I lost *everything!* When I asked my foster family for my stuff they burned it and sent me the fucking ashes! The only reason I did what I did was because I thought I'd have you and I got that for ONE! FUCKING! NIGHT! Not even a full day! You were gone by the afternoon! God damn it, why are you back!? Why are you doing this!? Fucking answer me!"

Adora could hear the tears in Catra's angry voice as she said, "Because I can't keep doing this! Because I'm so sorry and I've hated myself for years and I've tried to let it go but I can't! I know you're in a relationship and I know we're not getting back together but I just can't live like this anymore and I have to try and do something to make it right! I have to atone for my sins!"

"No! Don't talk like you're going to just pray to some invisible sky being and give some mealy mouthed apology and it's all better!" Catra shouted. "Don't you talk about atonement! This isn't some bullshit church thing, this is real fucking life!"

Adora could hear silence in the kitchen as she said, "It's not like that! I swear! What can I do!? Please!?"

"Go back and don't fucking abandon me," Catra said trying to sound hard and cold but only sounding upset and shaking.

Adora leaned forward, trying to keep her crying silent, as her shoulders shook. After a pause, she quietly said, "If I could I

would."

It was Catra's turn to be silent, long enough that Adora looked at the phone to see if she had hung up, before she finally said, "So would I."

Again, silence and Adora looked up to see Daniel looking in from the kitchen. She was about to give a fake smile but it died and she just shook her head at him before giving a brief hand gesture to go away. He nodded and disappeared again.

"Listen, I had this grand plan tonight to come to that rally and talk to you in person but I chickened out and I just… this is not how I thought any of this would go," Adora said.

"Story of my fucking life," Catra replied.

"That's my fault," Adora said.

There was a brief silence followed by Catra saying, "Fuck, I was going to say you're right but you're not. Well, not entirely."

"Yes, it is," Adora said.

“No, don’t try to take the sins of the world on you,” Catra said. “I fucking could have done more.”

Silence followed again but it didn’t feel quite as fraught with traps. Catra broke the silence by saying, “Glimmer try to kill you yet?”

Adora snorted a little tear filled laugh as she said, “Not yet but nights not over yet either.”

“She’s a good friend,” Catra said.

“Yeah, it seems that way,” Adora said. “Her and Bow are in the kitchen right now with my husband.”

“Husband… that’s weird to hear from you,” Catra said. “I’m scared to know what kind of religious shithead you married.”

“He’s not like that,” Adora said.

“Maybe I’ll meet him sometime,” Catra said and then they both went silent, afraid to say anything more for a moment.

“And… um, maybe, I’ll meet your girlfriend, sorry, I meant partner,” Adora said. “Is that right?”

“It’s whatever,” Catra said. “But I’m not in a relationship, what gave you that idea?”

“Glimmer said you were,” Adora said and fought down the surge of hope in her chest.

“OK, I’m dying to know why she said that,” Catra said.

“But you said maybe meet Daniel,” Adora said. “Does that mean you want to see me again?”

Catra made some noncommittal noises for a moment before she said, “Fuck no, I don’t but that doesn’t mean I’m not going to.”

“You don’t have to,” Adora said. “I really am not looking for a relationship with you. I just want a chance to say I’m sorry.”

“You already said it,” Catra said with a sigh. “And honestly, yeah, it was kind of nice to hear you grovel a little but it’s over, it’s done. Five years ago, I would have ground this in your face and laughed while I did it. I screwed up a perfectly good relationship and hurt some people being that kind of person though. Yeah, I hate you a little over this but it turns out it’s not worth holding on to I’m finding out.” There was a pause before another sigh. “Listen, I’ve got to be up early tomorrow and it’s already late.”

“Can I call you, can I have your number?” Adora spat out.

“Calm down,” Catra said. “I’m not brushing you off, I just… I think I’m done with this conversation for now but I do want to talk later. Say good-bye and take the phone to Bow. I want to talk to him.”

“Listen, Catra…,” Adora started to say before getting cut off.

“Adora, no. Take the phone to Bow, I’m done talking for now,” Catra said. Adora could hear the steel in her voice and, terrified of losing any chance she had to talk to her later, meekly said alright but not good-bye. She found she couldn’t say good-bye as she walked the phone to Bow.

“She wants to talk to you,” Adora managed to say as she held the phone out, scared to let go of it.

Bow took the phone from her and left for the living room. Adora turned to Glimmer who she was surprised to see was having a polite conversation with Daniel at the kitchen table. Adora found out immediately that didn’t apply to herself though.

“You manage not to horribly traumatize her this time?” Glimmer said as Adora sat down at the table.

Adora flinched as Daniel sighed and said, “Come on, we were having a nice conversation.”

“She yelled at me, a lot,” Adora said. “No more than I deserve.”

“You’re right,” Glimmer said, taking a drink of ice water that Daniel had given her.

“Are you alright?” Daniel asked Adora and she just kind of shrugged. “I’ve been talking with Bow and Glimmer about who I am. I think, well, I don’t know what to think really but I do think things are going to be OK.”

Adora heard the hope in his voice and couldn’t help but smile a little as she wiped at the sudden tears in her eyes as she said, “I think it will be as well.”

“God damn it,” Glimmer muttered, which caused both Daniel and Adora to look at her from the curse. “Stop looking at me like that.”

“What’s wrong?” Daniel asked.

“Nothings wrong,” Glimmer said, crossing her arms as she looked away from the two of them. “You’re just… did you have to be so relatable?”

“I can preach if you want,” Daniel said. “I used to be a youth pastor. I know how it’s done. I can tell you about the main man,

J-Christ.”

Glimmer cracked a smile as she fought back a laugh as she said, “Don’t you fucking dare.” She sighed as she relaxed her arms and reached for the drink on the table as she looked at Adora. “I guess I won’t extract my revenge on you, at least for tonight.”

“Thanks,” Adora said as they all turned to see Bow walking back into the room as he tucked his phone back into his pocket.

“She’s fine,” Bow said to Glimmer’s unasked question as he sat down at the table. “Are you alright? I heard what sounded like actual conversation.”

“Well, I told her that I wasn’t going to take my revenge tonight,” Glimmer said and then gave a little head nod at Daniel. “He’s not bad but you never know.”

“I’m sitting right here,” Daniel said with a grin. “I’d hate to see what you said if I wasn’t.”

“She’d say the same, trust me,” Bow said. “Every time she goes in front of a judge for work, I fear I’m going to have to bail her out.”

“I’m not that bad,” Glimmer said.

“You sure?” Adora said, surprising herself and everyone else at the table.

“OK, we’re at the cracking jokes phase of awkward,” Bow said. “That’s good. Listen, it is late and this day started way too early. Adora, Catra told me to tell you that she wants you to respond to her on Facebook and she’ll talk with you there.”

“And what we were talking about?” Daniel said and Adora sat up a little straighter.

“I’ve got your number,” Bow said. “I’ll text you that counselor's information. I promise you, they work with the queer community a lot, they’ll be able to talk with both of you and help you out without judgment.”

Daniel seemed to relax a bit more. Adora looked down as she fiddled with a coaster on the table as she said, “I apologized to Catra earlier and I’ll do the same for both of you. That day… I think about it, a lot, and it wasn’t just Catra I let down. You both went out of your way to help, including your parents, Glimmer. I’m sorry I spat on you.”

“You didn’t spit on us,” Bow said at the same time Glimmer was saying, “Yes, you did.”

Bow gave Glimmer a long suffering look as she looked back at him with an expression that said, "I said what I said."

"For what it's worth now, I really am sorry," Adora said. "I know it's just a word and I don't know what to do to make it seem real but I'm sorry."

Bow nodded as he said, "I accept your apology and you don't have to keep saying that."

"To him maybe. I wouldn't mind hearing it some more," Glimmer said as she dodged Bow's hand reaching out to give her a little push. "OK, OK, yeah, I'll accept your apology but I'm not quite ready to just let it go."

"I feel the same way," Adora said.

"Alright," Bow said as he stood up. "We're going to go now. Reach out to Catra, alright?"

Everyone else stood as Adora said, "I will and thank you. I know you didn't have to come out or even help at all."

"It's what I do," Bow said.

“It really is,” Glimmer responded.

“It was good to meet you,” Daniel said. “I hope we see you all again.”

“Come over to the house this weekend,” Bow said. “Saturday evening if you’re free, I’ll cook dinner.”

Glimmer looked at Bow in surprise before saying, “OK, yeah, let's do that.”

“We don’t have to,” Adora said.

“No, it’s alright,” Glimmer said. “If it’s not, well, we can just cancel later.”

“Tactful as always,” Bow said as he pulled Glimmer in and kissed the top of her head. Then he stepped forward and surprised Adora by hugging her tight. “It’s going to work out. Maybe not how you want, but it’s going to get better.”

Adora hugged him back just as tight as she tried not to cry. Bow turned to Daniel with his hand out but this time Daniel hugged him just as tight and Bow told him roughly the same thing he’d said to Adora. They all walked to the door and Adora and Daniel watched them walk to their car. Daniel had his arm around Adora but it didn’t feel like a husband and wife. It felt like two people

adrift at sea who'd just seen what looked like a shore and were desperate for salvation.

Chapter End Notes

I did not mean for this to be six thousand words long but it just rolling and rolling and rolling and I was having so much fun writing Glimmer and of course Bow was a delight being his kind and gentle self and it just kept going. I love it though. Now I just have to do the next two storylines justice like this. Also, this is not the last we'll see of this little snip. I thought I was close to an end, just a chapter or two, but I absolutely am not (though I am close, it'll just take a little longer to wrap).

Alright, who saw asexual Daniel coming? I'll be straight up on this one, the "Daniel said he had to work late" was absolutely set up to make it look like he was cheating on Adora. Did I intend for him to be doing so? Nope, not really. I considered it as a plot point but I didn't like it and never seriously considered it. I always planned for Daniel to actually not be a bad guy and I thought, "You know what this story needs? More queer rep, 100%." He's my fourth ace character. Cowrie was first, then Capella and Gress, and now Daniel joins the ranks. Also, I absolutely made myself laugh out loud at Adora's, "You think you're an amoeba?" line.

Also, Daniel trying to explain his identity is so close to my own experience coming out as nonbinary. People did not understand. Like, if I said I wanted to transition and identify as a woman, people would have got that. People don't get the nonbinary thing. I had a lot of conversations with my loved ones in my life over that. It was also a good reminder that a good ally isn't someone who knows all the perfect terminology and details but someone who's willing to listen and support you, even when they don't fully understand.

Charlie, the woman Adora had been a counselor for, was something I had thought about putting in the main Camp

Bright Moon series but never did. I did briefly mention in Graduation that Adora had had contact with some people from the camp who'd not done well over the years and Adora had blamed herself for some of it because she felt like she'd damaged them in some way or another. I didn't have enough room to elaborate on it, but Charlie would have been one of them.

The good people instead of good Christians thing Daniel says is something I said when I was shaking off my own religious trauma. I don't even remember exactly what it was about but I remember saying, "If that's being a good Christian then I'd rather be a bad Christian and be a good person instead."

For readers who aren't American, I know that there can be confusion with what is lemonade. For Americans, it's a non-carbonated drink made from a simple syrup of sugar and lemon juice and then added to water, stirred to mix, and then poured over ice. There's also powdered drink mixes you can get as well which is the most common way to make it at home.

The flavor is typically a bit sour, though some recipes go more sweet than sour (which is my preferred that I gave to Daniel). Most commercial brands go sour. It's always a crapshoot ordering it in a restaurant because the way the typical commercial brand gets mixed in a soda machine can be from sour but acceptable to "I'm drinking lemon flavored battery acid." The same goes if the restaurant makes their own. It could be really sweet and delightful or the aforementioned horrible. Check out a few recipes online if you're interested, it's pretty easy to make and you can play around with the flavoring. Also, lemonade mixed with some Grenadine is fantastic.

When the Musics Over Timeline

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora finally start to talk and Adora learns that Catra has someone extra in her life she's going to have to deal with somehow.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“What do you mean you’d be a hypocrite?” Catra said, referring to Adora’s comment about how Catra might have been romantically involved with Snowball.

“Just that after the divorce, I dated. Didn’t really go anywhere,” Adora said, doing her best to not think of the date she’d accidentally gone on the night before.

Catra’s claws scored the desktop she was gripping a little deeper as she said, “Not like I care. You can do what you want.”

“That desk says otherwise,” Adora said.

“Stop it,” Catra said. “And what do you want out of me?”

Adora sighed as she said, “I don’t know. I thought I wanted some answers and I thought I wanted some big confrontation but I don’t even know anymore.”

“Why didn’t you just stay away then?” Catra said.

“I’m an idiot, remember?” Adora said.

Catra shook her head as she said, “Don’t. Don’t do that. Don’t try and bring up our little things we did.”

Adora sighed as she said, “I wasn’t trying to, at least not on purpose. Mara’s breath, I missed you though.”

Catra frowned deeper as she said, “No, you don’t get to do this to me.”

“I’m not trying to do anything to you,” Adora said. “I’m trying to say what I feel.”

“Well, I don’t want to know what you feel,” Catra said. “We’re divorced, I haven’t seen you in years and I thought you’d finally given up on me.”

“I wouldn’t ever,” Adora said. “The only reason I even left you alone is because you went to every effort to be left alone.”

“Yeah, you’re right, I did,” Catra said. “This is the first place in years that I’ve used my own name. Do you have any idea what it’s like living under a fake name?”

“You didn’t have to though!” Adora said. “Why didn’t you try and come and work it out!?”

“Why should I? I’m not the one that left,” Catra said.

“Yes, you are!” Adora said.

“You walked out because we had the fight about kids again!” Catra said. “Then you didn’t come back and people started coming around to talk to me about how bad they felt about what was going on! It was pretty obvious you were just setting it up to be done with me!”

“And you didn’t bother to find out!” Adora said.

“No, I didn’t, because you know what? I was done! I’m glad you left me! I’m glad you divorced me! It was an endless nightmare having to deal with you!” Catra said.

Adora's mouth dropped open and her heart broke. She didn't think that was something that could even happen anymore but there it was, shattered once again.

"Do you… really?" Adora said as she fought to keep from crying. She'd be damned if she let Catra see her cry now.

"Yes!" Catra said. "You were so worried about the whole She-Ra thing and how people saw us! We were the saviors of the universe and you didn't want anyone to know that something was wrong! That was the real reason you wanted a kid, so everyone would see just us, being normal, having a kid as the next step!"

"No, that's not the reason," Adora said.

"You know what? I don't care what the reason is," Catra said. "It's over, it's done. It's been over and done for a long time now."

"I know," Adora said. "I know."

"You keep saying that," Catra said. "You keep saying you don't know why you're here except you saw some old photo of us and then had to come up here looking for me. So no, I don't think you fucking know."

"Catra, I just, damn, I don't know, maybe I am up here because I thought it wasn't over and maybe I'm up here because I'm fucking

pissed about that," Adora said, feeling anger take over from the tears. "It's the same bullshit as when we were teenagers all over again! You wouldn't just talk with me!"

"Don't! Don't bring that up! Don't you ever bring that up! I didn't bring up you running when we were teenagers so don't you bring up that because if I'm doing the same thing then you fucking are as well!" Catra said.

"No, it's not the same…!" Adora said as Catra cut her off.

"Yes, it is! Don't you get it!? That's why we failed! Have you just spent the years wallowing and not thinking about this!? We failed because we got stuck! We never tried to fix anything! We just trusted that love would carry it through and it fucking didn't!" Catra said.

"Our love saved the universe!" Adora said.

"Yes, but it didn't save us!" Catra said.

Adora blinked in shock at the statement. She could see the truth of it. She knew Glimmer and Bow had gone through a hard patch too but it was if everything was suddenly very clear to her. It wasn't that Bow and Glimmer loved each other more or harder than her and Catra had loved each other, she could see it was that they worked through it where Catra and Adora hadn't even known quite where to begin or how to ask.

“You see it,” Catra said and her voice was no longer angry, it was just weary.

“I, um, yeah,” Adora said as she let out a long sigh. “When did you figure this out?”

“Years ago,” Catra said. “I’d been up for days drinking and I just kind of had a moment of clarity. I’d been cursing at something I’d seen about some happy couple or other and then it hit me. We loved each other because it’s what we knew. We didn’t know how to deal with people but we knew what was in our gut and we were convenient.”

“No,” Adora said, shaking her head as she started to get angry. “That’s not why.”

“Yeah, it is,” Catra said. “It meant something, don’t get me wrong, but we’re broken, like really fucked up broken, and that’s what happened. We tried to shove our shards together and well, we got cut.”

“It can’t be like that,” Adora said as she reached up to push some hair behind her ear. “We just… it wasn’t like that.”

It went silent as Catra looked at Adora’s wrist that had peeked out of her sleeve. Adora realized where she was looking and quickly

covered up the scar tissue.

"It's not what you think," Adora lied.

"I know every scar on you," Catra said quietly. "Or did."

"I was stupid," Adora said.

Adora expected a sarcastic response but she didn't get anything.

"Say something," Adora whispered after the silence stretched out.

Catra looked down at the ground as she said, "I'd show you my scars but my attempt was with pills. Snowball found me. She's the reason I'm still alive."

"It was Swiftie for me," Adora said.

"How is he?" Catra said.

Adora shrugged as she said, "Still lives in Bright Moon, comes out to see me pretty regular. You know, sacred bond, that thing."

Catra gave a fleeting smile as she said, “I’m glad he saved you.”

“I’m glad Snowball saved you,” Adora said. “I might be pissed at you but I never wanted you dead.”

“Yeah, same,” Catra said before taking a deep breath. “Listen, I don’t want to hang around in this closet working this out and it’s pretty fucking obvious it needs to be talked about. Where are you staying?”

“I just landed here right before I ran into you,” Adora said. “I don’t have a place.”

“I see planning still isn’t your strong point,” Catra said and Adora fought back the anger as she realized Catra was just trying to be funny. “There’s a few rooms here for travelers but it’s not like the town has anything like a hostel or inn or something. Come to my place, we can talk, and then get you setup for a place while you’re here.”

“I don’t want to cause trouble with Snowball,” Adora said.

“She’s not my partner, romantic at least,” Catra said. “It’s a story I don’t want to go into, alright? She hasn’t sworn a blood feud against you yet so I think we’re doing alright for now.”

Adora flinched. She was well aware of the Magicat blood feud tradition since Glimmer had to deal with them occasionally as queen, and the extent to which a Magicat would go to settle one, and the thought of one sworn against her was enough to cause her gut to clench a little.

"I don't want to invade your space either," Adora said.

"Stop trying to guess what I want," Catra snapped before taking a breath. "Just, listen, just come over so we're not literally a foot apart, alright? Let's just deal with this."

"OK," Adora finally said after trying to think of something else to say.

When she turned around and opened the door, she was immediately met with Snowball's glare. She was leaning against a table not more than a few feet from the door and Adora couldn't meet the icy blue eyes that drilled into her own.

"We're, um, just going to…," Adora tried to say.

"I heard," Snowball said and her voice was just as cold as her name. Her eyes flicked over Adora's shoulder to where Catra was standing behind her. "I'm going along."

"Someone has to keep the grill open," Catra said.

“I’ve shut it down,” Snowball said. “Anyone who complains can come find me.”

“I’m trying to tell you…,” Catra started to say and Snowball cut her off.

“I know what you’re trying to tell,” Snowball said. “You can stop trying to tell it, it won’t change anything.”

Adora heard a familiar sigh from Catra, one she hadn’t heard in years and for a moment she felt like she was transported right back to when they were just barely past being kids. It was the sound of Catra giving up on an argument. It felt so familiar she almost smiled but she could tell by the way Snowball was looking at her that it wouldn’t be appreciated.

“Adora, move so I can show you where we’re going,” Catra said.

Adora got out of her way. Catra started walking towards the kitchen exit, grabbing her outdoors gear off a hook by the door. Snowball stood and glared at Adora as Adora realized that she needed to follow Catra. She hurried after her and she heard Snowball fall in behind her. It wasn’t the footfalls she heard, she knew how quiet a Magicat could be, it was the almost inaudible growl that was escaping from Snowball’s throat. It didn’t make for a comfortable walk to the small buried home where Catra and Snowball lived.

Adora could tell the entrance was on pilings but it was still level with the snow. She didn't want to try and guess how deep the snow was, considering she'd already seen snowdrifts taller than she was even when she was She-Ra, and she followed Catra into the one part of the house that was above ground. It was a decent sized mudroom and as they hung up their various clothes, she could still hear Snowball right behind her.

"You know she's She-Ra, right?" Catra said as she looked over Adora's shoulder at Snowball.

"Won't matter," Snowball said as Adora moved away from her.

"We're here to talk," Catra said. "Let's not start a fight. It's way too small in this place to do that."

"You will treat her with respect," Snowball said, pointing a finger at Adora, who couldn't help but notice the extended claw. "You will not hurt her."

"I can do that," Adora said.

"I know you can hurt her, that's why I'm saying don't," Snowball said.

“She’s agreeing with you,” Catra said and then said something in a language Adora didn’t know. Snowball responded back and Catra said something again, a little more haltingly. Snowball’s fur fluffed out a little in agitation before she gave a curt nod and went through the interior door and out of sight.

“What was that?” Adora said.

“Polar Magicat,” Catra said. “I don’t speak it that well but I needed to talk to her and she responds better to that.”

“No, I mean… that,” Adora said, trying to think of how to explain what she meant.

“She’s protective of me,” Catra said. “Really protective. It’s a long story.”

Adora could tell that was all she would get out of Catra and let it drop. She followed Catra into the next room, a small loft overlooking the main living area and followed her down the stairs. She remembered the house her and Catra had lived in at Bright Moon. It’d been meticulously tidy and decorated, always ready for guests. As She-Ra, she’d had people coming around all the time and she’d been embarrassed by the least little thing out of the ordinary and now she realized just how silly that thought was, especially looking around now.

The place wasn't messy but where the old house had looked like a museum, this looked like a place that was well lived in. There were a few skylights up in the roof that were currently covered in snow and the main living area consisted of a couple of comfortable looking couches with a couple of blankets on each as well as two easy chairs. A big low table sat in the middle of the furniture, covered in books, papers, and a few half-done craft projects. To the back of the room was the kitchen and a table with a few dishes sitting in the sink next to two refrigerators. Adora saw a small nook with three doors in it and she assumed that was the bathroom and bedrooms. Under the loft was what appeared to be more seating but was mostly just stacked boxes and a door.

"It's a nice looking place," Adora said, trying to think of something to say as Snowball grabbed some crochet project off the low table and sat down in one of the easy chairs.

"It's warm and that's the most important part," Catra said. "Sit wherever."

Adora sat down the furthest she could from Snowball, who was hooking yarn like she had a vendetta against it and doing her best not to glare at Adora. Catra noticed and said something to Snowball. Adora thought it sounded half amused, half exasperated, something she well remembered from their days together. Snowball just grunted but she did stop glaring at Adora so much.

"You want something?" Catra said as she walked to the kitchen.

“No,” Adora said, frowning as she realized Catra was probably about to start drinking. That had been one reason it’d ended and she knew just how ugly an argument with drunk Catra could be.

“Get that look off your face,” Catra said as she opened a refrigerator and Adora caught the glow of the refrigerator light through a huge assortment of fizzy drink bottles. She thought of the colors of the Etherian sky for a moment as Catra went on. “I don’t drink anymore. It’s why I’ve got two fridges crammed in here. I drink a lot of fizzy drink.”

“Oh,” Adora said. “I’m sorry, I wasn’t thinking. I’d like a grape if you have it.”

Snowball made a chuckling noise that surprised Adora as she snapped her eyes towards her.

“She has it. She has every flavor,” Snowball said.

“Isn’t there thirty-something flavors?” Adora said.

“Thirty-seven,” Catra said as she pulled out three bottles and walked back over. “I don’t have them all in the fridge though. I like to rotate them through.”

She handed Adora the glass bottle and pointed at a bottle opener on the table. She stepped over and handed Snowball one that was

bright red before sitting down on the couch close to Snowball but still facing Adora. Snowball gripped the top of the bottle, her arms flexed, and Adora heard the cap come loose. Adora didn't bother and just used the bottle opener and passed it to Catra.

They all sat in quiet for a moment, drinking their beverages, before Adora finally said, "I guess I should start off?"

Catra nodded as she said, "You want to do this in private?"

Snowball's lips went thin but Adora shook her head as she said, "I don't know what your relationship is but it's obvious you two care about each other. If it makes it easier for you, I don't mind."

"Behave," Catra said as she turned to Snowball for a moment before turning back to Adora. "Alright, go ahead."

"I had a moment to think on the way over here and I was trying to think of just why I was out here or why I didn't bother to try until now," Adora said. "It's because, um, I guess it's because I was furious at you. I saw that picture of us and things had settled for me but I've never really addressed it. I mean, I did go ahead and see someone, especially after… well, you know, but I guess I never really confronted it. Then I found out you were up here, or had been, and I remember how much we fought about visiting Frosta up here, and I just… I got pissed."

“You broke years of silence and flew all the way up here because you were mad about an old vacation argument?” Catra said, her ears sitting back a little in disbelief.

“No, that’s just kind of the final moment,” Adora said. “I guess we just never settled anything. I mean, when I did the divorce, we were supposed to sit down with arbitrators and work out the terms of everything and we never did that. You couldn’t be found. Maybe I just wanted that last moment and I know that the closure I look for isn’t the closure that I’m going to find but damn, anything would have been better than what happened.”

“So you want closure?” Catra said. “Adora, you’re not making a whole lot of sense.”

“Mara’s heart, I’m screwing this up,” Adora said with a huff. “I wanted to see you.”

“You aren’t over me,” Catra said.

“No, I guess I’m not,” Adora said and ignored Snowball sitting up a little straighter in her chair. “I know we’re not going to be romantically involved again but damn it, I miss my best friend! We grew up together in a nightmare and you were the only thing I had for the longest time and then… well, the war, but then afterwards it was so great!”

“Until it wasn’t,” Catra said.

“Yeah, until it wasn’t,” Adora said. “And I know that yeah, I can blame some of that on you but I can blame some of that on me as well but I didn’t want the last thing we ever said to each other to be in anger.”

Catra closed her eyes for a moment and took a long breath before letting it out.

“Adora, I’ve missed you too but we’re not good together anymore. Do you really think that we can be around each other and not do something incredibly stupid?”

Adora started to respond but she stopped as she realized she needed to be honest.

“No, probably not.”

“Exactly,” Catra said before she took a drink off her bottle and Adora couldn’t help but notice it was the same way she used to drink beer, a long pull off it to get as much down as possible. “I loved you. I was ready to die for you but I guess I wasn’t really ready to live for you. We were stupid kids who hurt each other so much and we didn’t know how to climb out of that.”

“I’m not saying I want to get back together…,” Adora said but Catra waved the bottle in front of her to cut her off.

“No, you're not getting it,” Catra said. “The Polar Magicats have a saying. It basically translates to ‘The ice took it.’ It means it’s gone. You loved it but something outside your control ripped it away. That was us. We were doomed from the start and the ice took it.”

Adora saw the tears in Catra’s eyes and she looked away as the room went fuzzy as her own eyes filled.

“You won’t even try and be my friend?” Adora said.

“Do you think I don’t want to?” Catra said. “Do you think I ran all the way up here and hid for so long because I was mad? I mean, yeah, I was but do you think I *stayed* because of that? I did it because I knew what would happen if I didn’t. I knew I’d got back if I talked with you and we’d just fall right back into it. We’d get back together, we’d try and it’d all just fall apart. One of us would probably be dead now, honestly. Probably me.”

“Both of us almost died,” Adora said, not turning to look at her.

“But we didn’t and if we stayed together… I know in my heart it would have been me for sure,” Catra said, her voice cracking. Adora turned to see the tears flowing as Catra looked down at the bottle in her hand. “Damn it, I want a drink so fucking bad right now.”

Snowball said something to her and Catra shook her head. Snowball repeated herself and Catra finally looked at her and responded. The two stared at each other for a moment before Adora spoke up.

"Do I need to leave?"

"No," Catra said, even as Snowball looked at Adora as if she wanted Adora to leave and fall into a deep hole as she did.

"Listen, do you want me to just go away? I'll go away and be done with it," Adora said. "Be honest."

"Would you really?" Catra said, looking at Adora, her eyes tired and sad. "Could you? Could you just let it go?"

"Could you?" Adora said.

Catra sagged as she said, "No, and neither could you or you wouldn't fucking be here."

"Is that so bad?" Adora said.

"Yes!" Catra shouted. "Damn it! I like my life now! I don't want to go back to being a drunken asshole that everyone hates! I don't

want to be Force Captain Catra or She-Ra's wife! I just want to be Catra! I was fucking happy with that and now I know I either have to disappear again or I have to deal with this and I don't want to fuck up again!"

Adora covered her eyes as she said, "I don't want any of that either. I don't want to be She-Ra or someone's savior or the perfect couple that saved the universe. I get what you mean. I live in Mystacor, hardly see anyone, and it's quiet and I like it but it still has something missing and that's why I'm here. I don't want to ruin either one of our lives."

"I don't want to get back together," Catra said.

"I don't either," Adora said. "I just want my friend in my life again, somehow."

Snowball said something then and Adora looked up in enough time to see Catra's face. Surprised barely covered the emotion on her face.

"Are you kidding me?" Catra said to Snowball. "I'm pretty sure you were ready to literally murder her earlier."

Snowball glared at Adora before turning back to Catra as she said, "It is pretty obvious you still care about her. It's been obvious since I first took you in. It won't change, no matter how you crush

it down. Since you were quoting our wisdom earlier, here is another one."

Snowball said something in Polar Magicat and Catra's ears laid back a little more and Adora noticed she looked a bit embarrassed.

"What? What was said?" Adora asked.

Catra repeated it in Polar Magicat and Adora rolled her eyes as she said, "I got that but I don't understand it."

"Well learn the language because I'm not translating," Catra said, glaring at Snowball who was actually grinning ever so slightly. "And don't you dare."

"I said nothing," Snowball said before turning to Adora. "I am not her lover. I haven't ever been her lover. She's…" Snowball hesitated as she searched for a way to put it and then just shrugging, said a word in her language. "It translates to adopted orphan but that's not right, there's so much more to it than that. She is like my sister but that is not right. I don't know how to put it. She is," and she repeated the word again, "and it is my duty to be there for her."

"It's not your duty and I don't accept your duty," Catra said, interrupting her. Snowball's ears flicked a little and she made a little shooing gesture with her paw at Catra before going on.

“Do you understand why I am telling you this?” Snowball replied.

Adora slowly nodded as she said, “You’re worried about her. She’s your friend and you don’t want her to be hurt anymore.”

Snowball shook head and let out a huff as she said, “No. I am not her friend. That word does not cover this. If she were lost, I would not rest until I found her. If she went into the ice, I would go down after her. If she were dead, I would likely be as well. Nothing breaks this. It is for life.”

Adora sat back from the intensity in Snowball’s eyes and said, “I think I understand. Kind of.”

“Good. Then understand this,” Snowball said. “I think you are in something similar with each other but you did not do it intentionally as we do. You did not take care to be sure that you are stable yourself, did not even understand that you both should do so, so it was ugly but it is still for life. Whether you shall be lovers again or not, it doesn’t matter. You are, what’s the word, bonded and…”

Snowball trailed off and Catra said, “Nope, you don’t just stop. Not after what you said earlier. Finish what you’re trying to say.”

Snowball gave a low growl but Adora understood it to be almost playful this time, or at least non-aggressive, before she said,

“Fine. I would have put you into the ground, Adora of Mystacor, for what you have done but I realize I was mistaken. Seeing you two talk now, I realized what it is between you two, what it is that has driven you and so, I grant you permission to be in her life.”

Adora almost said something about how it wasn’t up to Snowball but she caught Catra’s expression and her slow head shake at Adora.

“Thank you,” Adora said.

Snowball stood up and said, “I’m going back to the diner. I’ll call in Otter early to cover for you. I expect you both to speak and come to a resolution.”

“Can do,” Catra said as she stood up and hugged Snowball.

Snowball hugged her back and then started for the stairs. She stopped at the bottom and seemed to think for a moment before turning around and pointing a finger at Adora.

“Don’t think just because you are She-Ra that I will not end you if you hurt her again. I care not how many princesses you know. None of them could stop me.”

Adora gave a little head nod at her as she said, “I understand.”

Snowball huffed again before saying, “I’ll be back later.”

With that, she left. Adora sat for a moment, waiting until she heard the door shut and then turned to Catra.

“Yeah, I know, she’s a lot,” Catra said but she was smiling a little. “There’s a very long story there but I’m basically part of her clan now. You think Half-Mooners can get intense, you haven’t met her, well, our family.”

“Wait, our?” Adora said, her eyes widening.

“Yeah,” Catra said, looking away as she scratched at her face for a moment. “Our. I’m part of the clan, like I said. They’re not my biological family but they’re family all the same. You think I learned Polar Magicat to talk to just Snowball? It’s not an easy damn language.”

Adora shook her head in amazement as she said, “That’s… wow. I never would have thought.”

“Me either,” Catra said. “It’s a story, like I said, and not one I’m going into right now. So, this. I guess we work this out.”

“Like I said, I just want my friend back,” Adora said. “If I have to worry about a homicidal Magicat watching over me for it, I’m more than willing to deal with it.”

“She wouldn’t actually try and kill you,” Catra said before pausing and then shrugging. “Probably.”

“That fills me with relief,” Adora said.

“She’s actually really kind,” Catra said. “I was going to say a sweetheart but yeah, no, that does not fit. She was there for me though. She really helped me but enough of that. Now what?”

“I don’t know,” Adora said. “I don’t know how to go from what was going on to just, um, friends.”

“I think we need to go slow,” Catra replied.

“I agree,” Adora said. “Is it OK if I tell Glimmer and Bow?”

“Oh, Mara,” Catra said as she grunted. “I’m going to have to deal with a homicidal queen.”

“She’s not like that,” Adora said and then added on, “if I asked her not to be. I think.”

“I don’t know if I want to be around her to be honest,” Catra said. “She drank a lot too. I don’t want to fall into that again.”

“She’s sober these days,” Adora said. “Her and Bow almost got divorced about the same time we actually did and that was a huge part of it.”

“OK, yeah, tell them then,” Catra said. “Tell them not to visit though. I need to ease into this.”

“You sure you don’t want to jump in with both feet? Worked so well for us in the past,” Adora said, trying to put a smile on it.

Catra rolled her eyes as she said, “Yes, as can be shown by our, well, everything.”

“Listen, we need to talk but right now I’m feeling kind of wrung out,” Adora said. “Would it be OK if we postponed that while I figure out my skiff and stuff?”

“Yeah, we can do that,” Catra said. “I’ll come with you, get you set up with one of the rooms at the port.”

“The port? There’s a dock here?” Adora said as they both stood up.

“The airport,” Catra said with a laugh. “The locals call it the port. I don’t know why, it’s not like there isn’t plenty of time to say the air part. Not much happens up here if you haven’t noticed.”

“Sounds relaxing,” Adora said as they made their way to the stairs.

“It really is,” Catra said. “I mean, it’s also infuriatingly maddening in winter when you can’t even get out of the house for days at a time but you know, small price.”

“For being hidden?” Adora said and then realized she probably shouldn’t have said that. “Sorry, that was kind of shitty.”

“I mean, yeah, it was,” Catra said as they got to the top of the step. “It’s alright though. I don’t have it in me to fight with you I guess and besides, you’re not wrong.”

They were quiet as they got into the mudroom and started grabbing their coats. Adora felt at peace in the quiet ritual of putting on her boots and then her coat and hat. She was grabbing for her mittens when they dropped on the floor. Catra noticed and was kneeling down to grab them at the same time Adora did. They almost rammed their heads together but managed to stop just in time.

“Go ahead,” Adora said with a laugh as she sat back.

Catra grabbed the mittens and held them out to her with a laugh of her own as she said, “Still clumsy I see.”

“I was never clumsy,” Adora said with a smile as she took the gloves. “It just looks that way next to how smoothly you move.”

Catra grinned as she looked away and flipped her hood up.

“Whatever, goofball.”

In a moment, they were both standing at the door. Adora stopped Catra before she could open it.

“Hey, I just wanted to say that, well, I know this was sudden and I know you didn’t want it but thanks for, I guess, I don’t know, thanks for not just completely blowing me off,” Adora said.

Catra turned as she said, “Yeah, whatever.” She shuffled her feet a little uncomfortably on the floor before she went on. “Just hug me like I know you want to do, you Bright Moon freak.”

Adora grinned as she said, “Don’t live there anymore, remember? I’m a Mystacor freak now.”

Catra grabbed her and hugged her as she muttered, “Just shut up and hug me. I’ve missed you.”

Adora hugged her tight as she said, “I’ve missed you too.”

The two stood there swaying for a minute before they finally let go of the hug. They shuffled their feet awkwardly in front of the door before Catra muttered something.

“What was that?” Adora asked, wondering what she had said.

“I said I’m an idiot,” Catra said and then grabbed Adora and pulled her into a kiss. Adora didn’t even bother trying to fight it. She pulled Catra tight to her and kissed her right back.

Their first kiss saved the universe. Neither of them were teenagers any more, they knew that a kiss didn’t heal all wounds or right all wrongs but, at least in that moment, that kiss saved them. It showed they both still cared. It showed that things might be alright and for two broken people, that’s what was needed. So they kissed and they cried with laughter and then they kissed again and a foundation was prepared for what might come.

Chapter End Notes

I can not believe it has been almost a month since I updated this. It has been an interesting time since I last updated. I've got arthritis in my shoulder and that's flared up so for about a

week I didn't want to do anything. Then I've been trying to finish a fic for an event for the fourth anniversary of the show that's next month. I'm looking forward to everyone seeing that one. Then there was the day I drove out of state to go see the total solar eclipse. I'm going to say this, if you ever get a chance to see one, even if it means traveling, do it. It was quite possibly the most amazing thing I've ever seen. I saw someone on Tumblr say, "I looked into the eye of God for a few minutes and now I'm expected to just go back to my life?" And yeah, truth. Even if you've seen a partial eclipse, even up to 99%, you still haven't seen it all. Totality is absolutely jaw dropping. Anyway, enough about that. The rest of the time was spent just getting this written and edited while dealing with every day life.

Anyway, this isn't the end to the timeline but like the last one for Camp Bright Moon, it is the wrapping up stages. I think we have about two more chapters. I need to go back to the original Bright Moon timeline and I want to have a wrap up chapter. It might be three more, I don't know but I think two would do it nicely. We'll see how the writing goes. Anyway, thank you for sticking with me and I hope you enjoyed this one!

Bright Moon Timeline

Chapter Summary

Catra has been found but has the world changed too much?

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora held Catra close as she shook. After a few minutes, Adora spoke.

"I don't know what to do."

"I never thought I'd hear you say that," Catra said as she looked at Adora.

"Lots of things have changed," Adora said as her mind began to race. Things had changed. She was thirty years older for one and Catra still looked the same. Looking at her was like looking at an old picture except she was there in her arms. She pulled Catra in tighter and for a moment, fought to still her mind. Things had changed but that just meant Adora had decades of experience dealing with changing things. She knew if she just took a moment, she could figure it out. She felt a soft puff of breeze on her face for a moment but thought nothing of it, nor the rustling noise she heard.

"What happens now?" Catra said.

“I don’t know,” Adora replied. “I’m just trying to take a moment. It’s… it’s been a day.”

“Tell me about it,” Catra said and the way she said it, full of irony, pain, but humor, made Adora snort.

“Yeah, I guess you win the hard day award,” Adora said.

“Holy shit, you’re Catra!” Adora heard shouted from the entrance to the room. She turned to see Capella pointing in shock. Catra looked at her, looked back to Adora, and then started laughing and crying at the same time. Capella came rushing over as Adora heard the rustling behind her again without really paying attention to it.

“Can I help?” Capella asked as she knelt down beside them.

“You were supposed to leave,” Adora said.

“So were you,” Capella said to Adora before turning to Catra. “Are you really Catra?”

Catra looked up from her laughter and tears and nodded.

Adora reached out and pulled Capella gently closer as she said, "Capella, this is Catra, Catra, Capella, my daughter."

Catra shook her head again as she wiped at her tears, forcing herself to stop crying, as she said, "Bow and Glimmer as bio?"

"Yeah," Capella replied.

"Figured. You look like your Dad and act like your other Mom," Catra said with a laugh.

"You can't already be OK," Capella said, looking at Catra as she seemed to be pulling herself back together. "You've been dead."

Catra snorted as Adora said, "Capella!"

"I like you," Catra said as she wiped at her nose.

"Don't encourage her," Adora said.

"OK, so this has been extremely weird," Capella said, "and you're going to need a Listener," she said as she nodded at Catra, "so can we get out of this creepy damn place immediately so we can start that process?"

“Are you OK to go?” Adora said, her hand immediately resting gently on Catra’s shoulder.

Catra gave her a soft smile as she said, “Yeah, I think I can handle walking out.”

As they stood, Catra sniffling as she did, Adora once again heard the rustling noise nearby. She took a moment to look around and for a brief moment, thought she saw something in the dim room but it was gone in a blink.

“You hear it too, don’t you?” Catra said quietly.

“Yeah, that’s not a creepy thing to say,” Capella said as she looked around the room nervously.

“I hear it, yes,” Adora said. “What is it?”

Catra shrugged as she leaned into Adora and Adora took a moment to notice just how familiar it still seemed all these decades later. She was shaken out of her thoughts as Catra said, “I don’t know. I kind of remember hearing it right after we… well, right before I disappeared I guess and then heard it right before you showed up. It felt… I don’t know… it felt warm. I feel like I’m forgetting something but it feels comforting.”

“Let’s talk about it outside,” Adora said. “I think Cappe is getting a little weirded out.”

Capella, who’s face said she was more than a little weirded out, fought her features back to normal as she said, “I’m fine. You don’t have to rush on my account.”

“I want to see the world, come on, kid,” Catra said, giving a head bob towards the door.

“Kid? We’re probably the same age,” Capella said. “I’m probably older in fact.”

“Can you two do this later?” Adora said as she started to walk forward. Catra walked with her, a little shaky and Adora could tell she was still freaked out but didn’t want to show it in front of someone she didn’t know.

“Alright,” Capella said and then froze in place. Neither Adora or Catra noticed at first and were almost to the door when Capella managed to speak. “Mom!? *What is that!?”*

Adora turned around and her mouth dropped open. In the space where the Heart had been was a shape similar to the one she’d seen in Bright Moon castle’s stained glass over the years. For a split second, she even thought she was somehow seeing that stained glass mural because she never did think that Angella quite

looked like that but that was exactly what she was seeing now as she heard the rustle of feathers.

"She talked to me," Adora heard Catra say, as if in a trance. "She said I wasn't stuck, I just had to wait, that's right, she did say that. I was so scared but the wings were so soft and warm and she told me to just wait, nothing is forever."

"Mom?" Capella said, her voice shaking a little as she turned her head trying to make sense of what she was seeing.

Adora remembered the last time she'd seen Angella, sacrificing herself to save a world, and the soft, sad smile on her face. Now she watched as the face of the stained glass looking shape slowly turned to Angella for a split second. Catra was standing frozen to the spot and Capella was backing up towards them.

"It's alright," Adora said as she reached out and put a hand on Capella's shoulder, causing her to jump. "It's Angella."

"Who?" Capella said and then her brain kicked over and her eyes widened as she realized what had been said. "Wait… my grandmother?"

"Yes," Adora said, walking towards the shape. It was flickering like a bad projection, rapidly switching between the appearance of the memorial stained glass and a more realistic appearance of Angella. "Keep an eye on Catra."

Capella quietly shuffled over to stand beside Catra who was staring at Angella with a soft smile and blank eyes. Adora kept thinking she should already be close to where Angella seemed to be manifesting, and how Adora hated that word, like Angella was some kind of otherworldly entity rather than Glimmer's mom and a brave woman Adora had been honored to have known for a short time, but it seemed to just always be out of her reach and she finally stopped.

"Angella? Can you hear me?" Adora said and Angella turned her face towards Adora for a brief moment and the smile on her face seemed to light up the room.

"You've grown."

The voice seemed to come from everywhere and at the same time seemed to be whispered into Adora's ear just for herself. Adora felt the hairs along her arm lift as a shiver ran down her spine.

"Come towards me," Adora said. "Come with me."

All she received was that same soft, sad smile.

"Come on," Adora said, reaching out her hand. "Glimmer is grown and we're married and she's married to Bow. That's your granddaughter behind me; her name is Capella. You have a

grandson; his name is Nock. Come on, Micah is still alive! Reach out! Come back to us!”

Up until Adora mentioned Micah, Angella had just kept smiling her little smile but at the mention of Micah, her expression turned to heartbreaking sorrow. Tears fell from her eyes and Adora swore they made tinkling noises as they fell, like shattered glass. She resisted the urge to reach out and catch one and wasn’t sure what to even say as Angella spoke again.

“I have to stay.”

Adora was already shaking her head halfway through the statement as she said, “No, you don’t.”

Angella just shook her head, starting to fade back from herself and back into stained glass as Adora tried to get closer and failed.

“Grandma, don’t go.”

Angella seemed to shiver, her form like living glass, and looked out at Capella.

“I never left.”

With that, Angella faded, first to the appearance of her mural in Bright Moon and then faded out until nothing remained. Catra blinked once, twice, and then began to softly cry. Adora ran back over to her, crying herself as she caught Catra as she sagged and started to collapse. Capella caught the other side of her as they all ended up on the ground. Adora couldn't help but notice that Capella had tears in her eyes before turning her attention to Catra.

"It's my fault," Catra said.

Adora knew what she was talking about but didn't want to say anything about it as she said, "No, don't worry about that. We can figure this out later."

"She wouldn't be there if it wasn't for me," Catra said.

Capella looked at Catra and Adora could see the realization coming across her face of what Catra had talked about and for once, Adora cursed herself for making sure that Capella and Nock had been given the absolute best education they could manage, which had included very detailed descriptions of things that had happened during the war, including Catra almost collapsing reality and how that had been stopped. Adora started to say something, anything, to try and get her off the subject when Capella put an arm around Catra and hugged her tight.

"It's OK," Capella said. Catra shied away for a moment before reaching up and taking her arm and hugging her back. Adora wrapped them both up in her arms, trying not to sob more than

she already was when she heard Capella speak again. “We’re leaving.”

The teleport caught Adora by surprise and she heard Catra retch a little when they settled on the grass outside the Crystal Castle. Capella let out a long sigh of relief and fell back into the soft grass before rolling over so she could see Adora and Catra.

“Are you alright?” Capella asked as she saw Catra shaking her head and dry heaving a little.

“I don’t like teleporting,” Catra said.

“Sorry, I just didn’t want to slog back out of there through… well, everything,” Capella said.

Catra waved a hand, trying to show she didn’t care but the effect was marred by her making a choking noise before falling back into the grass herself and sighing. Adora sat down and took her hand as the three sat in silence for a while.

“What do you think Grandmother meant about how she’d never left?” Capella finally said.

Catra had her eyes closed and Adora had thought she’d actually fallen asleep but she began to slowly talk.

“I… I’m starting to remember things,” she said. “She was there for me.”

“You said something like that back there,” Adora said. “What do you remember?”

Catra shook her head as she said, “It’s just little flicks of memory but I think she watched over me and I think she even said something about watching over Etheria? I don’t know. Maybe I’m losing my mind but it seems real. I don’t know.”

Capella sat up and hugged her knees as she took a long breath before saying, “That’s… Mara, I have no idea what to say here.”

Adora looked at the sky as the light of day began to drain out of it and said, “Cappe, go get Bow and Glimmer. Don’t tell them what’s going on, they’re going to ask too many questions, just tell them I need them here right this minute.”

“You’re really going to drop me on them out of nowhere?” Catra said as Capella nodded and disappeared.

“They’re your friends,” Adora said.

“They were this morning,” Catra said as she sagged. “I don’t know if they are thirty years later.”

Adora hugged her tight as she said, “They’re your friends, I promise.”

Catra curled in on herself as she said, “Promise. You promise.”

“I keep them too,” Adora said.

“I remember a promise you gave me once,” Catra said, her voice a bit hollow.

“And I kept it,” Adora said.

Catra was quiet for a moment before she nodded, “Yeah, I guess you did.”

As the light faded, the stars came out. Catra looked up at the sky and Adora saw her eyes widen and her face relax a little.

“Whatcha thinking?” Adora asked.

“It’s beautiful,” Catra said.

Adora looked up as well. It wasn’t anything in particular going on, just the usual Etherian aurora with the moons and stars of the night sky but then Adora remembered that Catra had probably only seen it a few times where Adora had seen it every night for thirty years and in that moment, she saw the beauty in the sky as if with fresh eyes.

“It really is,” Adora said.

“I must sound like an idiot,” Catra said, taking her eyes away from the sky as she wrapped her arms around her legs. “I’m probably going to, a lot.”

“Hey, don’t talk about yourself like that,” Adora said, pulling Catra in close and felt her shaking a little. “You’re going to be alright.”

They were quiet for a little bit but Catra’s shaking didn’t subside.

“You alright? You’re shaking,” Adora said.

“I’m just… I’m remembering things,” Catra said, her voice shaking. “I remember seeing things. I remember seeing us up in the Northern Reach having a huge argument in some diner and I saw us but it wasn’t me, I didn’t have my fur or ears, but it was still us on some river somewhere but I don’t think it was Etheria and I

saw us fighting Shadow Weaver to save our kid, I think their name was Finn, and I saw us ruling the Horde, and I…"

Catra trailed off and Adora looked at her as Catra's shaking subsided as she stared straight ahead towards the Crystal Castle, her eyes unfocused.

"This was… this was while you were…?" Adora said, not sure how to put it.

"Away? I think so," Catra said as her ears twitched a little and she shook her head. "I just get hit by these memories that can't possibly be mine but they're still me and I'm remembering Angella through it all… I got her there and she still helped me. She showed me how to call out."

Catra put her head down on her knees and Adora wasn't sure if she was crying or not at first but she held her anyway as she heard the sound of Capella teleporting back in and Glimmer asking her what was going on.

"I told you, Mom said to just bring you, alright? She's right there, ask her," Adora heard Capella say.

"Adora what is…," Glimmer started to say and then her words sputtered out as she saw Adora with her arms wrapped around Catra. Capella stood behind her mother, her arms crossed and her

lips set in a tight line as she watched everything. “Is that… Catra?”

Bow had slowly walked forward and had knelt down next to Catra and Adora. He looked back over his shoulder, his eyes wide with surprise as he slowly nodded. Glimmer came forward and knelt down next to him as Catra looked up and saw the two standing there and didn’t even try to hide her tears as she said, “I’m so sorry.”

“For what?” Bow said.

“I’m so sorry,” Catra said. “She couldn’t come with me.”

“Who are you talking about?” Bow said but Glimmer suddenly reached out and put a hand on Catra’s shoulder.

“Who? Who couldn’t come with you?”

“We saw Angella,” Adora said.

Glimmer started to cry but it was silent, just tears streaking down her face as she said, “What do you mean?”

“We saw her,” Adora said. “Catra said she’d been watching over her and when we found her, we briefly saw Angella and she said she couldn’t leave where she was.”

“You talked to her?” Glimmer said and the queen of Bright Moon, the good ruler and clever diplomat of thirty years, fell away and Adora saw Glimmer as she had been on the day of her coronation, a scared, hurting young woman who desperately missed her mother.

Catra nodded as she said, “It’s my fault, she never should have been there.”

Glimmer was audibly crying now as Bow wrapped her in his arms and Capella came over to hold her mother as well.

“How?” Glimmer said. “How are you back and she isn’t?”

“I don’t know,” Catra said. “I just… I was trapped… I think… and she told me how to reach out… but I don’t… I don’t know.”

“Where were you?” Glimmer said.

“We found her by the Heart,” Adora said.

“Take me there,” Glimmer said.

Catra started shaking in fear and Adora pulled her close as she said, “I will but we need to see to her first.”

“Where is it in there?” Glimmer said. “I can find it.”

“Mom, I know where it is,” Capella said. “I’ll take you.”

“Are you sure this is a good idea?” Bow said. “Maybe we need to take a moment.”

Before Adora could agree, the three were gone. She realized that Glimmer had given a little nod to Capella and let out a long sigh.

“Come on,” Adora said to Catra. “Let’s get you to my skiff.”

They walked over, Catra leaning heavily against Adora, and she got Catra down against the skiff and began to pull out the emergency kit stowed away in one of the storage compartments. She got one of the sleeping bags out and opened it as it let out a little hiss as air rushed into the sealed bag it had been stored in. Adora draped it around Catra’s shoulders and she immediately burrowed into it, pulling it tight around herself.

“Don’t go,” Catra said as she watched Adora stand back up.

“I’m not leaving you,” Adora said. “I’m going to be right here. I’m just going to set a few things up.”

Catra nodded but said nothing else as Adora began to set up the tent, constantly looking at Catra as she did and so caught the moment Catra fell asleep. She stopped and held her breath as, for a moment, she was sure she’d fade away again but Catra just sat there curled up in the sleeping bag, her breathing slow and steady. After she was sure that Catra wasn’t going to disappear again, she finished putting the tent up and then sat down next to Catra with a few survival ration packs.

As she listened to Catra’s breathing, she pinched the corner of one of the packs and then shook it as it started to heat up. She’d heard people say the rations reminded them of the old Horde ration bars but she just laughed at anyone who said that because it was so obvious they didn’t really know what they were talking about. After a minute, she opened the bag and the smell of stew came out of it. Not particularly good stew but it was something and she was hungry and she figured she’d have a long wait ahead of her.

“Is that food?” Catra said, her voice thick with sleep.

“It’s stew, yeah,” Adora said as she looked over at Catra as she rubbed her eyes. “Want some?”

Catra sat up, nodding and Adora handed her the bag and the disposable spoon that came with it.

"I didn't mean to fall asleep," Catra said between mouthfuls of food.

"It's alright, it's been rough," Adora said as she heated up another ration pack.

"I think she's going to hate me," Catra said after a moment.

"Who, Glimmer?" Adora said, and then went on without waiting for an answer. "She's not going to hate you. She's had thirty years to come to terms with that. She didn't even hate you before… well, you know. You saved her after all."

"It's easy not to hate someone when they're gone," Catra said as she stared into her empty ration pack. "What am I going to do?"

"What do you mean?" Adora said.

"What am I going to do?" Catra said. "Everything has passed me by."

“You’re going to… I mean, I guess…,” Adora tried to say and then let out a long sigh. “I don’t know.”

“You would have, back then,” Catra said.

“No, I wouldn’t have,” Adora said. “I just would have been convinced I did and forged ahead no matter what.”

Catra gave a little mirthless chuckle as she said, “Yeah, you would have. You did.”

Adora touched the scar that the Failsafe had left behind as she said, “Yeah, I did, didn’t I?”

They were both quiet for a few minutes and Adora was about to say something when she heard Catra’s breathing change. She looked over to see her asleep again, the ration pack on the ground by her hand. Adora picked it up, set it to the side with her empty pack, and pulled the sleeping bag back around Catra before putting her around her and pulling her into her side. Then she just sat and waited. For what, she didn’t know, she just knew she didn’t have to go running forward. The future was going to be weird enough, she figured, she didn’t need to hurry to meet it just yet.

Chapter End Notes

I can't believe it's been so long since I've updated this! I apologize. The short reason is that I had some shoulder issues that kept me from being able to type for long periods

of time. I had to basically use what typing I could do for my job and then rest a lot. I'm in physical therapy now and things are getting better but I'm here to tell you, if you don't have a regular exercise program, I'd get one for yourself. Doesn't even have to be fancy, just fifteen or twenty minutes a day of some basic stretches and simple exercises. Older you will thank you.

As to this story, I'm thinking we just got another chapter or so to go and it'll be wrapped up. Thank you for reading and I hope to have this wrapped up sooner rather than later.

Wrapping Up

Chapter Summary

It all comes down to the end.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Years change people like water changes even the hardest of stone. Time passes and the change is slowly wrought, moment by moment, grain by grain, until the stone or the person is something different from what began.

For Adora, she realized how much had changed a little over a week after Catra returned to Bright Moon castle. They talked but to Adora, thirty years older, it was like talking to someone Capella's age. It was the person she remembered, it was Catra, it was the person she'd loved and the moment she realized in the middle of the night that loved was past tense, she'd got up out of bed and cried in the bathroom for an hour. Then she'd gone to find Catra.

"Hey, Mom," Capella had said as Adora walked into the rooms they'd given to Catra.

Adora looked around in confusion for a moment, wondering if she'd walked into the wrong room by accident, as she said, "Hey. Where's Catra?"

“She’s sleeping,” Capella said. “She doesn’t like to do it alone so I offered to hang out.”

“She didn’t tell me that,” Adora said as she sat down. There was a moment of silence before Capella spoke up.

“Is she like you remember?”

Adora just sighed as she said, “Yeah, but I don’t think I am anymore.”

***

“Mara, you’re just like you always were,” Adora said with a laugh as Catra grinned and Snowball rolled her eyes.

“She certainly is not,” Snowball said as she picked up one of the dice on a table and made a roll. She cursed as Catra said something to her in Polar Magicat.

“Yes, I know it’s over nine,” Snowball said as her tail flicked in annoyance as Adora reached out and raked in the small colored glass stones they were using as chips. “She is manipulating this somehow.”

“Nope,” Adora said. “Just luck of the throw.”

“I’ll throw you and see how lucky you are,” Snowball muttered as she stood up from the table and stretched. Adora, who was used to Catra and her small form, was always a bit intimidated by a full size Magicat who hadn’t had their growth stunted by Horde food, especially in the confined space of her and Catra’s home. She wasn’t afraid though as she’d found out over the last month that was just how Snowball was around just about anyone.

“You’re in a humor tonight,” Catra said.

“It’s late,” Snowball said and then turned her back and headed for bed.

The first time she’d done that, Adora had been surprised, thinking she’d said or done something wrong but that was the other thing she’d found out over the month, that Snowball didn’t announce simple things like that. At first Adora had wondered if it had been a Polar Magicat thing but Catra had told her no, that was just Snowball.

“Good night!” Adora had called out to be rewarded with a little ear twitch that signified Snowball had heard followed by a very brief head nod to the side indicating she wished her the same.

“Now what?” Catra said. “I know a dice game for two called Shut the Box if you want to play.”

Adora stretched as she said, “I’m alright. I think I’m going to call it a night as well. I’ve got to fly out tomorrow and I want to leave as early as I can.”

Catra nodded as Adora stood up and then reached out and took her hand. Adora stopped and looked down at her as Catra hesitated before saying, “Listen, I… I know… things have been weird…”

Adora sat back down as she took Catra’s hand in her own as she said, “Hey, what do you want to say?”

***

Catra’s laugh rang through the dining room at Glimmer and Bow’s home as Adora blushed hard. Daniel grinned as he looked at Adora as Bow shook his head with amusement at Daniel’s story as Bow said, “Did you really do that?”

“I didn’t know!” Adora said. “I thought it made sense to get the pot nice and hot and it’d boil water faster when you put it in! I didn’t think it’d crack!”

Glimmer came back from the front door holding some delivery Chinese food as she sat it in the middle of the table.

"What'd I miss?"

"Nothing," Adora said.

"Is it an Adora is Embarrassed story!?" Glimmer said. "You'll have to tell me later, Daniel."

As Catra started frisbeeing paper plates along the top of the table at people, Bow asked Daniel, "So, are you getting settled in at the new place?"

Daniel nodded as he helped unpack the food.

"It's been an experience. I've never lived on my own before so it's kind of weird, especially at night."

"You haven't said anything about that," Adora said. "What's wrong?"

"Nothing's wrong," Daniel said. "It's just, I don't know, it's weird. It's really quiet and I kind of spook myself sometimes but it's nothing horrible."

“I did that a couple of times back at my parent’s place,” Glimmer said.

“Well, yeah, I wonder why,” Catra said with a snort as she pulled some fried rice over to herself. “It’s a house that looks like something from a horror movie in the middle of nowhere.”

“First off, it is in much better shape than something from a horror movie,” Glimmer said. “Second, it had nothing to do with that look anyway.”

“And everything to do with Aunt Casta telling you stories about spirits out in the woods?” Bow said.

Glimmer rolled her eyes but didn’t say anything as Catra laughed again. The dinner went well and after Bow shooed Adora away from the table, she drifted out to the back patio where Catra was in the process of starting the iron fire pit she’d made for Bow and Glimmer.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra said as Adora leaned against the railing and watched as the flames spread through the newspaper and to the little twigs on top of it.

“I don’t think I’ve said thank you for… well, being cool with all of this,” Adora said.

Catra shrugged as she watched the flames for a moment before standing up.

"You haven't once tried to preach to me so that's a bonus."

Adora nodded as she said, "So we talked a while back and since the divorce was finalized today…"

Catra crossed her arms as she said, "I believe I said that we would see."

"You did, you did," Adora said, shaking her head. "I'm sorry, I shouldn't have brought it up."

"No, you're not scuttling backwards," Catra said. "What are you trying to ask?"

***

"You're not in love with her anymore, are you?" Capella asked softly.

Adora looked at her daughter in surprise before standing up and turning to look at some mural on the wall. The stark angles of the Bright Moon Castle style seemed to grate against her as she looked at it and tried to remember what it was supposed to represent for a moment before she spoke.

"I do love her but, you know, not like I did. I don't know how…," Adora said and then trailed off, not sure how to explain.

Capella came over and stood next to Adora and stared at the mural with her.

"She knows," Capella said.

Adora looked at Capella in surprise.

"How?"

"She's not an idiot," Capella said, not looking at her mother. "You're decades older than her. She hasn't really aged."

Adora sighed as she said, "I'm not the same person but she is and that's the problem."

Capella looked at Adora finally and saw the tears in her mother's eyes as she reached forward and hugged her.

***

Catra looked away from Adora as she muttered something.

"Couldn't hear you there," Adora said.

"Stay," Catra said, finally looking at her. "Tonight. I want you to stay tonight."

Adora didn't move for a moment. After their kiss together there had been others but that had been all. Adora hadn't stayed over, not wanting to irritate Snowball as much as just trying to keep it slow, and Catra hadn't even come to the little room Adora had been renting. She could think of a thousand reasons not to stay. While they'd talked about it, Adora was still mad about what had happened back when they'd broken up. She was still mad about how the relationship had gone even before that. She was just mad about the whole thing.

But Catra was standing there, asking, and Adora found she couldn't hang on to that anger as she reached for Catra's hand.

***

“I don’t know what I’m trying to ask,” Adora said. “I… I really don’t.”

“You know we can’t go back to what we had, right?” Catra said.

“I know,” Adora said and felt the ache in her chest she always did when she thought of how much she’d screwed up. “I mean, at least Mom isn’t going to screw it up this time.”

“You screwed it up, don’t blame her,” Catra said and then her face softened a little. “She still not talking to you over the divorce?”

Adora nodded as she said, “Pretty much.”

The two stood on the porch looking away from each other and Adora began to really hope that someone would come outside soon and they could just ignore that this whole thing hadn’t happened. Then she happened to see through one of the back windows to where Daniel and Bow were peeking around a curtain as Daniel caught her eye and gave her a smile and a thumbs up. Adora laughed suddenly and Catra looked at her.

“What are you laughing about?” Catra said.

Adora felt a brief moment like she had on the dock at Camp Bright Moon so many years before and heard herself saying, "Fuck it" just like she had years before.

"What?" Catra said, her face a study in confusion as Adora stepped forward.

"Catra, I fucked up," Adora said. "I regret what happened and it's stupid of me to ask this of you but I want a relationship. I don't want a friendship, I want to be with you. I want to see what we can make of this because I'm so fucking tired of wondering what might have been."

"I don't know…," Catra said and trailed off.

"I understand," Adora said. "I just…"

"I get it," Catra said. "I have every reason to tell you to get bent but… like you said, fuck it."

And Catra reached out her hand.

***

“What’re you talking about?” Catra said and Adora turned around suddenly, breaking the hug. Capella turned as well as she responded.

“You, actually.”

“I am pretty great,” Catra said as she stretched and sat down on the arm of a couch.

“You look like crap though,” Capella said.

“Cappe!” Adora said.

Catra gave a little hand wave at Adora as she said, “It’s fine. I didn’t sleep well.”

“The dreams again?” Capella said.

Catra nodded as Adora said, “What dreams?”

Catra looked at her and then Capella before sighing.

“I’m having weird dreams,” Catra said. “About Angella, about those versions of us I said I saw, about lots of stuff but it’s not awful, just taking some getting used to.”

Adora looked at the ground at the name of Angella. Glimmer had tried to rescue her, only to find out that she couldn’t. Whatever she’d done deep beneath the ground, she’d come back and said that not only was Angella watching over Etheria, she was holding it steady in the universe. Then she’d not been seen by anyone, including her spouses, for a day. When she’d come back, she’d been very quiet and subdued and hadn’t talked much since.

“Listen, I just… I had something to say,” Adora said as he looked down. “Now I don’t know how to say it.”

“It’s gone,” Catra said. “What we had.”

Adora felt fresh pain as she nodded and looked up to see Catra crying as well.

“I still love you,” Adora said. “But… it’s not…”

“You’re not you,” Catra said softly. “You’re… I don’t know what.”

“I know,” Adora said as Capella stepped over to Catra and hugged her tight. Adora was surprised to see Catra not flinch away from someone but instead hug her right back.

“I wish it could have been but…,” Adora started to say but just couldn’t finish it. “I’ll do what I can.”

Catra was nodding furiously, unable to speak, as Capella looked back at her mom as she said, “She’s not going to go through this alone. I’m going to be there for her. So’s Gress and Cowrie and P-Pear and everyone else.”

Adora sat down on the edge of a table as she thought of the other princesses that were Capella’s friends and thought of what it would be like for Catra to hang out with them and live with them and grow old with them. Those princesses hadn’t known war or the hardship of living in something like the Horde and they’d had loving parents and opportunities. They’d be able to fold Catra in amongst them and help her and comfort her and allow her to figure out who she was going to be. She’d have friends and maybe even one day she’d find someone to love again as a romantic partner. Adora could see it layed out in front of her, plain as day. It’d be good for Catra. For Adora, it hurt almost as much as when she lost her the first time because she knew she was going to lose her again.

She was an adult now though. The hard way, she knew, was often the right way. It didn’t make it any easier.

And in the Northern reach, Adora took Catra’s hand, warm and comforting as she knew she’d stay that night and said, “I love you.”

"I love you too," Catra said, the anger of their old relationship being packed away in both their minds to try again.

On the porch, Adora took Catra's hand. "I love you," Adora said and she knew she did even as she knew she didn't fully understand what it meant but she was ready to find out, even if she regretted it because regret was her companion and one she knew how to deal with now.

"I love you too," Catra said, shaking her head as if she couldn't believe that such a thing was coming out of her mouth but still with a little smirk on her face as she said it, because she figured it'd be worth a try.

And in the room in Bright Moon, Adora said, "I love you. I'll always be there for you, just like I would for Cappe."

"I love you too," Catra said and in both of their voices was the letting go, like a long sigh that wasn't going to end anytime soon but would open the way to how things would be, the new normal, that could be understood.

And that's how it was for all of them, for the past is only pictures on paper and in the mind and nothing is written for the future because nothing can be fully known of what it may bring except that anger, sorrow, and regret are temporary things of their own that can be overcome, with time and love.

Chapter End Notes

I did not intend for this to take this long but here we are, at the end. I don't have much to say except thank you for your patience and thank you for reading. I really appreciate it.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!